

Xi Jinping's Perceptions and the Belt and Road Initiative

Unofficial English translation of a master's thesis in International
Relations

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This thesis was originally written and defended in Persian (Farsi) and was subsequently translated into English by the author for submission as a writing sample. AI-assisted tools were used at various stages of the research and translation process, including: (a) summarizing academic articles for preliminary literature review and orientation; (b) assisting in the drafting, debugging, and refinement of code in R; (c) supporting data cleaning and preprocessing in spreadsheet environments; and (d) providing linguistic assistance during the translation of the thesis from Persian into English.

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Abstract

The Belt and Road Initiative is China's most ambitious infrastructure project under Xi Jinping. From its inception, the initiative has had a dual character: on the one hand, it follows China's traditional model of cooperation through bilateral agreements; on the other, like China's broader rise, it carries wider implications for the region and the world. This study examines why the People's Republic of China launched the Belt and Road Initiative by emphasizing the role of leadership perceptions in the process of policy formation. Drawing on cognitive mapping theory, it reconstructs Xi Jinping's cognitive system through qualitative content analysis of selected speeches and interviews. The findings indicate that Xi Jinping's cognitive framework integrates international order, development, and political legitimacy into a coherent interpretive schema. This schema operates as a filtering mechanism that structures the prioritization of policy goals, guides the selection of policy instruments, and ultimately conditions leadership responses to both structural and state-level stimuli. From this perspective, in Xi Jinping's perceptions, the Belt and Road Initiative functions as a strategic instrument that legitimizes China's outward investment by embedding the continuity of domestic development within a broader international program, thereby securing the political and public support necessary for its implementation. Simultaneously, by linking China's development and national interests with those of participating partner countries, the initiative frames China's rise as beneficial to the international order and seeks to mitigate external threat perceptions associated with China's rapid and unprecedented growth.

Keywords: Belt and Road Initiative; Xi Jinping; leadership perceptions; cognitive mapping; China's foreign policy

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Problem Statement

The Belt and Road Initiative (BRI),¹ first proposed by Xi Jinping in 2013, is widely regarded as the most ambitious foreign policy project undertaken by China in the contemporary era. The initiative gradually evolved into the backbone of China's foreign policy and Xi Jinping's overarching grand strategy. This evolution culminated in 2017, when the initiative was incorporated into the Constitution of the Communist Party of China as one of its fundamental guiding principles (International Department of the Central Committee of the CPC, 2018).

The primary objective of the initiative is the establishment of an extensive network of transportation and energy infrastructure linking China to three continents—Asia, Africa, and Europe (McBride et al., 2023). At the official level, the initiative is designed to strengthen regional economic connectivity, facilitate trade, enhance financial integration, and promote people-to-people exchanges through the construction of railways, ports, highways, and pipelines (MERICS, 2018).

Although the Belt and Road Initiative has now evolved into a comprehensive and multi-dimensional framework for China's foreign policy and global development strategy, no clearly defined or binding institutional structure for it has been established within the legal system of the People's Republic of China. While the initiative was incorporated as a strategic objective into the Constitution of the Communist Party of China at the 19th Party Congress in 2017 (International Department of the Central Committee of the CPC, 2018), the official Constitution of China provides no precise legal or executive definition of the initiative, and its formal status therefore remains ambiguous.

At the international level as well, the Belt and Road Initiative lacks a coherent institutional structure and binding multilateral mechanisms. Unlike comparable initiatives

¹ 一带一路 (*Yīdài Yīlù*)

proposed by Western countries—such as the “Partnership for Global Infrastructure Investment,” which the United States and the Group of Seven put forward in 2022 in response to the Belt and Road Initiative and which is based on a transparent and binding structure grounded in clearly defined governance standards and formal institutional frameworks (Simonov, 2025, p. 3)—the Belt and Road Initiative lacks a centralized international mechanism and is implemented largely through non-binding bilateral memoranda of understanding. These arrangements are typically of medium-term duration and provide only limited legal guarantees (H. Wang, 2021, p. 5).

The differences between the Belt and Road Initiative and similar schemes, together with the initiative’s operational ambiguities, have posed challenges for scholarly assessments of its nature, rationale, and mode of operation. Ambiguity surrounding its scope and implementation guidelines within China, China’s avoidance of establishing international institutions subject to multilateral oversight for the initiative, and the non-disclosure of the texts of the bilateral agreements that constitute it are among the main obstacles to research on the initiative.

Nevertheless, assuming that the foundation of statesmen’s thought and action is interests defined in terms of power, any policy or initiative can serve as a window through which to understand the motivations and strategic calculations of decision-makers. This assumption allows analysts, even without access to government decision-making meetings, to infer states’ objectives or motivations behind particular decisions and actions; in other words, by placing themselves in the position of the decision-maker and taking empirical realities into account, they speculate about the motivations underlying a specific decision (Morgenthau & Thompson, 1985, p. 5).

Against this backdrop, ten years after the launch of the Belt and Road Initiative, the manner in which it has been implemented calls into question the initial speculations about the reasons behind the adoption of such a decision; in other words, China’s behavior within the framework of the initiative does not align with the early predictions and expectations regarding how such an initiative would be carried out. When scholars, in Morgenthau’s words, place themselves in the position of the Chinese decision-maker, they find that relying on the assumptions of mainstream theories does not yield a coherent understanding of China’s decision-making logic with respect to this initiative (a detailed critical assessment of the Belt and Road Initiative is provided in Appendix A). As will be shown in detail in the literature review section, existing efforts to explain the Belt and Road Initiative through the lens of mainstream theories in international relations have produced a wide range of analyses; however, despite their solid scholarly coverage, these works still fall short—when the mode of implementation over the past decade is taken into account—of

offering a complete and comprehensive explanation of why the initiative was launched in the first place.

A large part of this challenge stems from the fact that the Belt and Road Initiative can be conceptualized across multiple dimensions and levels. The initiative cannot be neatly categorized as either bilateral or multilateral. The network of corridors and connectivity infrastructures under this project encompasses numerous countries, yet the contracts governing their construction are bilateral. Moreover, the profit-oriented nature of the projects complicates classifying the initiative as a purely strategic scheme, since in some cases efforts to maximize economic returns have undermined the potential strategic interests that might otherwise be attributed to them. At the same time, the geopolitical significance of infrastructure projects is too substantial for the initiative to be treated merely as an ordinary commercial undertaking. Such tensions raise a fundamental question: why did China choose to launch such an initiative in this particular form in the first place?

1.2 Review of the Literature

The literature analyzing the motivations and driving forces behind the Belt and Road Initiative can be classified into multiple categories depending on the criteria employed. Given this study's focus on the reasons underlying the decision, the literature is classified by level of analysis into international-system, state, and leader levels. A significant portion of the literature examines the initiative at the international-system level within various theoretical frameworks. At this level, studies analyze the Belt and Road Initiative in geopolitical and strategic, institutional, and normative terms, often portraying it as an effort to reshape the international order. At the state level, research emphasizes China's domestic economic and political requirements, highlighting the development² of China's inland regions—particularly its western regions—the export of excess production capacity,³ and the maintenance of economic growth as the initiative's primary drivers. The final category, which contains the fewest studies, centers on Xi Jinping personally and interprets the Belt and Road Initiative as an attempt by Xi to construct a lasting historical legacy.

1.2.1 The Belt and Road Initiative and the Global Order

System-level analyses of the Belt and Road Initiative can be divided into three broad groups. Some scholars focus primarily on geopolitical and strategic motivations, identify-

²In Chinese strategic culture, “development” primarily denotes economic development and, at times, socioeconomic development.

³Also translated as “industrial overcapacity,” this economic concept describes a situation in which productive capacity—including factories, machinery, labor, and infrastructure—can produce more than the market is able to absorb.

ing the initiative as a response to U.S. dominance and as an effort to reshape global geopolitics in ways that advance China's interests and security. A second group views the Belt and Road Initiative as part of China's broader attempt at institution-building and peaceful influence within the global order. A third group examines the normative dimensions of the initiative, interpreting it as an effort to transform prevailing international norms.

1.2.1.1 Geopolitical Dimensions of the Belt and Road Initiative

Studies emphasizing geopolitical and strategic motivations argue that the Belt and Road Initiative functions as a geopolitical instrument designed to expand China's strategic influence across Eurasia. From this perspective, the initiative can be understood as an attempt to resolve the geopolitical dilemmas created by China's "hybrid" strategic orientation: China is simultaneously a continental and a maritime power. The initiative is also viewed as a strategic response to the opportunities and challenges created by the United States' "pivot," or "rebalance," toward the Asia-Pacific region since 2011 (Clarke, 2018, p. 85). By extending its economic reach westward and southward, China is expected to weaken U.S. influence in these regions and neutralize Washington's containment strategies (Zhou & Esteban, 2018, p. 6). From this perspective—often described as soft balancing—the Belt and Road Initiative enables China to establish a sphere of influence in Eurasia and to constrain Western leverage. Some analysts even predict that this process will result in the emergence of two distinct spheres of influence: a China-dominated Eurasian region and a U.S.-led maritime domain (Clarke, 2018, p. 85).

China's strategic calculations within the Belt and Road Initiative also include tangible security considerations. One of the most significant factors is the so-called Malacca Dilemma, referring to China's vulnerability to maritime blockade at the Strait of Malacca. The creation of overland routes and port investments under the initiative allows China to identify alternatives to U.S.-controlled maritime trade routes and to mitigate this strategic vulnerability (Lindley, 2022). Such infrastructure can facilitate China's security presence in key regions and strengthen its diplomatic influence. In this regard, Movaqqe'i and Moradi Haghighi interpret the initiative as part of China's response to the U.S. "pivot to Asia" and as a strategy for redirecting China's geopolitical focus westward, toward Eurasia, in order to reduce direct confrontation with U.S. maritime dominance. Through the establishment of land-based corridors in Central Asia, South Asia, and the Middle East, the Belt and Road Initiative reduces China's dependence on vulnerable Asia-Pacific maritime routes that have long been monitored by Western naval forces. From their perspective, the initiative represents a peaceful strategy for China to attain a future hegemonic position by creating intercontinental economic corridors that enable a transformation of the existing order, shift the geopolitical center of gravity toward Eurasia, and diminish the

maritime significance of Britain and the United States (Movasaghi & Moradi Haghighi, 1401, p. 573).

Some scholars interpret the Belt and Road Initiative as an attempt by China to establish a parallel order alongside the existing global system. For instance, Jasmin et al. conclude that the initiative enables Beijing to employ political leverage to promote a China-centered international order and even to challenge the U.S.-led global order by creating an alternative centered on China (Jasmin et al., 2025, p. 9). Similarly, Dehshiar and Pourbagher argue that the initiative constitutes Beijing's effort to expand its geostrategic influence in opposition to the U.S.-led order, noting that infrastructure competition between the two powers extends beyond economics into political, security, ideological, and technological domains (Daheshiar & Pourbagher, 1402, p. 47). In this framework, China uses economic tools—such as loans and infrastructure contracts—to acquire strategic influence and create dependencies, consistent with the logic of economic diplomacy (Jasmin et al., 2025, p. 3). From a realist perspective, the Belt and Road Initiative can thus be understood as a power-maximizing strategy, whereby investments in ports, highways, and digital infrastructure enable China to secure strategic footholds and indirectly expand its logistical and military reach—for example, through ports with potential dual-use civilian–military functions (Haenle, 2017; Jasmin et al., 2025). Consequently, Western policymakers express concern that ostensibly commercial Belt and Road projects may facilitate maritime access or intelligence gathering for China, with the establishment of a Chinese military base in Djibouti following infrastructure investments in East Africa serving as a prominent example (Bhattacharya et al., 2019).

Other scholars characterize the Belt and Road Initiative as a form of a modern Marshall Plan, through which China strengthens its geopolitical allies by investing in infrastructure (Lindley, 2022). Qasemi and Eftekhari-Nia similarly argue that regionalism has long been an imperative of states' foreign policies and analyze cooperation among China, Iran, and Russia through the lens of nested regionalism, suggesting that these powers seek to counter the Western-dominated order by constructing overlapping regional networks (Ghasemi & Eftekharinia, 1403, p. 98). Zhou and Esteban likewise describe the Belt and Road Initiative as a decisive strategic maneuver that enables China to consolidate its status as a great power and enhance its security, allowing Beijing to move from a rule-taker to a rule-maker within the international system (Zhou & Esteban, 2018, p. 14).

Nadège Rolland argues that the Belt and Road Initiative constitutes a grand strategy aimed at advancing China's aspiration to become the dominant power in Eurasia and an unparalleled global power, aligned with Beijing's vision of a China-centered regional order and Xi Jinping's broader narrative of national rejuvenation (Rolland, 2017, pp. 119–120). From this perspective, the initiative's extensive network of infrastructure and economic

corridors is not merely economic in nature, but is deliberately designed to position China at the core of a new Eurasian geopolitical system.

Regional security and stability in China's periphery are also regarded as prerequisites for this China-centered regional order. The overland routes of the Silk Road Economic Belt traverse Central and South Asia—regions whose stability is of vital importance to Beijing. Scholars emphasize that maintaining stability in Xinjiang and securing energy supply lines from Central Asia have long been among China's top priorities (A. He, 2019, p. 3). By promoting economic development and connectivity in Central and South Asia, the Belt and Road Initiative aligns with China's security objective of cultivating a stable surrounding environment. Projects such as the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor are thus viewed not only as economic ventures but also as strategic buffers that tie Pakistan's stability to Chinese investment and create alternative trade routes to the Indian Ocean that bypass the vulnerable Strait of Malacca (Lindley, 2022).

In sum, geopolitical analyses of the Belt and Road Initiative portray it as an effort to counter U.S. influence, enhance China's security by breaking U.S. maritime encirclement, strengthen strategically aligned states, and cultivate a stable periphery. Nevertheless, regional responses—particularly from India—have been largely negative. The United States has likewise interpreted the initiative and associated financial institutions, such as the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, as challenges, responding by tightening pressure on Beijing and advancing alternative initiatives aimed at undermining the strategic significance of China's project (Daheshiar & Pourbagher, 1402, p. 48). In other words, these developments have not necessarily placed China in a more advantageous position, and Beijing's gains from the initiative remain limited. While the strategic and geopolitical importance of the Belt and Road Initiative is undeniable, it is difficult to explain the largest infrastructure project in human history solely on the basis of these considerations.

1.2.1.2 Transition without War

Another group of scholars does not view China's efforts to create financial and political institutions as inherently confrontational. This body of work emphasizes the institution-building dimension of the Belt and Road Initiative and related programs, interpreting them as attempts to transform the global order without resorting to conflict. Mousavi Shafaei argues that the introduction of the Belt and Road Initiative in 2013 coincided with a period in which China felt more secure in consolidating its regional position without provoking direct confrontation (Mousavi Shafaei, 1394). In this context, Xi's government advanced the doctrine of the "Three Nos": non-interference in the internal affairs of other countries, non-expansion of spheres of influence, and non-pursuit of hegemony. Through this approach, Xi sought to expand China's global influence while simultane-

ously avoiding the creation of anxiety among neighboring states (Mousavi Shafaei, 1394, pp. 204–205). From this perspective, the Belt and Road Initiative is also understood as a tool for expanding China's geopolitical influence through infrastructure development and investment, thereby drawing other countries into China's economic orbit. Nevertheless, Mousavi Shafaei—like other scholars—notes that Xi's initiatives, ranging from the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank to the growing role of the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, collectively complement the Belt and Road Initiative in constructing a China-centered regional order.

Shariatinia and Masoudi extend the discussion beyond the regional level, arguing that China participates simultaneously in three types of international order—hegemonic, balance-of-power, and institutionalized. While benefiting from existing institutions such as the World Trade Organization, China is also gradually reforming and reshaping the international order through the creation of new institutions, including the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (Shariatinia & Masoudi, 1398, p. 9).

Dashtgerd and Moradi Afrapoli similarly argue that China's economic strategies—such as the “One Belt, One Road”⁴ initiative, “Made in China 2025,” and the yuan-denominated Chinese crude oil futures market—serve purposes that extend beyond economics, contributing to the gradual transfer of power from the United States to China (Dashtgerd & Moradi Afrapoli, 1400, p. 8). According to this analysis, China employs economic and financial instruments as substitutes for traditional tools of hard power and strengthens its position as a potential hegemon by leveraging other countries' economic dependence. Masoumeh Heidari likewise maintains that China's strategy rests on three pillars: a multipolar system, a global market economy, and a world of modern, rational, and secular civilizations (Heidari, 1400, p. 87). By focusing on these pillars, Beijing seeks to acquire regional and international standing while maintaining the capacity to cooperate with major powers.

In this regard, Noroozi and Akbari argue that the objective of initiatives such as the Belt and Road Initiative, the Global Development Initiative, and the Global Security Initiative is to bring a large number of countries into the axis of China's foreign policy (Noroozi & Akbari, 2024, p. 112). They contend that China employs network diplomacy as a means of strengthening its position in the global economy. A prominent example of this approach is China's extensive cooperation with the United Arab Emirates within the framework of the Belt and Road Initiative, which has enabled Beijing to establish a network of economic and financial connections in the Persian Gulf. Unlike hierarchical models of power, this form of diplomacy is based on economic interaction and interdependence, allowing cooperation even with countries that are traditionally considered U.S. allies (Noroozi & Akbari, 2024, pp. 114–115).

⁴An alternative designation used for the Belt and Road Initiative.

Zhang and James further develop this argument, maintaining that in order to support and complement the infrastructure projects of the Belt and Road Initiative, China has actively pursued the creation of new institutions while also leveraging existing ones to shape a more China-centered order. For instance, Beijing established the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank and the Silk Road Fund as financial arms to mobilize resources for Belt and Road projects (E. Zhang & James, 2023, p. 37). In their view, forums such as the official Belt and Road Forum and mechanisms like the Shanghai Cooperation Organization demonstrate China's effort to "guide the reform of the global governance system" in line with its own interests and conditions (E. Zhang & James, 2023, p. 36).

Nevertheless, although scholars such as Zhang and James identify institutions like the Shanghai Cooperation Organization and the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank as examples of China-led institutions, the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank has played only a limited role in coordination and norm creation, while the Shanghai Cooperation Organization remains largely confined to Central Asia and lacks the breadth of influence necessary to sustain such claims.

Despite these limitations, Wang argues that the Belt and Road Initiative represents a distinctive model of multilateral cooperation characterized by a hub-and-spoke structure, in which China occupies the central position (H. Wang, 2019). Rather than establishing a formal treaty-based organization, China has pursued the initiative through bilateral agreements and flexible forums. According to Wang, China's approach to the Belt and Road Initiative is less rooted in formal institution-building and treaty foundations, and instead emphasizes adaptability and flexibility over binding rules (H. Wang, 2019, p. 8). This "middle-of-the-road" strategy enables Beijing to cooperate simultaneously with multiple partners without the conventional constraints of a formal multilateral institution (H. Wang, 2019, p. 25). Although Wang suggests that China may move toward clearer rules over time, in practice this flexible approach has thus far transformed the initiative into a network of bilateral partnerships centered on China. In this sense, the Belt and Road Initiative can be understood as a new form of regional multilateralism—a hub-and-spoke network in which China, as the core, facilitates connections with numerous countries. This flexible, network-based multilateralism stands in contrast to Western institution-centered models and has been described as a potential Chinese alternative to the deep, rule-based agreements of developed countries (H. Wang, 2019, p. 25).

Overall, this strand of the literature views the Belt and Road Initiative as an effort at institution-building. In other words, beyond its geopolitical dimensions, the initiative is engaged in redefining global institutions. Consequently, despite intensified U.S. pressure, Beijing continues to benefit from pursuing this agenda, as it may ultimately succeed in establishing its own independent institutions and reducing its exposure to U.S.-dominated

institutional constraints. However, such institutions will be effective only if they are capable of attracting other countries. Over time, an increasing number of states have become hesitant to join the Belt and Road Initiative, while Beijing has shown little inclination to fully withdraw from existing institutions. Moreover, China has not created a dedicated international institution specifically for the Belt and Road Initiative. Participating countries are involved solely through bilateral memoranda with China, with no additional institutional linkages among them. Although scholars such as Wang have attempted to articulate a coherent logic for the initiative, it appears that among competing interpretations, Wang's framework offers one of the most compelling perspectives—particularly insofar as it resonates with Chinese theoretical approaches such as relationality theory associated with Qin Yaqing.⁵ Nevertheless, these explanations remain largely speculative and lack definitive empirical confirmation, either in official statements by Beijing and participating countries or in observable practice. More than a decade after the initiative's launch (and roughly five years after Wang's article), the empirical trajectory of the Belt and Road Initiative has not evolved in the direction Wang anticipated.

1.2.1.3 Ideological Dimensions of the Belt and Road Initiative

Another explanation for China's distinctive institutional approach emphasizes its normative dimension. Garlick and Qin argue that China's approach to the global order through the Belt and Road Initiative is not purely institutional, but also normative in character. Chinese leaders consistently frame the initiative through concepts such as “win–win cooperation,” “mutual benefit,” and “public goods” for partner countries. This discourse is interpreted as part of China's effort to offer a normative alternative to Western leadership. Slogans such as “a community with a shared future for mankind” and “true multilateralism” are among the concepts Beijing employs to project a more inclusive and equitable order aligned with the cooperative ethos of the Belt and Road Initiative (Garlick & Qin, 2024, p. 987).

A key point is that the diffusion of China's preferred norms relies less on explicit rule-making and more on practical emulation and intergovernmental relations. Garlick and Qin note that Beijing, through initiatives such as the Belt and Road Initiative, places greater emphasis on introducing practices rather than imposing rules. This practice-based diplomacy—often summarized as a “do-as-I-do” approach—allows China to showcase its development model, characterized by large-scale infrastructure construction, economic connectivity, and partnerships grounded in respect for national sovereignty (Garlick & Qin, 2024, p. 993). Garlick and Qin emphasize that this relationship-based model of norm diffusion differs fundamentally from the European Union's rule-based approach. Such a

⁵ 秦亚青 (*Qin Yāqīng*)

model enables China to present itself as a benevolent leader in the Global South, offering win–win development opportunities while simultaneously forging economic and political ties that serve its strategic interests (Garlick & Qin, 2024, pp. 992–993).

Some scholars describe the Belt and Road Initiative as a form of public good for developing countries (Azizi & Haji-Yousefi, 1399, p. 331). They also emphasize the intertwining of economics and politics in Xi Jinping’s approach. For example, Movagge‘i and Moradi Haghighi argue that Xi Jinping’s Belt and Road Initiative embodies a political–security agenda accompanied by economic interests: China invests and trades, but simultaneously acquires political leverage and strategic advantages through these economic ties (Movasaghi & Moradi Haghighi, 1401, p. 557).

Beijing’s official narrative of the Belt and Road Initiative aligns with this interpretation. Xi Jinping has described the initiative as the “project of the century,” framing it in terms of win–win cooperation and inclusive globalization. In contrast to purely geopolitical interpretations, China’s official discourse presents the initiative as a tool for “building a community with a shared future for mankind,” signaling Beijing’s ambition to reshape international norms in ways favorable to China (Oliveira et al., 2020, p. 1). Scholars link this narrative to the concept of the Chinese Dream and national rejuvenation—the idea that the Belt and Road Initiative will restore China’s status as a great power after the so-called “Century of Humiliation” (Lindley, 2022). In this sense, Xi has presented the initiative as a form of top-level design serving China’s geostrategic vision (S. Zhao, 2020, p. 4).

Beyond economics, China seeks to offer normative alternatives to Western models. Zhou and Esteban view the Belt and Road Initiative as an instrument for transforming China into a “normative power,” through which Beijing seeks to redefine global governance in accordance with its own values and interests (Zhou & Esteban, 2018, p. 2). This interpretation aligns with perspectives that portray the Belt and Road Initiative as an effort to legitimize China’s rise. As Oliveira et al. argue, Beijing places strong emphasis on controlling the narrative surrounding the initiative, presenting it not as an “instrument of geopolitical domination or profit-seeking,” but rather as a “win–win project for shared development” (Oliveira et al., 2020, p. 1).

Overall, the existing literature suggests a degree of consensus that through the Belt and Road Initiative, Beijing seeks to present itself as a benevolent leader of a more inclusive global order. Nevertheless, some critics regard this interpretation as overly optimistic, arguing that the initiative’s underlying objective is to strengthen China’s power and position within the international system.

1.2.2 Domestic Needs as a Driver of the Belt and Road Initiative

Another explanation advanced for the Belt and Road Initiative emphasizes China's domestic economic imperatives. The initiative was introduced at a time when China's economy was experiencing slowing growth and mounting problems of industrial overcapacity. In practice, Beijing has viewed the Belt and Road Initiative as a mechanism for utilizing China's vast construction and investment capacity. By financing overseas projects such as roads, railways, ports, and power plants, China can mobilize its state-owned enterprises and channel its accumulated capital and excess industrial capacity into foreign markets (Oliveira et al., 2020, p. 1). This, in turn, contributes to sustaining China's gross domestic product growth. Clarke likewise emphasizes that ensuring continued economic growth—particularly for less developed regions and state-owned enterprises—in order to stabilize the legitimacy of the Chinese Communist Party constitutes one of the principal motivations behind the Belt and Road Initiative (Clarke, 2018, p. 85).

The expansion of the Belt and Road Initiative is also linked to China's internal regional inequalities. The initiative aligns with long-term objectives aimed at developing China's western regions (such as Xinjiang) and poorer inland provinces by integrating them into international trade routes (A. He, 2019; Lindley, 2022, p. 225). By improving connectivity infrastructure and creating new markets for these regions, the Belt and Road Initiative serves Beijing's broader agenda of strengthening national integration and maintaining domestic stability. Ye Min characterizes the initiative as an instance of state-mobilized globalization,⁶ led by a coalition of actors including top political leaders, bureaucratic institutions,⁷ and economic enterprises (M. Ye, 2020). These multifaceted motivations help explain why the Belt and Road Initiative encompasses a wide range of projects that at times extend beyond its original design (M. Ye, 2021). If successful, the initiative could accelerate the internationalization of the renminbi and economically bind host countries more closely to China's market, thereby generating long-term strategic benefits for Beijing.

Ajili et al. argue that Xi Jinping's Belt and Road Initiative pursues broad economic objectives across multiple dimensions, including energy security, the expansion of export markets and investment opportunities, and the development of infrastructure aimed at reducing trade costs (Ajili et al., 2019, p. 82). By financing and constructing railways, ports, and highways across continents, China under Xi's leadership can connect its inland provinces to global markets and stimulate trade. Ajili and his co-authors interpret this strategy as both an economic necessity and a strategic deployment of China's financial power.

⁶A form of globalization driven and coordinated by the state.

⁷Referring to state administrative bodies and agencies.

Although the underdevelopment of China's central—and especially western—provinces due to limited access to ports is a structural reality, the development of these regions depends on effective trade linkages with external markets. From this perspective, however, the Belt and Road Initiative appears to have fallen short of Beijing's expectations. China's principal export markets remain the powerful consumer economies of Europe and the United States. Central Asian and Middle Eastern countries have yet to demonstrate purchasing power comparable to that of Western markets, nor have they achieved a favorable trade balance with China. Part of this limited success can be attributed to host governments' concerns regarding issues such as debt traps and one-sided contractual arrangements. Additional concerns stem from certain Chinese commercial practices—such as the reliance on Chinese labor and firms for project implementation—which have reduced the extent of local economic benefits. Nevertheless, some scholars maintain that the initiative's effects on the development of particular Chinese regions and industries cannot be determined with certainty and that this dimension of the Belt and Road Initiative cannot yet be assessed precisely (Sjöholm, 2023, p. 11).

Nevertheless, Ye Min's analysis of China's state-level motivations for the Belt and Road Initiative appears particularly compelling. He argues that, contrary to conventional interpretations, the initiative is not the product of a coherent external grand strategy, but rather a form of nationalist mobilization in response to domestic economic and bureaucratic crises. According to Ye, China faced export stagnation, industrial overcapacity, and loss-making state-owned enterprises in 2012 and 2013. In this context, Xi Jinping employed the ambitious yet deliberately vague slogans of the Belt and Road Initiative to mobilize the state apparatus and market actors, encouraging them to revive economic growth through investment and globalization. This political mobilization prompted ministries, state-owned enterprises, and local governments to reinterpret the initiative in line with their own interests and conditions, generating projects and special zones across the country (M. Ye, 2020, pp. 3–6).

Overall, the literature reviewed in this section suggests that explanations grounded in domestic factors and bureaucratic imperatives portray the Belt and Road Initiative primarily as a product of internal pressures within China's economy, including slowing growth, industrial overcapacity, export stagnation, and the need to generate new stimuli for state-owned enterprises and less developed regions. Most studies converge on the view that by expanding overseas infrastructure projects, Beijing seeks to externalize surplus productive capacity, accumulated capital, and construction expertise, while simultaneously strengthening the integration of inland regions into the global economy.

Alongside these economic considerations, analyses such as Ye Min's highlight the Belt and Road Initiative as the outcome of a bureaucratic–national mobilization in response to

domestic crises, during which various state institutions and state-owned enterprises have reinterpreted the initiative to serve their own interests. Central to Ye's argument is the relationship between Xi Jinping and the bureaucratic apparatus. As Ye observes, "an autocratic leader appears more powerful when subordinates endorse his policies, because in the absence of institutional indicators of power, only the support of subordinates can demonstrate the certainty of his authority" (M. Ye, 2020, p. 210). Although Ye Min's process-tracing approach portrays Xi as a charismatic authoritarian leader, it ultimately attributes the initiation of the initiative to the bureaucratic apparatus of China's organizations and institutions, presenting Xi primarily as its executor.

While Ye Min puts forward a persuasive argument, it appears that his analysis somewhat downplays the role of Xi Jinping and assigns greater weight to the bureaucracy. Studies of this kind remain incomplete without a careful examination of the individual level, focusing on the leader himself. The following section therefore turns to works that examine Xi Jinping in connection with the Belt and Road Initiative.

1.2.3 Xi Jinping's Initiative

Nearly all analysts agree that the Belt and Road Initiative is Xi Jinping's personal project. Zhao Suisheng characterizes it as "Xi Jinping's diplomacy," to which Xi has explicitly tied his political legacy (S. Zhao, 2020, p. 1). Todd Hall and Alan Krolikowski describe it as the "Xi Show,"⁸ arguing that the close association between the Belt and Road Initiative and Xi has endowed it with substantial political significance. This association has enabled the initiative to function as a form of domestic political propaganda across governmental and societal levels, thereby enhancing its mobilizational potential. As a result, diverse actors have rebranded existing projects under the Belt and Road label or proposed new initiatives in its name (Hall & Krolikowski, 2022, p. 6). Ye Min likewise refers to the initiative as President Xi's brainchild⁹ (M. Ye, 2020, p. 210). The incorporation of the Belt and Road Initiative into the Constitution of the Chinese Communist Party has further transformed it into a defining vision of China's future under Xi's leadership (Lindley, 2022). At the same time, the initiative's top-down and personalized character has generated challenges, as local officials—seeking to demonstrate loyalty—have labeled unrelated projects as part of the Belt and Road Initiative, contributing to fragmentation and incoherence in practice. Nevertheless, Xi's role in the initiative remains undeniable, as its success or failure is closely intertwined with the credibility of his leadership and the legitimacy of his developmental vision. Examining Xi Jinping's own perceptions of the initiative is therefore of central importance.

⁸A term emphasizing the personalistic and performative dimension of Xi Jinping's leadership.

⁹An expression highlighting the personal origin of the initiative in Xi Jinping's leadership.

Some studies have drawn on political psychology to understand Xi's cognitive framework. One such method is operational code analysis, which examines leaders' belief systems through their speeches. For example, Villa and Villar analyze the slogan of the "Chinese Dream of national rejuvenation" and show that Xi emphasizes active cooperation while avoiding direct confrontation (Villa & Villar, 2019). At the same time, he remains cautious toward external actors and seeks to avoid costly conflicts (Feng & He, 2017, p. 14). These findings align with arguments emphasizing the role of historical memory—particularly memories of foreign domination—in shaping Xi's worldview (Hart & Johnson, 2019). This perspective helps explain why Xi simultaneously asserts China's rights while exercising restraint.

Although methodologically rigorous studies of Xi's perceptions remain limited, discourse analyses suggest that concepts such as "a community with a shared future for mankind" reflect a vision of international order more compatible with China's governance model (Hart & Johnson, 2019). Overall, Xi Jinping appears to view China's rejuvenation, national security, and the expansion of global prosperity as interlinked objectives, with the Belt and Road Initiative representing the practical embodiment of the cognitive map guiding China's foreign policy.

Taken together, over the past decade the Belt and Road Initiative has been examined from multiple perspectives; yet at its core, it remains Xi Jinping's flagship project. The literature broadly agrees that Xi's motivations encompass a wide spectrum of factors: ideological ambitions to reshape the global order, geopolitical objectives to expand China's influence, economic imperatives to maintain domestic stability, and personal and political aspirations to secure his legacy. Despite this, no study has systematically analyzed Xi's perceptions while elucidating the causal relationships underlying them. In other words, the individual-level role of Xi Jinping in the Belt and Road Initiative constitutes a significant gap in the existing literature.

1.2.4 Conclusion

The existing literature on the Belt and Road Initiative offers a wide range of explanations for China's motivations in launching the project. A substantial portion of this scholarship—particularly at the systemic level—has sought to explain the strategic, geopolitical, and institutional rationales underlying the initiative. From this perspective, the Belt and Road Initiative is viewed as a tool for redefining China's position in the international order and countering U.S. dominance, representing an effort to construct a new order centered on Beijing. At this level of analysis, the initiative is primarily conceptualized as a geopolitical instrument aimed at expanding China's influence across Eurasia, securing energy supplies, and reducing dependence on Western-controlled maritime

routes. Concurrently, another strand of research emphasizes the initiative's institutional and normative dimensions, interpreting it as an attempt to build a form of networked multilateralism that places China at the center of a web of bilateral agreements and new financial institutions. Accordingly, the Belt and Road Initiative is understood not merely as an economic program, but as a tool for reconfiguring the global order and legitimizing China's emerging role within the international system.

Despite the internal coherence of these theoretical explanations, the implementation of the Belt and Road Initiative has not aligned with many of the initial expectations. Anticipated outcomes—such as the rapid expansion of an integrated Eurasian infrastructure network, the attraction of new allies, or the emergence of a China-centered order—have not materialized as envisioned. Many flagship projects have faced delays, suspension, or revision, and the image of a cohesive infrastructure network has given way to a fragmented array of uneven projects. This divergence between theoretical analysis and empirical reality suggests that while systemic-level studies have shed light on China's broad motivations and strategic objectives, they have been less successful in explaining how decisions are formulated and implemented in practice.

State-level analyses have attempted to address this gap from a different angle. These studies focus on domestic developmental imperatives and bureaucratic mechanisms, portraying the Belt and Road Initiative as a response to China's internal economic challenges, including industrial overcapacity, slowing export growth, and the need to develop the country's western regions. From this perspective, the initiative is not merely a foreign policy instrument, but rather an extension of China's domestic development logic on a global scale. It can be understood as an effort to externalize China's state-led development model, whereby state-owned enterprises and private firms seek to replicate domestic success in broader international markets. However, these studies also demonstrate that within China's multilayered and complex state structure, coordination among the central government, provincial authorities, and economic actors has been fraught with difficulty. Competing interests and bureaucratic rivalries have often resulted in uneven and contradictory implementation of the initiative.

Most state-level studies approach this relationship primarily through the lens of bureaucratic processes, focusing on how top-level directives are translated into policy execution, rather than on how leadership beliefs and perceptions shape the initiative's structure. In other words, it remains unclear whether the Belt and Road Initiative emerged from bottom-up decision-making dynamics within the bureaucracy, or whether China's multilayered bureaucracy gradually aligned itself with Xi Jinping's preferences as a result of his charismatic and ideological authority. These two pathways yield analytically distinct conclusions: in the former, the initiative reflects organizational logic and internal state

contradictions; in the latter, it represents the concentration of power and a shift in China's decision-making system toward the personalization of foreign policy.¹⁰ Existing scholarship has rarely addressed this two-way dialectic between leadership and bureaucracy.

In fact, the lack of individual-level research constitutes the most significant gap in the analytical chain of the Belt and Road Initiative literature. While systemic-level analyses clarify motivations and state-level studies explain implementation processes, the individual level has not adequately bridged the two. Without a precise understanding of Xi Jinping's perceptions, beliefs, and decision-making logic, it is impossible to determine how China's bureaucracy has aligned with—or resisted—the initiative. Examining this level can reveal whether the Chinese state has merely implemented the Belt and Road Initiative, or whether the initiative itself has functioned as a tool through which Xi has redefined his relationship with the state and reorganized China's decision-making system. From this perspective, focusing on the individual level not only fills a critical gap in the literature, but also enables a more precise causal understanding of the link between ideas, decisions, and implementation.

1.3 Research Questions and Hypotheses

The main research question of this study is simple yet fundamental:

Why did China launch the Belt and Road Initiative?

The central hypothesis of this research is formulated as follows:

Xi Jinping's perceptions of the relationship between development, order, and leadership led to the Belt and Road Initiative.

This research is based on the following assumptions:

1. The perceptions of key decision-makers play a decisive role in shaping foreign policy.
2. In China's foreign policy, considerations related to development and the preservation of legitimacy occupy a central position.
3. The specific manner in which these considerations are articulated in China's external relations depends on the perceptions of China's leader.

To answer the main research question, the following sub-questions must also be addressed:

¹⁰This idea occupies a substantial place in the scholarly literature on changes in China's foreign policy. Because that broader debate is not directly related to the Belt and Road Initiative, it is not reviewed in this study.

How does Xi Jinping conceptualize development within his cognitive framework, and what relationship does he establish between development, power, and legitimacy?

How does Xi Jinping conceptualize the linkage between authority, hierarchy, and cooperation in the process of constructing order and advancing development?

1.4 Theoretical Framework

This study adopts *cognitive mapping* as its theoretical framework. The theory was first developed by Robert Axelrod to improve decision-making processes (Axelrod, 1976). Axelrod drew upon five other theoretical traditions, including psychologies, causal inference, graph theory, evaluative assertion analysis, and decision theory (Young & Schafer, 1998, p. 75).

The core idea of cognitive mapping is that thought structures are reflected in policy discourse and texts and can be identified and simplified through causal relationships among concepts. By revealing the structure of policymakers' thinking and the linkages among their beliefs, this approach facilitates the analysis of decision-making processes (Moshirzadeh, 1396, p. 148). Constructing a cognitive map makes it possible to extract causal relationships (e.g., A leads to B) as well as normative–evaluative or utility relationships (e.g., B is desirable or beneficial), thereby revealing actors' reasoning from both causal and normative perspectives (Van Esch & Snellens, 2024, p. 434).

1.5 Research Methodology

This research, drawing on the assumptions of perceptual theories regarding the relationship between actors' beliefs and their statements (see Young & Schafer, 1998), will first employ content analysis. Given the impracticality of using quantitative computer-based software for texts in non-English languages, qualitative content analysis will be used. Through this approach, Xi Jinping's perceptions and beliefs about international relations and their impact on the adoption of the Belt and Road Initiative will be examined. Key nodes will be extracted from Xi Jinping's speeches, official documents, and strategic statements, manually coded, and analyzed through content analysis to identify the causal linkages among the core concepts in his discourse. This method makes it possible to identify patterns in Xi Jinping's strategic thinking on development, legitimacy, and international order, and to demonstrate which perceptions of which concepts led to the formation of the Belt and Road Initiative. Subsequently, process tracing will be employed to examine the role and influence of these perceptions in the launch of the Belt and Road Initiative. In this way, the perceptions derived from qualitative content analysis will be used as testable evidence

in the process tracing of the Belt and Road Initiative, allowing for the inference of a causal relationship between these perceptions and the initiative.

1.6 Significance and Rationale of the Study

Identifying the underlying logic and motivations of the Belt and Road Initiative is of considerable importance. Explaining this initiative can illuminate key dimensions of China's foreign policy and its position within the international order.

First, the Belt and Road Initiative is unprecedented in terms of both the scale of investment and the scope of implementation. Some scholars have compared it to the United States' Marshall Plan following World War II; however, numerous studies have demonstrated that the two projects differ fundamentally in nature and objectives. Accordingly, examining this unique approach—particularly given its vast economic and geopolitical dimensions—holds substantial scholarly value.

Another crucial aspect is Xi Jinping's role as the principal architect of the Belt and Road Initiative. He is the third leader of the People's Republic of China whose ideas have been incorporated into the Constitution of the Chinese Communist Party, a distinction that grants him an exceptional position in contemporary Chinese political history. Analyzing his cognitive patterns, especially in relation to the Belt and Road Initiative as China's largest and most costly international strategy, is therefore of particular academic significance.

Moreover, the Belt and Road Initiative is an international project encompassing nearly 150 countries across different continents, political systems, and levels of economic development. Nevertheless, China remains its designer and primary actor. While China is minimally influenced by other participants, it exerts the greatest influence upon them. Any project smaller than the Belt and Road Initiative would have remained within the realm of China's bilateral policies or domestic affairs, while any initiative larger than it would likely have assumed a multilateral or organizational form in which China's role would have been more constrained. In this sense, the Belt and Road Initiative represents a point of equilibrium, enabling China to exercise its will in an international environment while retaining initiative control.

This characteristic makes the study of the Belt and Road Initiative particularly valuable, as it provides insights into China's potential behavior under conditions in which it holds predominant power within an international institution and can exert substantial influence over other actors. Although this research does not claim to offer definitive answers to such a broad question, it can nonetheless provide important insights into China's behavioral patterns under such circumstances.

1.7 Temporal Scope of the Study

This study examines Xi Jinping's perceptions as reflected in his interviews and speeches from 1989 to 2012, with a focus on their implications for the Belt and Road Initiative.

1.8 Structure of the Study

Chapter Two examines the three main approaches in international relations—realism, liberalism, and constructivism—alongside Chinese theoretical perspectives, in order to clarify how each interprets the Belt and Road Initiative. This discussion highlights the strengths and limitations of both classical and Chinese theories. The chapter then introduces cognitive mapping theory, outlining its intellectual origins, core assumptions, and application to the analysis of leaders' perceptions. The methodology section explains text selection, sampling strategy, coding procedures, map construction, and causal analysis, providing the analytical tools for subsequent empirical chapters.

Chapter Three places the study in its appropriate historical and intellectual context. It first introduces China's political and economic transformations during the 1990s and 2000s, then explains the challenges China faced in international politics, and finally presents a concise political biography of Xi Jinping. In this way, the chapter traces the historical developments that ultimately led to the formation of the Belt and Road Initiative and provides the context needed to understand the initiative's origins and its place in Xi Jinping's perceptions.

Chapter Four presents and analyzes the empirical data. Xi Jinping's speeches, interviews, and official documents are collected and coded, and key concepts (nodes) and causal relationships (edges) are extracted. Xi Jinping's cognitive map is then presented and its main components explained. The study subsequently moves from description to causal analysis. Using process tracing, the evidence presented in Chapter Three, and the cognitive map, the chapter demonstrates how Xi Jinping's perceptions are reflected in the Belt and Road Initiative and then uses this analysis to answer the research questions.

The final chapter presents the conclusion in an analytical form and synthesizes the study's theoretical, empirical, and policy-related discussions.

Chapter 2

Theoretical Framework and Research Methodology

2.1 Introduction

In this chapter, three major theoretical traditions in international relations (realism, liberalism, and constructivism) are first examined, along with Chinese indigenous theories and approaches, in order to clarify how each of these frameworks interprets and makes sense of the Belt and Road Initiative. The aim of this theoretical comparison is to reveal the capacities, strengths, and, at the same time, the limitations of classical international relations theories and Chinese perspectives in explaining the logic, objectives, and consequences of this initiative. This review demonstrates that each approach emphasizes specific dimensions of the Belt and Road Initiative while also encountering shortcomings in explaining certain aspects of it.

Next, cognitive mapping theory is introduced as an alternative theoretical framework. This section outlines the intellectual origins of the theory, its epistemological and ontological assumptions, and its capabilities for analyzing the perceptions of political leaders. The primary focus is on how cognitive mapping can systematically reconstruct the link between individual leaders' perceptions and the formation of macro-level policies, including the Belt and Road Initiative.

Finally, the research methodology section explains the procedural steps of the study. It describes the method of text selection, sampling strategy, concept-coding process, the construction of cognitive maps, and the method for analyzing causal relationships among concepts. The role of process tracing is then discussed to clarify how causal inferences about perceptions in the initiation of the Belt and Road Initiative are drawn. This section provides the necessary methodological framework for the empirical analysis of data and forms the foundation for the subsequent empirical chapters of the study.

2.2 Realism: Power, Security, and the Belt and Road Initiative

Realism is one of the most influential and enduring theories of International Relations and has consistently attracted significant support due to the close affinity between its core assumptions and the pragmatic mindset of policymakers (Moshirzadeh, 1388, page 73). From a realist perspective, the anarchic nature of the international system generates inherent insecurity: no central authority exists to prevent conflict, and states, operating in a self-help system, seek to ensure their survival by accumulating power (Mearsheimer, 2001, page 334). Although realism does not constitute a fully unified and contradiction-free theoretical whole (Moshirzadeh, 1388, page 73), it is nonetheless possible to identify a set of broadly shared assumptions. Different theorists, however, have articulated these assumptions in varying ways.

For example, Randall Schweller identifies seven core assumptions as the “hard core” of the realist school: (1) humans primarily interact as members of groups rather than as isolated individuals; (2) international relations take place under conditions of anarchy; (3) power is the fundamental attribute of international politics and is essential for achieving any objective; (4) international interactions are inherently conflictual; (5) increased rationality and knowledge do not enable humanity to attain lasting peace; (6) politics is not subordinate to morality, but morality is a byproduct of power; and (7) the imperatives and logic of the state take precedence over moral considerations (Schweller, 1997, page 927).

Similarly, Wohlforth identifies three assumptions shared across all variants of realism: groupism, egoism, and power-centrism. In other words, (1) humans act in groups, which constitutes the primary source of conflict; (2) egoism ultimately shapes political behavior; and (3) power is the central axis of politics, with relationships consistently formed under the shadow of coercion and the potential use of material power (Wohlforth, 2016, page 36). Taken together, these foundational principles offer a broadly pessimistic view of world politics, one in which competition for power remains the dominant driving force.

At first glance, the declaratory language of the Belt and Road Initiative diverges substantially from the core assumptions of realism. In China’s official documents on the Belt and Road Initiative, emphasis is placed on win–win cooperation, the equality of countries regardless of their relative power, and concepts such as friendship, mutual understanding, confidence-building, and people-to-people bonds. For example, the *Vision and Actions on Jointly Building the Belt and Road* document explicitly states that the initiative is a “road towards peace and friendship” that promotes win–win cooperation by enhancing mutual understanding and trust among peoples (National Development and Reform Commission et al., 2015). Such rhetoric, which stresses solidarity and shared interests, appears at odds

with the realist presumption that power competition and distrust are inherent and unavoidable features of international politics.

Nevertheless, realists do not take official rhetoric at face value and instead focus on underlying intentions and material capabilities. For example, John J. Mearsheimer, a leading proponent of offensive realism, argues that great powers pursue four overarching objectives: achieving regional hegemony, maximizing national wealth, attaining dominance in conventional land power, and securing superiority in nuclear capabilities (Mearsheimer, 2001, pp. 140–145). If China’s behavior over the past decade is examined, the rapid growth of its wealth and economy, the substantial strengthening of its military forces (including its nuclear arsenal), and the implementation of a massive project such as the Belt and Road Initiative all appear consistent with the objectives identified by Mearsheimer. In his theory, a hegemon is defined as a state that enjoys clear dominance over all other states within the system (Mearsheimer, 2001, p. 40). From this perspective, the Belt and Road Initiative can be interpreted as an effort by China to consolidate dominance over its neighbors and to emerge as a regional hegemon. Concepts such as the “debt-trap” narrative¹ and the “string of pearls” theory² are also advanced within this framework. According to this view, China’s infrastructure projects in smaller countries render them heavily indebted, and in cases of repayment failure, enable Beijing to acquire control over ports and other strategic assets. China may then possess a chain of ports stretching from South Asia to Africa, which could potentially serve as military facilities to secure dominance over these regions (Mobley, 2019).

By contrast, recent empirical assessments do not lend strong support to the above narrative. For instance, a study examining China’s financial interactions with six countries in Asia and Africa—including Sri Lanka, the Maldives, Malaysia, Laos, Kenya, and Djibouti—finds no evidence of a deliberate “debt-trap” strategy (Himmer & Rod, 2022). On the contrary, research indicates that the debt problems faced by these countries largely stem from their own domestic policies and elite decision-making rather than from a pre-meditated Chinese scheme (Himmer & Rod, 2022; Jones & Hameiri, 2020). In some cases, the Chinese government has even postponed loan repayments or forgiven portions of debt to assist these countries; had its intention been merely to ensnare them, it could instead have demanded strategic concessions in exchange for debt relief (Himmer & Rod, 2022). Some scholars have gone further, characterizing the very notion of “debt-trap diplomacy” as a myth and a product of media exaggeration (Himmer & Rod, 2022; Rana & Ji,

¹This claim refers to the argument that Beijing provides large-scale loans to developing countries in order to entangle them in cycles of debt distress, thereby increasing its political and economic influence.

²This notion in geopolitical studies refers to the perception that China seeks to establish a chain of ports, logistical hubs, and maritime investments along the Indian Ocean, creating a network of strategic footholds to support energy routes and expand its naval power. These facilities are likened to pearls connected along a necklace, forming an integrated corridor.

2020). By the same logic, the mere development of infrastructure across different countries does not necessarily translate into China's political–military domination over them. Even if China were to acquire predominant influence in its surrounding regions, this outcome would be attributable less to the Belt and Road Initiative itself than to the growing weight of China's economy and technological capabilities within the global system. In other words, China's expanding economic power—such as its share in global trade or its position in global supply chains—generates leverage almost automatically, whether or not the Belt and Road Initiative exists.

On the other hand, structural obstacles to China's attainment of hegemonic status should not be overlooked. China operates in an environment where a powerful neighbor such as Russia—with a vast nuclear arsenal and significant conventional land power—would not permit China to achieve uncontested dominance. Moreover, rather than pursuing unilateralism in managing regional security, Beijing has increasingly turned to multilateral mechanisms. A prominent example is the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, established with the participation of China, Russia, and the Central Asian states to facilitate regional security coordination. The existence of such mechanisms indicates that China's approach in Central Asia, as the core area of the Silk Road Economic Belt, rests more on regional convergence and cooperation than on the creation of a unipolar regional order under its own domination. This reality does not conform to the patterns expected by offensive realism.

The realist tradition itself encompasses a diverse range of theories—classical, structural, neoclassical, and others—and the question of China's position within the international order extends well beyond the simplified analysis outlined above. Nevertheless, what matters for the present research is that the Belt and Road Initiative has been defined primarily in the realm of economic cooperation rather than military confrontation or security competition. Consequently, explaining its emergence solely on the basis of a logic of power maximization, as emphasized by realism, entails significant shortcomings. As the subject of this study, the Belt and Road Initiative has been implemented chiefly around economic cooperation rather than power politics and conflict management; therefore, analyzing it within a realist framework cannot provide a convincing explanation for why China adopted this policy.

2.3 Liberalism: Interdependence and Institutionalism Put to the Test

Theories emerging from the liberal tradition adopt a more optimistic view of international relations than realism. In these perspectives, cooperation among states is both possible and

desirable, and international institutions and patterns of interdependence are seen as contributing to peace. Most of these theories, however, have been developed on the assumption of liberal (democratic) states, and therefore do not fully correspond to the Chinese case, which is characterized by a single-party system. Although certain liberal concepts—such as win–win cooperation, a unified human community, and the shared destiny of nations—appear in China’s official discourse on the Belt and Road Initiative, in practice China’s policy remains state-centered (indeed, party-centered) and assigns no meaningful role to an independent civil society or to constraints on state authority. For example, China’s conception of “people-to-people diplomacy” functions primarily as an instrument to facilitate intergovernmental rapprochement, rather than as an expression of a universal human community in line with liberal ideals.

In general, four major areas of emphasis can be identified within liberal theories: (1) democratic peace (the proposition that democracies do not go to war with one another); (2) transnationalism and the role of supranational institutions; (3) the effect of trade and economic interaction in reducing conflict; and (4) international institutionalism (Moshirzadeh, 1388, p. 28). Among these four dimensions, the third and fourth appear most directly relevant to the Belt and Road Initiative—namely, the idea of peace through economic interdependence and the substitution of an order based on international institutions for unilateral hegemony. Although some analyses have gestured toward these approaches, they are nonetheless primarily designed to explain behavior at the systemic level and offer limited explanatory leverage for foreign policy and the decision-making processes behind it.

Among the mainstream traditions of international relations theory, institutionalism arguably offers the greatest explanatory potential for understanding the Belt and Road Initiative. Institutionalism is grounded in the idea that states, even under conditions of anarchy, create international regimes and institutions in order to pursue shared interests. An international regime consists of a set of principles, rules, norms, and decision-making procedures within a specific issue area that align actors’ expectations and reduce uncertainty. By defining the rules of the game, regimes raise the costs of defection and unilateral behavior and thereby facilitate cooperation (Moshirzadeh, 1388, p. 77).

Some analysts have interpreted China’s mode of engagement with Belt and Road countries as an attempt at regime-building; that is, China seeks through its initiative to establish new norms and arrangements that may ultimately lead to a durable framework for cooperation. A frequently cited example is the establishment of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, which China created alongside older financial institutions (such as the World Bank) in order to finance projects associated with the Belt and Road Initiative (Shariatinia & Masoudi, 1398, p. 27). Some scholars go even further, arguing that China aims to construct an “informal regime” without creating a formal organization, within which other

countries, observing the benefits of cooperation with China, gradually emulate Beijing's practices, giving rise to a form of unwritten normative compliance (Garlick & Qin, 2024, p. 987).

Nevertheless, in practice it is difficult to equate the Belt and Road Initiative with a deliberate and coherent effort at liberal order-building. Several serious obstacles stand in the way of such an interpretation: the lack of transparency and indeterminacy of rules, the extremely heterogeneous composition of participating countries, pronounced power asymmetries, and China's single-party political system.

International regimes emerge when repeated patterns of behavior and interaction among actors crystallize into stable expectations and when there is broad agreement on the legitimate rules governing interaction. In the case of the Belt and Road Initiative, although China has issued overarching policy documents, most of the specific bilateral agreements concluded with participating countries remain opaque and confidential. The memoranda of understanding that China has signed with dozens of countries under the framework of the Belt and Road Initiative are largely declaratory in nature, emphasizing general intentions to cooperate while defining few concrete legal frameworks or binding commitments (H. Wang, 2019). Moreover, the details of many Chinese infrastructure contracts—from the volume and interest rates of loans to the conditions of financing and implementation—are concealed from public view and, in some cases, are not even disclosed to the parliaments or oversight bodies of recipient countries (Tabnak, 1401). It is therefore evident that, in the absence of transparency and without clear indications of which behaviors will be rewarded and which will be sanctioned, the formation of a cooperative regime is unlikely. Put differently, countries participating in the Belt and Road Initiative lack a clear understanding of the rules that govern cooperation and the shared practices they are expected to follow.

The Belt and Road Initiative encompasses countries ranging from East Asia to Africa and Europe that are highly heterogeneous in terms of political systems, levels of economic development, and strategic interests. It is therefore difficult for a single, unified set of rules to govern China's relations with such a diverse group of partners. Each country has its own specific expectations and constraints, and China likewise engages with them on a largely case-by-case basis (N. Wang, 2022, p. 874). International regimes tend to emerge when actors are able to monitor one another's compliance with shared rules and procedures (Keohane, 1984, p. 79). In the absence of formal multilateral institutions for the Belt and Road Initiative—a situation that largely reflects China's own preferences—states do not, in practice, monitor each other's behavior within the framework of the initiative, which prevents the emergence of imitation or norm internalization.

In light of these considerations, mainstream liberal theories face notable limitations in explaining the Belt and Road Initiative. The liberal vision in which states gradually build trust through deepening economic ties and cooperate within transparent institutional frameworks diverges from the empirical reality of the Belt and Road Initiative. In this gap, China's domestic political structure—an authoritarian single-party system—and the pervasive lack of transparency play a decisive role. For this reason, understanding the dynamics of the Belt and Road Initiative may require turning to an approach that places greater emphasis on norms and ideas—namely, constructivism.

2.4 Constructivism: New Ideas in China's Approach to Order-Building

Constructivism is not a single unified theory but rather a broad theoretical approach in international relations that emphasizes the social construction of social realities through ideas, norms, and beliefs. The introduction of constructivism into international relations debates brought about a significant ontological shift in the discipline (Moshirzadeh, 1388, p. 324), highlighting concepts such as the structure–agency relationship, the impact of identity on national interests, and the role of discourse in shaping state behavior. Put simply, constructivists argue that many international phenomena—ranging from conflict to cooperation—cannot be explained solely through material variables; instead, it is necessary to examine how states perceive and define themselves and others, and how shared norms are formed or eroded (Steans et al., 2013, pp. 187–188).

The constructivist approach appears particularly well suited for studying a power such as China, which seeks to transform the international order through the articulation of new ideas. Unlike realism and liberalism, which tend to presuppose limited and predetermined pathways for rising powers—such as aggression or institutional integration—constructivism leaves room for alternative trajectories. Contemporary China does not seek merely to follow the existing order, as evidenced by numerous statements from its leaders emphasizing the need to reform global governance, yet it also does not claim to have articulated a fully coherent alternative order. Rather, it can be argued that China is engaged in a process of normative experimentation.

One prominent example is China's promotion of the concept of a “community of shared destiny,” advanced as a normative framework expressing its preferred vision of the international system. Within this perspective, China portrays itself as a “moral power” aspiring to build a more just and inclusive order (Callahan, 2016, p. 13). The Belt and Road Initiative represents one of the concrete channels through which this idea is operationalized: by investing in infrastructure in developing countries and connecting economies, China

seeks to construct an interconnected network that encompasses not only material interests but also political and cultural linkages. As William Callahan argues, Beijing is weaving together ideas, institutions, and practices in order to present a new grand strategy as a norm-shaping project (Callahan, 2016, p. 13). The ultimate objective is to embed neighboring countries within a China-centered network of economic, political, and security relations that may gradually give rise to a new regional—and eventually global—order with novel norms and rules.³ (Callahan, 2016; Rolland, 2017, p. 13).

Within a constructivist framework, it becomes possible to address questions that earlier approaches were unable to pose. For example, is the Belt and Road Initiative primarily China's response to changes in the global power structure—such as perceived threats stemming from the United States' presence in East Asia—or is it instead the product of a redefinition of China's identity and role by its leadership? Put differently, has China, in observing intensifying competition with the West, decided to strengthen its surrounding strategic depth in Central Asia, South Asia, and the Middle East, with the Belt and Road Initiative serving as a preemptive move to substitute Eurasian markets for Western ones in the event of heightened confrontation with the United States? Or, conversely, has the Belt and Road Initiative itself been a factor that generated concern in Washington and contributed to the escalation of rivalry? Both narratives have circulated within China's elite discourse, and constructivism enables an examination of the reciprocal perceptions between China and the United States, as well as the discursive representations each holds of the other's intentions.

From a constructivist perspective, the Belt and Road Initiative can also be interpreted as an effort at gradual norm formation. In contrast to institutionalism, which emphasizes formal and transparent mechanisms, a constructivist might argue that what truly matters is the emergence of a shared intersubjective understanding between China and its Belt and Road partners regarding new patterns of interaction. If such shared understandings take hold—for instance, the belief that cooperation with China is beneficial for national development—then even in the absence of binding formal treaties, an informal yet stable order may emerge. For example, the details of China's financial agreements with a particular country may not be publicly disclosed, but if states observe that infrastructure cooperation with China yields economic growth and tangible benefits, a positive cognitive image of the Belt and Road Initiative may form among elites. This, in turn, can attract further participation and reduce skepticism. In such circumstances, norms governing interaction with China can be said to have been institutionalized in a soft manner, fulfilling a function similar to what institutionalists expect from international regimes, albeit without formal treaties or full transparency.

³This argument can also be understood through Qin Yaqing's relational theory, discussed below.

A closer examination of China's performance within the Belt and Road Initiative, however, reveals that this constructivist optimism is not without problems. The emergence of a stable intersubjective understanding requires a degree of transparency and consistency in behavior. Yet the very concept and scope of the Belt and Road Initiative underwent several revisions between 2013 and 2020. Initially conceived as a project focused on Central Asia and Southeast Asia, it was later expanded to include Africa and Latin America. It was first labeled "One Belt, One Road" and subsequently rebranded as the "Belt and Road Initiative." In one phase, the primary emphasis lay on infrastructure investment, while later additional components such as the Digital Silk Road and the Health Silk Road were incorporated. Such shifts—referred to by some observers as the "second version of the Belt and Road Initiative" (Yu, 2024, p. 200)—indicate that even within China, consensus over the initiative's definition did not emerge quickly, and that it took years for a relatively clear conceptual framework to develop. Official government documents remained highly general, and the relationship between the Belt and Road Initiative and other Chinese initiatives—such as the Shanghai Cooperation Organization, the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank, and various bilateral economic arrangements—was never clearly articulated. As a result, China appears to be pursuing a series of fragmented actions and institution-building efforts that lack an overarching coherent picture. This conceptual ambiguity has undoubtedly hindered the formation of a shared understanding among all stakeholders, as the differing approaches adopted by different actors also demonstrate.

Despite these limitations, constructivism remains a valuable analytical tool for examining the role of ideas and identity in Chinese policymaking. As noted above, Xi Jinping and the intellectual circle surrounding him have sought to articulate a new narrative of China's role in the world—one that presents China as the standard-bearer of a new order distinct from Western hegemony yet oriented toward shared benefits. Concepts such as the "Chinese Dream," the "community of shared destiny for mankind," and the emphasis on morality in international politics all signal Beijing's effort to reconstruct international norms in line with its own perspectives. Callahan argues that an examination of ideological debates within China over foreign policy—particularly Xi's view of China as a moral power and the notion of a community of shared destiny—reveals how Beijing intertwines ideas, institutions, and practices in order to present a new grand strategy as a norm-shaping power (Callahan, 2016, p. 13).

Moreover, constructivism provides a theoretical foundation for methodologies aimed at uncovering these ideas. One particularly useful tool is speech act theory developed by John Searle and its interpretation in the social sciences by Nicholas Onuf (2013, p. 82). According to Onuf, the performative utterances of political leaders reflect the conditions they seek to bring into existence (Kubáľková, 2001; Moshirzadeh, 1396, p. 66). Therefore,

analyzing the speeches and statements of leaders can provide a window into their mindset and true intentions. In the case of China, Xi Jinping's remarks in international forums—such as his repeated emphasis on “win-win,” opposition to a new Cold War, calls for common development, and so on—can be examined as indicators of future orientation. This is the path that the present study seeks to follow: examining Xi Jinping's discourse in order to map his cognitive framework regarding the Belt and Road Initiative.

However, the constructivist approach as a whole is too broad to serve as a coherent theoretical framework for this study. For this reason, the study adopts the specific “cognitive mapping” theory as its theoretical framework. This theory focuses explicitly on leaders' perceptions and provides a better theoretical structure for the objectives of the current research.

That said, before addressing the theories related to this approach, a brief reference will be made to Chinese international relations theories. Given the shared roots of these theories and China's foreign policy, a better understanding of Chinese theories will contribute to a broader understanding of China's foreign policy in general and Xi Jinping's perceptions in particular.

2.5 Chinese International Relations Theories

From the perspective of Chinese theorizing in international relations, international politics is not understood as a network of self-contained units operating under conditions of anarchy, but rather as an interwoven set of dynamic relationships within which actors' identities and interests are constructed and reproduced through continuous interaction. In the theory of “relationality,” formulated by Qin Yaqing, relations constitute the fundamental unit of analysis, and the “logic of relationality” suggests that actors' decisions and actions are defined primarily on the basis of their relationships with others. This logic is rooted in the epistemology of Zhongyong Dialectics⁴ which, in the Confucian tradition, emphasizes harmony and balance, whereas Western philosophy has often treated contradiction and conflict as foundational principles of social order (Qin, 2018, p. 170). Accordingly, actors in international relations can be likened to pieces in the game of Go,⁵ whose meaning and rationality can only be understood in relation to their position within a network, rather than as isolated and self-sufficient units (Z. Wang & Zhao, 2021, p. 12).

⁴中庸辩证法 (*Zhōngyōng Biànzhèngfǎ*).

⁵围棋 (*Wéiqí*). A traditional East Asian strategic board game in which two players place black and white stones on a grid with the aim of surrounding and controlling more territory than the opponent. Despite its simple rules, the game exhibits profound strategic complexity and is commonly regarded as a symbol of long-term and subtle strategic thinking.

This ontological and epistemological foundation yields a model of relational governance for understanding the Belt and Road Initiative. Within this framework, the advancement of cooperation is achieved not merely through formal and legal rules, but primarily through processes of negotiation, flexibility, and the cultivation of mutual trust. Research suggests that in Asia a transition from rule-based governance toward relational governance is underway; however, the experience of countries such as Malaysia⁶ demonstrates that reliance on relational governance alone is insufficient and may generate significant political and implementation challenges. For this reason, a combination of relational practices with rule-based mechanisms is considered necessary (Z. Wang & Zhao, 2021, p. 12).

Alongside this framework, the theory of the “Balance of Relationships” (BoR),⁷ advanced by the Taiwanese scholar Chih-yu Shih⁸ and his collaborators, emphasizes that states, in order to sustain stable relationships—especially under conditions of tension—must engage in restraint, repair, and improvisation. Unlike balance-of-power theory, which treats anarchy and conflict as the natural condition of international relations, this approach assumes relationality to be the prevailing state among countries, and holds that perceived similarity or shared identity can serve as a basis for mutual obligations and durable stability (X. A. Yang, 2021, p. 1).

Chinese-language scholarship has also advanced theoretical perspectives beyond relational theory and has linked the Belt and Road Initiative to China’s domestic domains. Duojie Angxiu⁹ argues that the Belt and Road Initiative constitutes a historic opportunity to redefine China’s relationship with “Asia” and to transform China’s peripheral domestic minorities into hubs of cross-border connectivity. He analyzes this process through the conceptual framework of *Tianxia*¹⁰ and emphasizes that by rearticulating the *Tianxia* system on the basis of political ethics, China can simultaneously strengthen internal ethnic cohesion and enhance its international legitimacy (Duojie Angxiu, 2018, p. 24). In other words, ethnic minorities are envisioned as bridges linking China to other Asian societies, thereby moving beyond a rigid Han/non-Han dichotomy.

Other scholars, such as Sun Jiesheng,¹¹ emphasize the need to theorize international relations on the basis of China’s diplomatic practice in initiatives such as the Belt and Road.

⁶In Malaysia, Belt and Road Initiative projects were largely negotiated behind closed doors and with insufficient transparency, leading to allegations of corruption and heavy debt burdens.

⁷关系平衡 (*Guānxì Pínghéng*).

⁸石之瑜 (*Shí Zhīyú*).

⁹多杰昂秀 (*Duōjié Ángxìu*). A Tibetan name.

¹⁰天下 (*Tiānxià*). Literally meaning “all under heaven,” a classical Chinese conception of the world and the ordering of relations among political units.

¹¹孙吉胜 (*Sūn Jíshèng*).

They argue that principles such as equality,¹² inclusiveness,¹³ dialogue,¹⁴ and mutual learning,¹⁵ articulated within a broader civilizational outlook,¹⁶ can serve as new theoretical foundations for international relations theory (Sun, 2022, p. 27).

Overall, in comparison with Western theories, the distinctive features of the Chinese approach emerge on several levels. First, a relational ontology is set against the unit-centric assumptions of realism and liberalism. Second, an epistemology of moderation stands in contrast to the conflictual dualism characteristic of much Western thought. Third, a historical–processual methodology is favored over abstract modeling. Analytically, these distinctions suggest that the Belt and Road Initiative is less an attempt at hegemonic domination than an effort to establish China’s relational centrality within a network of regional and global linkages—a network in which power is defined not merely as the capacity to coerce, but as the capacity for mutual empowerment. At the same time, Wang’s critique indicates that explaining the Belt and Road Initiative through relational theory does not imply that the initiative will necessarily culminate in a fully relational order in Asia as envisioned in Qin Yaqing’s theory (Z. Wang & Zhao, 2021, p. 22). What relationality adds to the discussion is a theoretical basis for multilateral cooperation without the creation of formal multilateral institutions. This corresponds to China’s foreign-policy practice and, as noted above, several scholars have reached similar conclusions about Chinese policy generally and Xi Jinping’s foreign policy specifically.

A review of the Chinese-language literature further shows that much of China’s research on the Belt and Road Initiative remains policy-oriented and practical in focus. Topics such as the internationalization of the renminbi, the construction of economic networks, and their economic effects have attracted far greater attention, while relatively few studies engage the initiative explicitly through the lens of Chinese international relations theories. Those that do employ Chinese theoretical frameworks tend to focus more on other concepts promoted by Xi Jinping, such as the “community of shared destiny for mankind.” Another important observation regarding Qin Yaqing’s relational theory is that it appears to have emerged inductively from China’s diplomatic practice, and thus may be understood, at least in part, as a theoretical articulation of Xi Jinping’s views.

In sum, a review of Chinese theorizing indicates that although this body of thought seeks to offer an indigenous and civilizational framework for understanding international relations and the Belt and Road Initiative—and offers highly persuasive explanations—it largely remains at a macro level and pays limited attention to the concrete mechanisms

¹²平等 (*Píngděng*).

¹³包容 (*Bāoróng*).

¹⁴对话 (*Duihuà*).

¹⁵互鉴 (*Hùjiàn*).

¹⁶文明观 (*Wénmíng Guān*).

of decision-making within China's political structure. In other words, theories such as "relationality" or the "balance of relationships" focus primarily on the general logic of China's international conduct and on norms derived from the Confucian intellectual tradition, rather than on the perceptual and psychological processes through which leaders arrive at specific policy choices. Consequently, in order to answer the central research question—namely, why China adopted the Belt and Road Initiative—it is necessary to move from the macro level of civilizational theorizing to the micro level of individual perceptions and motivations within China's power structure.

Addressing the main research question (the rationale behind the adoption of the Belt and Road Initiative) therefore requires engagement with the level of decision-making inside China. Grand theories—realism, liberalism, and constructivism—each illuminate part of the picture; however, the ultimate decision to launch the Belt and Road Initiative was taken by a specific individual or a defined group within China's leadership structure. It is thus essential to turn to theories and models that provide analytical tools for uncovering motivations and decision-making processes. Within the field of foreign policy analysis, two sets of approaches are particularly useful: perceptual theories that focus on leaders' beliefs and perceptions, and group decision-making theories that explain interaction among individuals in the decision process. To bridge these two levels, cognitive mapping theory provides an appropriate framework.

Overall, in order to explain why the Belt and Road Initiative was adopted, this study proceeds—after a critical review of macro-level approaches—to an analysis of the perceptions and beliefs of China's leader. In other words, cognitive mapping analysis is used to examine Xi Jinping's specific decision to launch the initiative. This approach is expected to yield a more comprehensive and deeper understanding of the motivations and strategic calculations underlying the Belt and Road Initiative.

2.6 Cognitive Mapping Theory

Cognitive mapping theory provides an analytical framework for representing and examining how individuals think about complex decision-making problems. At its most basic level, a cognitive map is a graphical model of an individual's belief system, in which concepts are depicted as nodes and causal relationships among them are represented by directed arrows. Robert Axelrod, who introduced this approach into the study of international relations, defines a cognitive map as a "graphic representation of an individual's causal propositions, presented as a diagram consisting of points and arrows" (Axelrod, 1976, p. 60).

In other words, a cognitive map is a visual representation that illustrates how, in the belief system of a decision-maker, different factors influence one another and lead to particular outcomes. Each linkage between concepts typically carries a valence or orientation, represented as positive (+), negative (−), or neutral (o). Valence indicates whether one concept increases or decreases another. For example, in a leader's cognitive map one might observe a relationship such as “economic aid” → (+) “political influence” (a positive causal relationship) or “sanctions” → (−) “economic growth” (a negative causal relationship).

These causal chains often terminate in ultimate goals or core values such as “national security” or “economic prosperity,” which in cognitive mapping theory are referred to as “utility nodes.” By examining the causal pathways within a map, it becomes possible to reconstruct the decision-maker's underlying reasoning—from the perceived effects of specific policies on intermediate outcomes to their ultimate impact on overarching objectives.

Overall, cognitive mapping theory offers a systematic method for representing what an actor believes (concepts), how those beliefs are connected (causal relations), and how the direction of those relations is evaluated (as beneficial or harmful). In this way, the theory provides a conceptual structure for modeling decision-making processes in which policy alternatives, causes, consequences, and goals are all interconnected as nodes within a causal diagram. Analyzing such maps can reveal key dimensions such as central concepts, underlying assumptions, and focal points of reasoning, thereby yielding a clearer understanding of the perceptual foundations of decision-making.

2.6.1 Intellectual Origins of Cognitive Mapping Theory

Cognitive mapping theory emerged at the intersection of ideas from cognitive psychology and systems theory. Cognitive psychology provided the initial inspiration, particularly through studies of mental representations and causal reasoning. For example, Kurt Lewin's field theory, developed within Gestalt psychology, and Fritz Heider's balance theory introduced the notion of perceptual “maps” of attitudes and highlighted the human tendency toward consistency and coherence within belief systems (Neumann, n.d.). Heider's work on “congruity” and “attribution” was grounded in the idea that individuals act as intuitive scientists who construct causal explanations in order to make sense of events. These ideas later contributed to the development of attribution theory and to the broader view that individuals possess internal belief structures that guide their perceptions (Bonham, 1993, p. 257). Causal beliefs are emphasized in cognitive mapping theory precisely because cognitive psychology has shown that causal inference plays a major role in problem-solving and decision-making (Young & Schafer, 1998, p. 75).

Indeed, the term “cognitive map” itself was first introduced in psychology by Edward Tolman, who used it to describe the mental map formed by a rat navigating a maze, arguing that humans similarly construct cognitive maps of their environments. Tolman even suggested that “narrow cognitive maps” could lead to aggressive behavior, whereas “truly comprehensive maps” enable rational action (Bonham, 1993, p. 257). These psychological foundations underscore the idea that decision-makers possess internal representations of the world that shape how they decide and act.

Alongside developments in cognitive psychology, systems theory and cybernetics played a crucial role in the formal development of cognitive mapping theory. Axelrod, drawing on graph theory and mathematics, sought to model belief systems as networks. Building on research in “psycho-logic” and models of causal inference, he developed cognitive maps in a formal and structured manner (Axelrod, 1976, pp. 8–10).

Scholars such as Maruyama elaborated complex feedback loops within “cybernetic systems” and emphasized the role of self-reinforcing and self-balancing cycles within them (Axelrod, 1976, p. 66). The concept of feedback, derived from cybernetics, occupies a central place in cognitive mapping theory: unlike simple linear models, cognitive maps often include cycles (for example, A affects B, B affects C, and C in turn affects A) that better reflect the real dynamics of policymaking and the interaction between mind and environment. For instance, Bougon and his colleagues described organizational cognition in terms of “causal maps” that link individuals’ mental models within organizations to their surrounding environments, thereby representing organizations as active and intelligible cognitive systems (Laukkanen & Wang, 2015, p. 14).

Thus, cognitive mapping theory stands at the intersection of cognitive science and systems-oriented thinking. It rests on the premise that decision-makers hold complex mental models of causal relationships and employs systems-analytic tools—such as graphs, matrices, and feedback concepts—to represent and analyze these models in a systematic way.

The intellectual lineage of the theory also draws on psychological theories of belief structures, such as personal construct theory, which conceptualized cognition as a set of interconnected constructs organized hierarchically (Bonham, 1993, p. 256). It also connects to traditions of analytical modeling, including Herbert Simon’s notion of bounded rationality and Blalock’s causal modeling approaches (Bougon et al., 1977, p. 4). In the early 1970s, these streams converged, and scholars such as Axelrod introduced cognitive mapping theory into the study of political decision-making. They explicitly emphasized its foundations in cognitive consistency theories, evaluative assertion analysis, and formal decision theory.

Put simply, cognitive mapping theory is based on the idea that by combining cognitive psychology's concern with the mental structures of belief and systems theory's tools for modeling causal networks, it is possible to systematically reconstruct the mental maps of decision-makers.

2.6.2 Core Assumptions of Cognitive Mapping Theory

The cognitive mapping approach is grounded in a set of key assumptions regarding decision-makers' thought processes and the manner in which these processes can be modeled. First, this approach rests on the assumption that beliefs about causal relationships constitute a central element in decision-making processes (Young & Schafer, 1998, p. 75). A crucial feature of the beliefs that link decisions to outcomes is their indirect nature. Individuals are generally unable to infer a direct relationship between a decision and its outcome in a single inferential leap. Rather, their reasoning typically follows a chain such as the following: if a particular decision is taken, other actors will behave in a certain way; given the conditions of the external environment, these actions will then produce a specific outcome (Axelrod, 1976, p. 78). Axelrod emphasizes that causality, especially when choices are under discussion, is "built into our language," and that mapping these perceived causal linkages is therefore essential for understanding decision-making logic (Axelrod, 1976, p. 5).

This simple graphical grammar—composed of directed arrows marked with positive and negative signs—makes it possible to encode highly complex reasoning. For example, an official may hold a mental structure such as: "infrastructure improvement" (+) → "economic growth" (+) → "political stability" (−) → "corruption," while simultaneously believing that "corruption" (−) → "effective infrastructure." Such a configuration generates a feedback loop that complicates the ultimate policy outcome. Cognitive mapping theory assumes that these structures reflect the internal, perceived logic through which individuals understand causal relationships in a given issue area, and that this logic can be modeled in an analytically tractable manner.

Another core assumption of cognitive mapping theory is that belief systems possess a discernible and analyzable structure. Cognitive maps are treated as quasi-mathematical representations of individual belief systems. As demonstrated by Axelrod, a cognitive map can be formally represented as an adjacency matrix, often referred to as a *valence matrix*. This matrix is denoted by

$$\mathbf{V} = [v_{ij}],$$

where each element v_{ij} represents the presence, direction, and strength of a causal linkage from concept i to concept j (Axelrod, 1976, p. 347). Such representations enable system-

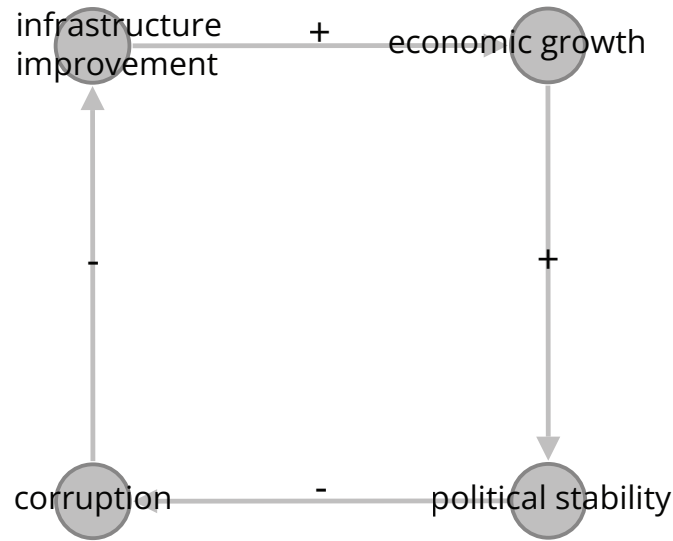


Figure 2.1: An Example of a Feedback Loop

Note. Figure created by the author.

atic forms of analysis. For example, indirect causal relationships among concepts can be examined by computing a reachability matrix, or transitive closure, defined as

$$\mathbf{R} = \mathbf{V} + \mathbf{V}^2 + \dots + \mathbf{V}^{n-1},$$

where $\mathbf{V}$ is the valence (adjacency) matrix and n denotes the number of concepts in the cognitive map. Each power $\mathbf{V}^k$ captures causal paths of length k , such that $\mathbf{R}$ summarizes all possible direct and indirect causal chains linking concepts within the belief system (Axelrod, 1976, p. 352).¹⁷ If changes in one concept generate extensive cascading effects on other concepts—indicated by a large number of non-zero entries in the $\mathbf{R}$ matrix—it can be inferred that the individual’s belief system exhibits a high degree of interconnectedness, which in turn signals a high level of cognitive complexity (Axelrod, 1976, p. 355).

In fact one of the central premises of the theory is thus that the structural properties of a cognitive map carry meaningful perceptual implications, including the presence or absence of feedback loops. Within this framework, the number of alternative pathways and options that a leader perceives is treated as an indicator of that leader’s level of cognitive complexity (Shapiro & Bonham, 1973, p. 150).

The cognitive mapping approach is based on the assumption that, although individuals are inevitably compelled to simplify reality, the pattern of these simplifications—namely, which factors they connect or ignore—reflects their perceptual strategy.

¹⁷For a detailed explanation of how these matrices are calculated, see Appendix C.

The comprehensive view that a cognitive map provides of an individual's perceptions makes it a useful tool for interpreting why a particular policy or decision is adopted. In this sense, a decision can be traced back to the underlying beliefs and ideas of the actor. For instance, if a leader pursues a seemingly high-risk initiative, cognitive map analysis may reveal that, from the leader's perspective, the initiative was not perceived as risky at all, but rather as a logical step within a chain of causal beliefs. Bonham emphasizes that cognitive maps can uncover such "root causes" and the perceived consequences underlying policy proposals (Bonham, 1993). By examining an official's cognitive map, analysts can identify central nodes—core concepts and key concerns—and understand how evidence, historical examples, or past analogies are employed in the individual's reasoning (Bonham, 1993, p. 263). In this way, cognitive maps directly guide the interpretation of data: statements or documents are not evaluated merely at the surface level, but are analyzed as elements within a network of beliefs that confer meaning upon them. This approach bridges the gap between qualitative evidence, such as speeches and declarations, and systematic analysis. Each fragment of discourse is coded within the map, and the structure of the map helps explain the policymaker's narrative and choices.

In sum, the analytical value of cognitive mapping theory in international relations lies in its ability to construct a transparent bridge between ideas and outcomes. The theory compels analysts to make an actor's internal logic explicit. Once this logic is mapped, data—whether speeches, positions, or actions—can be interpreted through content analysis as either consistent or inconsistent with the cognitive map. Decisions can be anticipated, and even counterfactual "what if" scenarios can be explored by asking which options would have been prioritized had the underlying beliefs been different.

2.7 Research Method

This study will use the process tracing method to infer the causal relationship between Xi Jinping's perceptions and the Belt and Road Initiative. To do so, it is first necessary to obtain an accurate representation of Xi Jinping's perceptions, and then the role and influence of these perceptions will be examined as evidence within the process tracing framework.

In doing so, it will employ a qualitative content analysis approach to systematically examine Xi Jinping's statements and to extract his perceptual patterns. Content analysis is generally defined as a set of procedures for drawing inferences from texts and can be conducted in either quantitative or qualitative forms (Krippendorff, 2019, p. 91). In quantitative content analysis, texts are coded into predefined categories and the frequency of keywords or themes is counted (Krippendorff, 2019, p. 102). This type of analysis often

relies on computer software and large datasets, focusing on observable variables in order to provide rapid and reliable answers to “what” questions (Morin et al., 2021, p. 60). By contrast, qualitative content analysis emphasizes the interpretation of context and latent meanings through close reading of texts and is used to address “how” and “why” questions (Morin et al., 2021, p. 59). In inductive qualitative content analysis, the researcher approaches the text with an open stance—typically working with smaller samples—and allows categories or insights to emerge from the data. The outcome of this process is a rich and nuanced understanding; however, its reproducibility in larger samples is more limited and it is not primarily designed for replication (Morin et al., 2021, p. 58). Given the aims of this research, qualitative content analysis constitutes the most appropriate strategy, as it enables the capture of linguistic nuances and subtle dimensions of Xi’s thinking that are easily overlooked in purely quantitative analyses.

As discussed earlier, within the cognitive mapping approach, an individual’s perceptions are visually represented as a network of concepts that are causally linked to one another. In other words, a cognitive map provides a model of how an individual thinks and of his worldview, in which causal relationships are expressed in the form “A leads to B.” This method offers a standardized way of studying ideas and has been successfully applied in fields such as political psychology and organizational studies (Van Esch & Snellens, 2024, p. 433). The core assumption of this approach is that an actor’s ideas are reflected in his spoken or written discourse—such as speeches, documents, media statements, or interviews. Unlike general text-analysis techniques, which typically treat individual concepts or themes as the unit of analysis, cognitive mapping takes the relationships among concepts as its basic analytical unit.

Although Axelrod’s original formulation relies primarily on qualitative content analysis, subsequent software developments have added quantitative dimensions to this method. Young, through the development and use of the *Worldview* software, extended the representation of relationships among concepts beyond simple positive and negative links, incorporating relations that express an individual’s judgments about the correctness, incorrectness, or conditionality of a concept (Young, 1996, p. 398). Van Esch and Snellens, drawing on concepts from network theory, further translated qualitatively extracted data into quantitative interpretations. Assuming that a stronger causal belief corresponds to a heavier weighted link between cause and effect, they incorporated counts of how frequently an individual refers to a particular linkage in his verbal acts. They also assumed that the greater the “distance” between a cause and an effect, the weaker the perceived causal power, and therefore included the number of intervening concepts between two nodes as part of their interpretive framework (Van Esch & Snellens, 2024, p. 440). In this way, the methodology employed within the cognitive mapping framework remains

fundamentally qualitative while using selected quantitative calculations to generate more precise and deeper insights into the meanings of the codes extracted from texts. Nevertheless, because the codes themselves are derived manually through close reading, the content analysis in this study is classified as qualitative.

2.7.1 Text Selection and Sampling Strategy

Because content analysis is text-based, the selection of appropriate texts constitutes the first and most crucial step in conducting such research.¹⁸ These data may be sampled from existing sources or collected directly by the researcher (Klotz and Prakash, 2008, p. 152; Schreier, 2012, p. 3). In the studies presented in *The Structure of Decision*, Axelrod employed both strategies, drawing on content generated through focus group interviews as well as on transcribed texts of statements exchanged in decision-making meetings. According to Axelrod, depending on the type of research, spoken words may hold an important advantage over written words. The spontaneous nature of speech, as compared to the careful selection of words in writing, can more effectively reveal an individual's genuine thoughts (Axelrod, 1976, p. 363). At the same time, he emphasizes that the nature of the research determines which types of data—confidential or published materials, speeches or interviews, official documents or informal texts such as notes and letters—constitute the most appropriate sources.

An important methodological challenge in content analysis grounded in cognitive mapping theory concerns source selection. Research inferences should not be derived from policy outcomes. In other words, one cannot explain the reasons behind a policy decision by reference to the policy's results. Instead, perceptions must be studied independently of the policies that were shaped by them (Van Esch & Snellens, 2024, p. 430). The most reliable way to ensure this separation is to use sources that were articulated and published prior to the decision under investigation.

Given the nature of China's political system, accessible documents for reconstructing Xi Jinping's cognitive map are limited. Nevertheless, a survey of the China National Knowledge Infrastructure (CNKI).¹⁹ revealed that a sufficient number of interviews with Xi Jinping are available for the purposes of this study. Owing to the linguistic nature of the methodology, the content is analyzed in its original language, Chinese. The sampling period for interviews spans from 1989—the date of the earliest available interview in the database—to 2002. After 2002, Xi Jinping entered national-level politics, and a noticeable

¹⁸In a broader sense, content analysis as a research method is not limited to written texts; virtually any form of audio, visual, or textual message can be analyzed using this approach.

¹⁹China National Knowledge Infrastructure (CNKI) — 中国知网 (*Zhōngguó Zhīwǎng*) A comprehensive Chinese academic database that includes journal articles, theses, research reports, and scholarly periodicals, and is widely used in social science and humanities research.

change is observable in the style and content of his interviews and speeches. From hundreds of news reports, interviews, and speech transcripts published in Chinese outlets, 190 sources were initially selected for closer examination. Letters and speeches were excluded because of their highly scripted nature in Chinese politics. Only interviews were retained, and among them, only reports in which journalists clearly distinguished their questions from Xi Jinping's answers were selected. This procedure was intended to ensure that the coded text consisted of Xi Jinping's own words rather than journalistic paraphrases or interpretations. Ultimately, 13 distinct interviews in Chinese met all these criteria and were available to the researcher.

In addition, two speeches delivered by Xi Jinping at Nazarbayev University and the Indonesian Parliament—where the Belt and Road Initiative was introduced for the first time—are also coded, in order to compare the place of the Belt and Road Initiative in these speeches with the cognitive map derived from the core interview material. For these two speeches, the official English translations are used for analysis.

The sampling strategy in this study pursued two objectives. First, by selecting this temporal window, examining Xi Jinping's statements prior to his attainment of the highest level of power makes it possible to observe the formative perceptions and guiding ideas that shaped his thinking, without the distortions introduced by the position of supreme leadership. Second, by focusing on interviews published in domestic outlets and excluding pre-scripted speeches, the study selects material whose primary audience consisted of domestic or intra-party readers. As a result, these texts are generally more candid and, in comparison with carefully calibrated official speeches, provide deeper insight into Xi Jinping's perceptions and beliefs.

2.7.2 Coding Procedures

After assembling the textual corpus, the next step is the coding of the material. To this end, the study follows Axelrod's standard cognitive mapping procedure, in which texts are systematically decomposed into discrete causal statements. Weber defines content analysis as "a set of procedures for making inferences from text" and notes that this method can illuminate how individuals use symbols to convey meaning (Klotz & Prakash, 2008, p. 151). In the present research, these "symbols" consist of the words and phrases contained in Xi Jinping's interviews, while the procedures are determined by the cognitive mapping framework. In order to adhere to standard practices in political science, explicit coding rules developed by Margaret Tucker Wrightson for cognitive mapping theory are followed to ensure the validity and reliability of the research process (Wrightson, 1976, pp. 291–332; Van Esch et al., 2016, pp. 14–21; Van Esch and Snellens, 2024, p. 434). Overall, Xi's interview texts are treated as data to be coded systematically, while the anal-

ysis and interpretation of those codes draw on cognitive theory and an understanding of the relationships among concepts.

As noted above, the unit of analysis in this study is the linkage between concepts. Each unit consists of a causal concept, an outcome concept, and the causal linkage connecting them. This linkage is directional, indicating that a change in one variable or concept is believed to bring about a change in another. The linkage may be positive (increasing) or negative (decreasing) (Axelrod, 1976, p. 68). Within this theoretical framework, this directionality is referred to as valence (Axelrod, 1976, p. 115). The concepts, ideas, or issues that are coded are referred to—by analogy with graph theory—as nodes or vertices, while the causal connections established between them are termed links or edges (Axelrod, 1976, p. 60). During the coding process, each relevant textual passage that expresses a causal or explanatory relationship is identified, the causal and outcome concepts are extracted, and the valence of the linkage between them is determined.

Axelrod also employs additional types of valence, such as non-negative or non-positive valence (which are neither neutral nor strictly positive or negative, but incline toward one of them), as well as ambivalence, defined as the simultaneous presence of positive and negative relationships between two nodes (Axelrod, 1976, p. 295). However, the present study does not incorporate these relatively rare cases into its calculations and instead restricts the coding scheme to three categories: positive, negative, and neutral.

2.7.3 Concept Integration and Consistency

The next step in the coding process involves the concept integration and standardization of causal and outcome concepts. Because different expressions may be used across speeches and interviews to refer to a single underlying idea, a post-coding concept integration procedure is required. For example, terms such as “economic growth,” “economic development,” and “increase in gross domestic product,” if they refer to the same underlying concept, are merged into a single conceptual node. At this stage, synonymous or highly similar concepts are grouped together, and one representative term is selected as the standard label. The advantage of concept integration is that the resulting cognitive map exhibits a clearer and more comparable structure, in which each conceptual node is unique and the accurate depiction of frequencies and relationships becomes possible. The aim of this process is to strike a balance: overly fine-grained expressions are merged into broader categories, while meaningful distinctions are preserved.

2.7.4 Map Construction

The next step is constructing the cognitive map. The first stage in mapping involves organizing the coded data into an adjacency matrix. This step is carried out using Excel, where each row contains three columns: the causal concept node, the effect concept node, and the directional link indicating the valence of the relationship.

On the basis of these data, the network visualization software Gephi (Bastian et al., 2009) is used to generate graphical cognitive maps. Gephi allows the construction of network graphs by importing conceptual nodes and their directed edges. In the resulting cognitive map, nodes represent concepts and arrows (edges) represent causal linkages between them. Each arrow is marked to indicate its valence; for greater clarity, color coding or symbolic notation may be used (for example, green or “+” for positive effects and red or “-” for negative effects). The software adjusts the thickness of arrows in proportion to the weight of each linkage, so that causal relationships mentioned more frequently appear more prominently, indicating greater emphasis in Xi’s discourse.

For spatial layout, Gephi offers algorithms such as ForceAtlas2, which simulate the network as a system of springs: connected nodes are drawn closer together, while unconnected nodes are pushed apart, producing an intuitive visual clustering.

However, in cognitive mapping, visual representation itself constitutes part of the data analysis. The relative position of each node, the nature of its connections, and its placement within the overall map all contribute to interpretation. Axelrod argues that, where possible, maps should be drawn so that arrows move from left to right, nodes should be arranged to minimize crossing arrows, policy-choice variables should be placed on the left side of the map, and overall utility variables should appear on the right (Axelrod, 1976, p. 62). While visual representation does not alter the informational content of the map, changes in layout can influence interpretation, a point consistent with principles from graph theory. For this reason, in the present study Gephi’s automated layout algorithms are not used for the final visualization. Instead, the spatial arrangement of the final cognitive map is adjusted manually in accordance with the substantive interpretation of the data.

2.7.5 Interpretation and Analysis

Once the cognitive map has been constructed, the final stage involves interpreting the data in light of the research questions. The interpretation of cognitive maps is always accompanied by methodological caveats. As Axelrod explains, this method should not be treated as a tool for uncovering individuals’ “true inner beliefs,” since cognitive mapping—like other approaches based on the analysis of speech and writing—can only generate infer-

ences about beliefs from actors' conscious and controlled linguistic behavior (Axelrod, 1976, p. 252). Van Esch and Snellens likewise emphasize that cognitive maps alone are insufficient to demonstrate causality. What this method provides are "testable expectations" about policies derived from extracted beliefs. In their study, expectations generated from Dutch leaders' cognitive maps corresponded closely with subsequent policy choices, demonstrating the method's predictive validity (Van Esch & Snellens, 2024, p. 441). Nevertheless, establishing causality requires combining cognitive mapping with additional methods such as process tracing (Van Esch & Snellens, 2024, p. 446).

Accordingly, in the present study Xi Jinping's cognitive map is analyzed solely as a representation of his causal and normative logic during the period 1989–2002, rather than as a comprehensive reflection of his inner beliefs.

During interpretation, the structure of the cognitive map and the strength of connections are used to distinguish between core and peripheral beliefs. The temporal context of the interviews is also taken into account in assessing the potential influence of historical events on these beliefs (Van Esch & Snellens, 2024, p. 440). In some cases, due to the complexity of the map, the R programming language²⁰ (R Core Team, 2025) and the *igraph* network analysis library (Csárdi et al., 2025) are employed to conduct calculations aimed at identifying structural relationships among nodes and detecting related clusters. Finally, these findings are used to address the study's subsidiary research questions. The answers to these questions generate testable expectations that can be employed in process tracing, ultimately allowing the study to assess whether perceptions played a causal role in the adoption of the policy in question.

2.7.6 Causal Inference through Process Tracing

The use of cognitive mapping theory to demonstrate a causal relationship between perceptions and outcomes is incomplete unless it is tested through process tracing (Van Esch & Snellens, 2024, p. 431). At this stage, the empirical findings derived from the cognitive map are employed as evidentiary inputs in a process-tracing analysis, through which the causal relationship between perceptions and the final decision is examined and the research hypothesis is put to the test.

To establish a causal link between a perceptual cause and an outcome, the research design must provide evidence that: (1) the decision-maker held specific perceptions; (2) those perceptions shaped the decisions taken—in other words, that evidence of a causal mechanism of influence exists; and (3) those perceptions cannot be reduced to the material features of the decision-making context, meaning that the independent variable must be

²⁰R: A Language and Environment for Statistical Computing.

shown to be exogenous (Bennett & Checkel, 2015, p. 45). Process tracing is a method well suited to testing such evidence.

Process tracing is often likened to the work of a detective. In solving a murder case, a detective gathers clues and evidence and constructs a narrative explaining who committed the crime. The detective then determines which sequences of events, behaviors, and motives point toward particular suspects and which exonerate others (Huddleston et al., 2022, p. 284). In the present study, answers to the subsidiary research questions are used to construct a narrative explaining how Xi Jinping's perceptions led to the launch of the Belt and Road Initiative. Through process tracing, evidence is then marshaled to demonstrate the plausibility of this narrative. In this way, a causal relationship between Xi's perceptions and the Belt and Road Initiative can be specified, thereby addressing the study's main research question.

Large-scale policies such as the Belt and Road Initiative typically emerge from the convergence of multiple objectives. In other words, they are usually adopted in pursuit of a variety of goals and cannot be reduced to a single causal factor. The different objectives that might plausibly explain China's adoption of this strategy, and the arguments supporting them, have been examined in the literature review. The aim of the present study is not to reject the causal relevance of these alternative explanations, but rather to show that, taken on their own, they are insufficient to account for all dimensions of this major initiative, and that one important causal element in its formation was Xi Jinping's perceptions. Put differently, a different leader, holding different perceptions, might have pursued similar objectives through different means, and these differences in approach would in turn have produced different outcomes. Accordingly, the focus of this section is on evaluating the validity of the study's hypothesis rather than on refuting alternative explanations. Process tracing provides the methodological tools necessary for undertaking this task.

Process tracing is a method designed to study causal mechanisms in single-case research (Beach & Pedersen, 2019, p. 2). Three main variants of process tracing have been identified, and the approach adopted in this study is theory-testing process tracing. In this variant, the researcher derives a theory from the existing literature and then examines whether evidence of the hypothesized causal mechanism can be identified in a particular case. This approach enables within-case inference by assessing whether the mechanism was present and operated as expected. However, it does not allow the researcher to claim that the mechanism under investigation was the sole cause of the observed outcome (Beach & Pedersen, 2019).

In other words, this type of process tracing does not permit a systematic comparison of competing mechanisms and is applied exclusively to the hypothesis under examination (Beach & Pedersen, 2019, p. 15). The method proceeds in three steps. The first step

involves the conceptual specification of the hypothesized causal mechanism, explaining how the independent variable leads to the dependent variable. The second step consists of operationalizing the hypothesized mechanism; that is, translating theoretical expectations into concrete, observable predictions whose presence would indicate that the components of the mechanism are at work in the case under study. The third step entails the collection and testing of empirical evidence. At this stage, the researcher examines whether the hypothesized mechanism is present in the case and, if so, whether it operates in the manner predicted in the second step. Testing the evidence in this final step allows the researcher to draw causal inferences and to increase or decrease confidence in the validity of the hypothesis (Beach & Pedersen, 2019, p. 14).

In the first step of theory-testing process tracing, the researcher must conceptually re-construct the hypothesized causal mechanism linking cause and outcome. This involves clearly defining the cause and the outcome, specifying the context and conditions under which the mechanism is expected to operate, and formulating the stages or components of the mechanism. In other words, the researcher identifies the relevant “actors,” “activities,” and “causal linkages” that logically connect the cause to the outcome. At this stage, no data are yet collected; instead, drawing on existing theory and logical reasoning, the researcher develops a clear and testable causal model that will guide the subsequent steps of process tracing (Beach & Pedersen, 2019, p. 14).

In the next stage, the causal mechanism is operationalized. This means specifying what observable evidence should be expected if each component of the mechanism is indeed present. The purpose of operationalization is to clarify how the hypothesized mechanism can be empirically tested. Put differently, the researcher must clearly identify what kinds of evidence would indicate the presence of each assumed component of the causal mechanism (Beach & Pedersen, 2019, p. 100).

To demonstrate causal inference within process tracing, four types of evidentiary tests are employed: the straw-in-the-wind test, the hoop test, the smoking-gun test, and the doubly decisive test. These tests are rooted in the Bayesian logic underlying process tracing.²¹ In this framework, the inferential strength of evidence depends on two criteria: (1) how unique the evidence is to a given hypothesis, and (2) how necessary the evidence is according to that hypothesis. Different combinations of necessity and uniqueness give rise to the four types of tests, each of which offers a different capacity to confirm a hypothesis or to rule out rival explanations. Evidence that is necessary but not unique can only eliminate hypotheses (hoop test). Evidence that is unique but not necessary can strongly support a

²¹Bayesian logic refers to an inferential approach in which the plausibility of a hypothesis is updated dynamically in light of new evidence. The researcher begins with a prior belief regarding a given explanation and then revises this belief—either strengthening or weakening it—as additional evidence is incorporated, ultimately arriving at an updated posterior probability.

hypothesis if observed (smoking-gun test), but its absence does not necessarily weaken the hypothesis. Evidence that is both necessary and unique provides very strong leverage for both confirming and disconfirming hypotheses (doubly decisive test). Finally, evidence that is neither necessary nor unique has weak inferential value (straw-in-the-wind test), although the accumulation of several such weak pieces of evidence can nonetheless clarify the overall causal direction (Bennett & Checkel, 2015, pp. 16–17).

Given the perceptual nature of the causal variable under investigation, the evidence must also satisfy the three conditions outlined at the outset of this discussion.²² The cognitive map and the inferences derived from it constitute a type of smoking-gun test. Because these inferences are drawn directly from Xi Jinping's own statements and can only be observed if such perceptions genuinely exist, they possess a high degree of uniqueness: they cannot plausibly be attributed to factors other than Xi's perceptions. However, evidence derived from cognitive mapping is not necessary evidence, since its absence does not necessarily imply the absence of such perceptions and may instead reflect data limitations or analytical shortcomings. For this reason, cognitive mapping evidence is classified as a smoking-gun test and, as such, cannot by itself invalidate alternative explanations for the launch of the Belt and Road Initiative.

Ultimately, by testing the results of the cognitive map through the steps outlined above, it becomes possible to demonstrate in a rigorous manner the existence of a causal relationship between the extracted perceptions and the initiation of the Belt and Road Initiative.

2.8 Conclusion

This chapter, by reviewing various theories, examines the theoretical challenges in studying the Belt and Road Initiative and explains why cognitive mapping theory was chosen as the theoretical framework for this research. It also clarifies the application of this theory for conducting the study by explaining the research methodology and outlines the research pathway necessary to answer the research questions.

In this study, cognitive mapping is employed as an effective tool for representing the causal and normative logic of political leaders. Through the analysis of verbal and written data, this method allows the identification of key concepts and the way they are interconnected in the mindset of a political actor. As discussed in the theoretical sections, cognitive maps should primarily be considered as hypotheses about the mental structure of leaders, whose validity is assessed by tracing how they influence actual actions and policies. From

²²Evidence of the existence of perceptions, their influence on decisions, and the inability to explain the evidence solely through material factors.

this perspective, the present chapter establishes a methodological foundation to systematically and reliably analyze Xi Jinping's thinking in the subsequent stages of the research.

In accordance with the theoretical and methodological requirements outlined, Xi's perceptions must be extracted through qualitative content analysis of selected texts and then tested by tracing their influence on decision-making. To this end, Chapter Three examines Xi Jinping's biography and explains China's challenges in the domestic and international political arenas, providing the necessary information to understand the cognitive map and to implement process-tracing in the subsequent chapters.

Chapter 3

Xi Jinping in the Context of China's Transformations (1990–2012)

3.1 Introduction

This chapter seeks to examine China's political and economic transformations in both the domestic and international arenas by situating them within a historical and personal framework, while also introducing Xi Jinping's lived experiences during his period of political ascent. To this end, the chapter is divided into two main sections: the first addresses China's domestic and external transformations, and the second focuses on Xi Jinping's political life.

The first section examines China's domestic socio-economic requirements, the political currents involved, and the international constraints that shaped policy choices. The scope of this analysis is limited to developments that ultimately contributed to the adoption of the Belt and Road Initiative. By analyzing internal socio-economic imperatives, relevant political forces, and international requirements, this section seeks to trace the domestic and international drivers that motivated the formation of the initiative.

The second section provides a concise account of Xi Jinping's personal and political life. It examines the experiences and developments that contributed to his political advancement and the formation of his ideas. This section not only offers a clear depiction of the trajectory of Xi's political rise, but also explains the underlying political context of the period, thereby addressing not only how his ascent occurred, but also why it unfolded in this particular manner.

Overall, Chapter Three clarifies why and how Xi Jinping rose to power, and the decision-making environment he confronted after attaining leadership. In doing so, it establishes the necessary groundwork for addressing the research questions examined in Chapter Four.

3.2 China's Political–Economic Transformations (1990–2012)

China entered the 1990s while confronting the domestic and international repercussions of the suppression of the Tiananmen Square protests. Domestically, the Tiananmen protests had unsettled the country's political atmosphere. Internationally, the fall of the Berlin Wall and the collapse of communist regimes in Eastern Europe cast doubt on communism as a viable political system (S. Hu, 1994, p. 796). Within the Party, leftist factions attributed the protests to deviations from Mao Zedong's methods, while protesters themselves demanded greater civil and political freedoms. These dynamics frightened foreign investors and led to capital withdrawal from the Chinese market, while the violent suppression of the Tiananmen protests resulted in the imposition of various sanctions against China. Deng Xiaoping linked domestic unrest and external pressure, interpreting the prevailing situation as part of an unavoidable process shaped by both internal and international conditions (S. Hu, 1994, p. 795).

It was under these circumstances that Deng Xiaoping undertook his “Southern Tour” in 1992 in an effort to resolve internal divisions within China (Brown, 2016, p. 71). The Southern Tour constituted a political–media maneuver by Deng Xiaoping aimed at weakening the Party's leftist factions and safeguarding the trajectory of China's economic reforms. Under the pretext of visiting Shanghai and the southern provinces—regions that, unlike Beijing, demonstrated greater receptiveness to reform—Deng delivered a series of speeches presenting reform as the only viable path forward for the Party. The objective of Deng's journey to the southern provinces was to mobilize coastal provincial leaders against the conservative stronghold in Beijing and to reassert control over the Party's central media apparatus (S. Zhao, 1993, p. 748).

Although this political–media maneuver is now widely known as the Southern Tour, coverage of the trip did not appear in the Party's official media until several days after the provincial visits had concluded. Only after multiple meetings between Deng and his allies with senior Party leaders were official Party documents circulated to cadres at various levels, after which media outlets gradually began to publish details of the speeches. The precise mechanisms through which Deng succeeded in forging political cohesion behind closed doors remain unclear; nevertheless, he ultimately managed to steer the Party back toward the reform path ahead of the Fourteenth National Congress of the Chinese Communist Party in 1992 (S. Zhao, 1993).

Another outcome of the Southern Tour was that it narrowed the rift among reform-minded forces within China. As reform advanced, two distinct approaches had emerged among reformists: conservative reformers who supported economic reform, and liberal

reformers who called for a theoretical reexamination of the Party's interpretation of political freedom (X. Guo, 2019, pp. 236–237). The Southern Tour clarified that there was no room for political reform, and Deng himself continued to maintain that while elements of capitalism could be utilized, China should not become capitalist. Politically, Deng never retreated from the Four Cardinal Principles—Marxism–Leninism and Mao Zedong Thought, the leadership of the Chinese Communist Party, socialism, and the dictatorship of the proletariat (S. Zhao, 1993, p. 756).

The consolidation of Deng Xiaoping's reformist vision over China's political future and developmental trajectory had two major consequences. At the international level, Western observers became convinced that China would remain communist and continue its development within its existing political–economic system. As a result, China's development—previously regarded in the West as a positive phenomenon—suddenly emerged as a source of significant concern. This moment marked the beginning of a strategic rivalry which, after decades of fluctuation and escalation, continues to shape relations between China and the United States. This issue will be examined in greater detail in the following section.

Another important consequence unfolded at the domestic level. With earlier divisions largely closed, Deng Xiaoping's followers were now afforded the opportunity to debate among themselves how economic reforms should be advanced. This process led to the emergence of two rival political currents holding divergent interpretations of how reform ought to be implemented. The remainder of this section examines these competing currents and their relationship to Xi Jinping's rise to power and the subsequent launch of the Belt and Road Initiative.

During the reform era, coastal regions in eastern and southeastern China were designated as the primary engines of economic growth. Deng Xiaoping's well-known dictum—"let some people get rich first"—conveyed a promise to the Chinese populace that although development would begin in these regions, it would gradually extend to the entire country.

The selection of coastal regions as the principal drivers of economic growth was not accidental, but rather based on geographical advantages, access to global markets, port infrastructure, and proximity to East Asian trade networks. Provinces such as Guangdong, Fujian, and Jiangsu, through the establishment of Special Economic Zones and the provision of extensive incentives for foreign investment, became the main laboratories of the policy of reform and opening up.¹ While this strategy generated unprecedented economic growth for China, it simultaneously concentrated capital, technology, and employment opportunities along the coastal belt and exacerbated regional inequality between the eastern, central, and western parts of the country (Tian, 2004, p. 611).

¹ 改革开放 (*Gǎigé Kāifàng*).



Figure 3.1: Map of China's regions

Note. Reprinted from “China Develops Its West: Motivation, Strategy and Prospect,” by Q. Tian, 2004, *Journal of Contemporary China*, 13(41), pp. 611–636 (<https://doi.org/10.1080/1067056042000281404>). Copyright 2004 by Taylor & Francis. Reprinted with permission.

At the same time, the coastal provinces—and the Chinese economy more broadly—were confronted with a structural challenge. During this period, China's export-led growth could no longer rely solely on low value-added industries, and the need for technological upgrading, market diversification, and direct access to strategic assets became increasingly evident. The emergence of the Asian financial crisis, the declining absorptive capacity of regional markets, expectations surrounding accession to the World Trade Organization, and mounting pressure over the valuation of the renminbi placed growing strain on economic decision-makers (Shen & Mantzopoulos, 2013, pp. 129–130). In addition, state-owned enterprises were facing significant difficulties, as excess production capacity and non-performing loans increasingly weighed on their performance (M. Ye, 2020, p. 40).

By the late 1990s, the consequences of China's unbalanced development model and the need to upgrade the country's position within global value chains had become politicized. On the one hand, state-owned enterprises were required to sustain development through outward investment; on the other hand, western and central provinces—which received only a limited share of state investment and foreign trade flows—remained economically underdeveloped and confronted widespread poverty, infrastructural deficiencies, social discontent, and, in several sensitive regions, security and ethnic challenges. These tensions contributed to the emergence of two distinct political currents commonly referred to as the “Shanghai Gang”² and the “League faction”³.

The categorization of the Shanghai Gang and the League faction is, in the first instance, based on the political origins of their members. The Shanghai Gang refers to officials who advanced under Jiang Zemin during his tenure as mayor of Shanghai in the mid-1980s and subsequently rose alongside him as he reached the apex of Party power (C. Li, 2001, p. 1). By contrast, the League faction denotes leaders whose political advancement proceeded through the Communist Youth League of China.⁴ Hu Jintao and many of his close associates have roots in the Youth League, and figures such as Li Keqiang⁵ rose directly with Hu's support (C. Li, 2016, p. 279).

What truly distinguishes these two groupings, however, is the marked divergence in their approaches to development and policymaking. The Shanghai Gang, whose principal base lay in prosperous coastal regions and major metropolitan centers, continued to emphasize rapid growth, high efficiency, and the leading role of eastern regions. From this perspective, any redistribution of resources should not undermine the competitive advantages of coastal provinces or reduce the pace of economic expansion. Accordingly, the Shanghai Gang prioritizes rapid growth, efficiency, and the economic interests of coastal regions,

² 上海帮 (*Shànghǎi Bāng*).

³ 团派 (*Tuánpài*).

⁴ 中国共产主义青年团 (*Zhōngguó Gòngchǎn Zhǔyì Qīngnián Tuán*).

⁵ 李克强 (*Lǐ Kèqiáng*). A close associate of Hu Jintao who later served as Xi Jinping's premier.

even at the cost of widening inequality. By contrast, the League faction—whose representatives possessed extensive administrative experience in inland and less-developed areas—stressed the necessity of active state intervention to reduce inequality, strengthen social justice, and prevent the marginalization of western regions. The League faction emphasizes social justice, cohesion, and balanced development, and is willing, if necessary, to temper the pace of economic growth in order to mitigate social inequality. In this sense, the League faction adopts a more populist and socially oriented approach, whereas the Shanghai Gang places greater emphasis on economic efficiency and urban elites (C. Li, 2009, 2012).

The outcome of this contestation was the emergence of a form of unstable compromise in policymaking. China's leadership concluded that the continuation of economic growth would face serious structural constraints without the active expansion of Chinese firms' presence abroad, in a process in which coastal provinces were expected to play a pivotal role. At the same time, however, the persistence of a coast-centered development model without corrective intervention risked undermining both the Party's political legitimacy and the country's territorial cohesion. In response to these concerns, two major strategies were articulated: the "Western Development Strategy"⁶ and the "Go Out" policy⁷. Although both strategies were accepted in principle by the two rival political currents, each faction prioritized one over the other in accordance with its own developmental logic. The following sections examine these two strategies in turn.

3.2.1 Western Development Strategy

The Western Development Strategy encompassed a set of coordinated and multi-layered measures. Its objective was not to abandon coastal growth, but to complement it by integrating China's underdeveloped western regions into the national economy (H. H. Lai, 2002). At the infrastructural level, the central government undertook large-scale investments in transportation networks, highways, railway lines, and energy and water-supply projects in order to reduce the geographical constraints on development in western regions. At the institutional level, systems of fiscal transfers and tax exemptions were designed to make investment in western provinces more attractive to both state-owned and private enterprises. In addition, the policy of provincial pairing—commonly referred to as the "hand-in-hand aid" or counterpart support policy⁸—was implemented, under which more developed coastal provinces were required to assist less-developed regions through the transfer of capital, technology, and human resources. This mechanism effectively repre-

⁶西部大开发 (*Xībù Dàkāifā*).

⁷走出去 (*Zǒu Chūqù*).

⁸对口支援 (*Duikǒu Zhīyuán*).

sented an effort to redistribute the benefits of growth without disrupting the overall framework of a market-oriented economy (Lu & Deng, 2011).

The Western Development Strategy reflected official recognition of the problem of inequality and the necessity of state intervention—an emphasis closely aligned with the discourse of the League faction. At the same time, however, this strategy never entailed a fundamental reordering of development priorities. Growth in the eastern regions continued to be preserved as the principal engine of China's economy, a position more compatible with the logic of the Shanghai Gang. In this sense, western development was defined not as a substitute for coastal development, but as its complement: a middle-ground solution that sought to ensure social stability and national cohesion without sacrificing the momentum of economic growth.

Although the Western Development Strategy was introduced during the Jiang Zemin era, it achieved limited success in advancing western development under his leadership. Despite extensive political publicity, the development gap between coastal and western provinces widened between the announcement of the strategy and 2003. While the central government introduced incentive schemes for investors in western provinces, it simultaneously offered more favorable policies to coastal regions (M. Ye, 2020, p. 64). Ye argues, however, that given the government's emphasis on market forces, the widening of this gap was not primarily the result of state intervention, but rather of market mechanisms (M. Ye, 2020, p. 66).

By contrast, Hu Jintao placed greater emphasis on addressing poverty and rural issues and continued Jiang's policies with respect to western development. More specifically, he extended funding for infrastructural projects initiated under the Western Development Strategy and allocated substantial additional financial resources to these regions. Moreover, Hu sought to channel direct investment from coastal provinces toward western regions. This approach was consistent with his administration's broader policy orientation toward promoting technology-intensive industries. Labor-intensive industries were gradually relocated to western provinces, while coastal regions were prepared to accommodate higher value-added, technology-based sectors. Once this structural stabilization of the economy had taken shape, the government redirected fiscal resources toward education, poverty alleviation, and environmental protection in these regions (M. Ye, 2020, p. 69).

Overall, the Western Development Strategy proved largely successful during Hu Jintao's tenure and achieved its principal objectives. During this period, the development gap between coastal and western provinces narrowed, and economically robust enterprises emerged in western regions. Although the 2008 global financial crisis and the excess production capacity generated by government fiscal stimulus created challenges for these

provinces, these difficulties were not sufficient to call the overall success of the strategy into question.

Nevertheless, by the time Xi Jinping assumed power, China was confronting financial pressures and a relative economic slowdown. These conditions generated concerns regarding the sustainability of western development, and many projects approved under the Western Development Strategy were left in a state of uncertainty. Rather than abandoning this strategy, Xi Jinping introduced the Silk Road Economic Belt, which geographically overlapped with the western regions, and assigned the central body responsible for coordinating the Western Development Strategy to oversee the implementation of the Belt and Road Initiative as a whole (M. Ye, 2020, p. 74).

3.2.2 Go Out Strategy

Alongside the Western Development Strategy—which was primarily a response to domestic territorial inequalities—the Go Out strategy sought to address the structural constraints facing Chinese enterprises through the active expansion of their presence abroad. Under this strategy, the state encouraged economic actors, particularly state-owned enterprises, to take their business operations and investments overseas.

The objective of this policy was to upgrade China's position within global value chains (Shen & Mantzopoulos, 2013). Through this strategy, China sought to achieve a range of goals, including the relocation of low value-added segments of production abroad, access to scarce natural resources, the creation of outward investment capacity, the enhancement of national brands, and relief from pressures associated with excess production capacity and anti-dumping accusations. Five core components of this policy can be identified: the utilization of external resources, the development of offshore processing chains, the strengthening of financial and legal support systems, regional cooperation, and the enhancement of the global recognition of Chinese brands (Zhu & Pickles, 2014, pp. 56–57). In other words, the Go Out strategy constituted a strategic response to the necessity of China's transition from a purely production-oriented economy to an international actor grounded in technology, capital intensity, and resource acquisition—a transition in which outward foreign investment, global mergers and acquisitions, and the construction of transnational production networks became key instruments.

The Go Out strategy and the ideas associated with it more closely reflected Jiang Zemin's policy outlook. Under the pressure generated by sanctions imposed by the United States and the European Union, Jiang advocated diversification into international markets. In Jiang's view, by mobilizing both domestic and international markets and resources to achieve development, the country would become strong and thereby capable of addressing any global challenge (M. Ye, 2020, p. 93).

Jiang believed that alongside attracting foreign investors and facilitating the entry of foreign firms into China, Chinese enterprises themselves should expand abroad and draw on external resources and markets to sustain growth. Through this process, excess production capacity could be transferred overseas, while structural weaknesses of the Chinese economy could be mitigated through the inflow of foreign firms and investment. In this way, deeper engagement with globalization and integration into international regimes would smooth China's path toward continued development.

Efforts by Chinese state-owned enterprises to invest abroad, however, were accompanied by substantial challenges. State-owned firms were held accountable for the returns on these investments, and corporate managers were required to respond to concerns regarding the preservation of state assets. At the same time, their projects were subject to multilayered and parallel bureaucratic oversight, which complicated and often delayed implementation. Moreover, managers were expected to operate simultaneously as political actors, taking into account the political ramifications of overseas projects (M. Ye, 2020, pp. 96–109). In developed countries, nationalist discourses surrounding the Go Out strategy generated suspicion and resistance toward Chinese investment. In developing countries, Chinese activities were frequently met with accusations of neo-colonialism and concerns over social and environmental damage.

With Xi Jinping's rise to power, the Go Out strategy was incorporated into the Belt and Road Initiative. In 2017, Hu Xiaolian—former director of the State Administration of Foreign Exchange, one of the key institutions involved in the Go Out strategy—was appointed chairwoman and Party secretary of the Export–Import Bank of China, the principal financial provider for Belt and Road projects (M. Ye, 2020). Through this institutional realignment, the two strategies of “Western Development” and “Going Out” were ultimately integrated within the framework of the Belt and Road Initiative.

The Belt and Road Initiative has, in turn, become entangled in many of the same international debates that had previously surrounded the Go Out strategy. Distrust toward Chinese investment, accusations of neo-colonialism, and related concerns have continued to cast a shadow over the implementation of the initiative. These international challenges confronting China's development have gradually fed back into considerations of domestic legitimacy.

First, the Chinese Communist Party historically relied on factors such as victory in the Second World War, the expulsion of foreign occupiers from China, and communist ideology to legitimize its rule. With the onset of reform and the declining salience of revolutionary credentials, however, the Party increasingly came to rely on economic performance as the primary source of political legitimacy. Consequently, the continuation of economic

growth acquired existential importance for the regime. As noted earlier, sustained growth itself depends heavily on China's interaction with the international economy.

Second, Western countries initially expected that the launch of economic reforms in China would ultimately lead to social development and, in turn, to a transition away from communism and a broader ideological and political transformation. The suppression of the Tiananmen Square protests in 1989, combined with diplomatic disputes over territorial claims in the South China Sea and the persistence of tensions with Taiwan, transformed earlier positive perceptions of China's development into serious concerns. In other words, from the early 1990s onward, China's economic development—which had previously been viewed in the West as a positive phenomenon—gradually came to be regarded as a source of apprehension. These concerns manifested themselves in the form of diplomatic tensions, foreign policy crises, and various sanctions.

As Western attitudes toward China's development shifted, and given China's continued reliance on Western countries for sustaining growth, Chinese foreign policy became indirectly linked to the Party's domestic legitimacy. The defense of China's international image thus gradually emerged as a policy priority. The following section examines changes in China's foreign policy orientation and analyzes their relationship with development, legitimacy, and domestic political currents.

3.3 China's International Challenges (1990–2012)

The suppression of the Tiananmen Square protests and the disappearance of prospects for political reform in China fundamentally altered the nature of international debates surrounding China's development. The interaction between China's domestic politics and the international order became a central theme in the international relations literature and has remained so to the present day. The most prominent debate within this context is the so-called “China threat” discourse.⁹ A wide range of arguments—advanced at the levels of the international system, the region, the state, and leaders' perceptions—have been put forward both in support of and in opposition to the notion of China as a threat, and more than two decades later, these debates continue unabated.

The issue of the “China threat” was first raised in the United States in early 1993 (Yee & Storey, 2005, p. 2). Proponents of this view argue that China's rapid economic growth will naturally translate into increased military power and, ultimately, aggressive and revisionist behavior in foreign policy. From this perspective, the substantial rise in defense spending, the modernization of the People's Liberation Army (Roy, 1996, p. 760), and

⁹In Chinese usage, theories that portray China's development as a threat are commonly grouped under the umbrella term “China threat theory.”

China's firm positions on issues such as Taiwan and the South China Sea are interpreted as indicators of Beijing's ambition to assume a dominant role in the regional order (Yee & Storey, 2005, p. 4). Some portray China, as the last remaining communist great power, as an ideological threat to the West, while others contend that China's strategic culture is grounded in *Realpolitik* and treats the use of force as a primary instrument of statecraft (Yee & Storey, 2005, p. 9).

Others question the analytical relevance of intentions altogether. They emphasize that even if Chinese leaders proclaim peaceful intentions, the structural logic of the international system and the historical experience of great powers suggest that a rising power, as its material capabilities expand, will seek to redefine the balance of power in its favor. From this standpoint, the principal threat does not stem from China's declared intentions, but from the unavoidable consequences of its power ascent (Roy, 1996, p. 769).

In response to this perspective, a diverse set of counterarguments has been advanced, ranging from systemic arguments that emphasize China's economic interdependence with other states as a constraining factor against conflict (Roy, 1996, p. 762), to views that regard the Confucian roots of China's strategic culture as inhibiting recourse to coercion and force (Roy, 1996, p. 763). This debate encompasses nearly all major theoretical dimensions of international relations and foreign policy analysis and has raised fundamental questions for which no clear consensus has yet emerged, most notably whether China's rapid rise constitutes a positive development for the international system or a destabilizing and potentially harmful force.

Early formulations of the China threat theory—prior to Chinese scholars subsuming a wide range of similar arguments under this single label—often drew an analogy between China and Nazi Germany. According to this line of reasoning, China's rapid rise at the beginning of the twenty-first century resembled Germany's ascent in the early twentieth century. The argument held that China, like Germany, was a humiliated yet arrogant power that would resort to any means necessary to restore its lost grandeur. Economic growth would inevitably lead to military expansion, and the rise of a power such as China would unavoidably disrupt the existing balance of power in the international system (Jeffery, 2009, p. 313).

By contrast, Chinese analysts argued that this view was fundamentally flawed. From their perspective, China was a backward developing country with a relatively moderate military that merely required modernization for defensive purposes. Chinese analyses examined the China threat theory across three dimensions—military, economic, and cultural—and subsequently rejected it. They portrayed China as a developing country with a peace-loving population and contended that, rather than interpreting China's rise through Western international relations theories derived from the violent rise and fall of European

great powers, it should be understood within the context of peace and stability in the East Asian regional order. Ultimately, these analyses concluded that the China threat theory was a Western construct advanced by actors who, in the post–Cold War world, continued to cling to Cold War modes of thinking. Moreover, they argued that the United States needed to recognize the fallacy of its so-called “enemy deprivation syndrome,” which had driven it to seek a substitute for the Soviet threat in the form of China. From the Chinese perspective, therefore, those who regarded China as a potential threat were mistaken both empirically and theoretically (Callahan, 2005, p. 706).

3.3.1 Accommodation under Jiang Zemin

During the 1990s, China largely sought to disregard these debates and to maintain its focus on development. This approach was rooted in Deng Xiaoping’s strategy of keeping a low profile and pursuing progress quietly. In this period, China’s responses to foreign policy crises were highly flexible and, in some cases, deliberately accommodating.

A notable example is the 1993 *Yinhe incident*, in which the Clinton administration accused China of transporting materials for the production of chemical weapons to Iran aboard a Chinese cargo vessel. Washington disabled the ship’s GPS system, forced it to anchor in the Indian Ocean, and urged regional states to deny it permission to dock. Ultimately, China allowed a joint American–Saudi inspection team to board the vessel. Although the United States failed to find any evidence supporting its allegations, it neither issued an apology nor provided compensation. In response, Jiang Zemin adopted a policy of goodwill and articulated a sixteen-character formula¹⁰ for managing relations with the United States, which emphasized increasing mutual trust, reducing sources of friction, strengthening cooperation, and avoiding confrontation.¹¹ As a further gesture of goodwill—and aware of President Clinton’s interest in playing the saxophone—Jiang presented him with a finely crafted saxophone as a gift (S. Zhao, 2023, p. 63).

Another major crisis concerned the unofficial visit of Taiwan’s president (Republic of China), Lee Teng-hui, to Washington in 1995. Lee was a graduate of Cornell University and, at the invitation of the university, intended to deliver a speech on Taiwan’s democratic achievements. Despite the opposition of the People’s Republic of China, the U.S. Congress adopted a resolution calling for the issuance of a visa to Lee. In protest, Beijing recalled its ambassador from Washington and conducted missile exercises in the vicinity of Taiwan. These developments marked the onset of the Third Taiwan Strait Crisis (Shao, 2022, p. 542).

¹⁰It is common in Chinese political language and culture to formulate slogans and policy principles in a fixed number of characters.

¹¹增加信任 (*zēngjiā xìnren*, “increase trust”), 减小麻烦 (*jiǎnxiǎo máfan*, “reduce troubles”), 加强合作 (*jiāqiáng hézuò*, “strengthen cooperation”), 不搞对抗 (*bù gǎo duìkàng*, “avoid confrontation”).

According to some scholars, Lee's move fell only one step short of a declaration of Taiwanese independence (Johnston & Ross, 2006, p. 73). Although this episode is referred to as the Third Taiwan Strait Crisis, its intensity differed markedly from the previous two crises. In the earlier crises, the People's Liberation Army shelled Taiwan-controlled islands to such an extent that ammunition supplies were reportedly exhausted. By contrast, during the third crisis, China limited its actions to military exercises, and some accounts suggest that Beijing had even reassured Taiwan in advance that no direct threat was intended. This decision was not reached easily. The military exerted significant pressure on Jiang Zemin, to the extent that during this period he reportedly received up to eight hundred angry letters per day from officers protesting Lee Teng-hui's visit to the United States. In one Politburo meeting, Jiang reportedly reproached himself for adopting an overly conciliatory policy toward Taiwan (K. He, 2016, p. 58). The crisis ultimately subsided after assurances by President Clinton regarding adherence to the One China policy.

Another foreign policy crisis that elicited a restrained response from Jiang was the 1999 bombing of the Chinese embassy in Belgrade during the Kosovo War. Two U.S. B-2 bombers dropped five two-thousand-pound bombs on the Chinese embassy, killing three Chinese journalists and injuring twenty other Chinese citizens. In response, intense anti-American protests erupted in China, causing damage to the U.S. embassy in Beijing and the consulate in Chengdu. This period also coincided with U.S. opposition to China's accession to the World Trade Organization and the leakage of a report from Washington accusing China of stealing U.S. nuclear secrets (K. He, 2016, p. 70). Under these circumstances, a failure to respond firmly to the embassy bombing risked undermining Jiang Zemin's standing in domestic politics. Accordingly, China's foreign minister articulated four demands to the United States: (1) a formal apology to the Chinese government and people, including the families of those killed and injured; (2) a comprehensive investigation of the incident; (3) the immediate release of the investigation's findings; and (4) severe punishment of those responsible (K. He, 2016, p. 73). In response, the United States acceded to parts of these demands: President Clinton issued an apology, the U.S. investigation attributed the incident to outdated maps, and Washington agreed to pay financial compensation. Nevertheless, Jiang's most significant achievement in the aftermath of the crisis was the finalization of China's accession agreement to the World Trade Organization (K. He, 2016, p. 75).

The above examples clearly indicate that Jiang's primary focus during this period was the continuation of development rather than engagement in international political confrontations. Indeed, it appears that even the level of response that did occur was driven less by Jiang's own preferences than by pressures related to domestic political legitimacy.

Nevertheless, by the late 1990s, China concluded that simply ignoring these debates would not cause them to disappear. Accordingly, Beijing institutionalized a system of regular press conferences and developed a range of communication programs aimed at responding rapidly to what it characterized as “false” accusations or “misleading” information directed against China. Although the International Communication Office of the CCP Central Committee¹², also known as the State Council Information Office¹³, had held annual national conferences on external propaganda since its establishment in January 1991 (Ding, 2011), more systematic and substantive responses at both the governmental and scholarly levels began to take shape only in the late 1990s. These efforts intensified further with the rise to power of Hu Jintao and, subsequently, Xi Jinping.

3.3.2 A Harmonious World

During Hu Jintao's tenure, the United States became deeply engaged in the wars in Iraq and Afghanistan as part of the global war on terror. This development partially reduced negative international attention toward China. In this period, China also initiated limited cooperation with the United States on counterterrorism. Overall, this era lacked the density of crises that had characterized the 1990s. As a result, the Hu administration enjoyed greater room for discursive initiatives and efforts to reshape China's international image.

One such effort was the introduction of the concept of China's “peaceful rise,” which was explicitly advanced as a response to the China threat discourse. Zheng Bijian¹⁴, who served as an advisor to both Jiang Zemin and Hu Jintao, introduced the term in late 2003 as part of the ideological framework of Hu's leadership, and it was treated for a time as official policy. Through this slogan, the Hu administration sought to portray China as a responsible actor focused primarily on domestic affairs and the improvement of its citizens' welfare, rather than on intervention in global affairs (Pathak, 2015). In an article published in *Foreign Affairs*, Zheng framed the global implications of China's peaceful rise chiefly in terms of China's role as a “huge market” for the consumption of other countries' products (Bijian, 2005, p. 24).

The slogan of China's “peaceful rise” not only failed to reassure critics, but was itself used to cast doubt on China's credibility. Critics argued in various public forums that if China's rise was truly peaceful, why did Beijing threaten the use of force against Taiwan, and why was it expanding its military capabilities? For example, U.S. Secretary of Defense Donald Rumsfeld stated in the summer of 2005: “Since no nation threatens China, one must wonder why it is increasing its [weapons] investments. Why this growing and

¹²中共中央对外宣传办公室 (*Zhōng Gònghéguó Zhōngyāng Duìwài Xuānchuán Bàngōngshì*).

¹³国务院新闻办公室 (*Guówùyuàn Xīnwén Bàngōngshì*).

¹⁴郑必坚 (*Zhèng Bìjiān*).

expanding arms procurement?” (Logan, 2011). The slogan of China's “peaceful rise” thus failed to provide a convincing response to the China threat theory. China's efforts to defend the narrative of a peaceful ascent proved ineffective, and Beijing ultimately replaced the term “rise” with “development.” The new slogan of “peaceful development” built upon Deng Xiaoping's well-established formulation of “peace and development.”¹⁵ Shortly thereafter, the Hu Jintao administration advanced the concept of a “harmonious world,”¹⁶ thereby discarding references to “rise,” “peacefulness,” and even “China” itself from Hu's discursive response to the China threat theory.

The idea of a “harmonious world” was not entirely new and bore clear similarities to Mao's concept of the “Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence.” In fact, Jiang Zemin had articulated comparable ideas toward the end of his tenure (Jiang, 2000). However, Jiang's formulations did not crystallize into a coherent foreign policy doctrine with a distinct keyword; rather, they functioned as a general orientation that was subsequently adopted and refined by later leaders.

Nevertheless, some scholars have argued that the appeal of the “harmonious world” concept lay in China's more proactive effort to articulate a normative vision of how global order ought to be structured (Poole, 2014). This concept rested on four main pillars. First, multilateralism aimed at achieving common security through the rejection of Cold War mentalities, the strengthening of collective security mechanisms centered on the United Nations, the peaceful settlement of disputes, and opposition to violations of sovereignty and external intervention, alongside cooperation on counterterrorism and arms control. Second, mutually beneficial cooperation for shared prosperity, grounded in the claim that globalization should benefit all countries, particularly developing ones. Third, inclusiveness and respect for civilizational diversity through the rejection of cultural superiority, recognition of each country's right to choose its own social system and development path, and the promotion of dialogue among civilizations in order to “democratize international relations.” Fourth, active yet cautious reform of the United Nations to enhance its authority and effectiveness, with priority given to development issues, as well as reform of the Security Council to increase representation for developing countries—especially African states—while emphasizing broad consensus in decision-making (J. Hu, 2005).

Most of Hu Jintao's initiatives were directed toward constructing a positive image of China. Indeed, these efforts were so extensive that some scholars have referred to them as the “China puzzle” (M. Li, 2019). During Hu's tenure and later under Xi Jinping, economic priorities remained central; however, Chinese international relations theorists assumed a more active role than before. As noted earlier, their efforts were largely oriented

¹⁵和平与发展 (*Héping yǔ Fāzhǎn*).

¹⁶和谐世界 (*Héxié Shìjiè*).

toward correcting what they regarded as Western empirical and theoretical misunderstandings about China.

3.3.3 A Community with a Shared Future for Mankind

Over the past two decades, the discourse of Chinese policymakers and scholars regarding the international order and China's role within it has remained markedly conservative. Much of this discussion has been articulated through frameworks such as the "harmonious world" under Hu Jintao and the "community with a shared future for mankind" under Xi Jinping. These frameworks emphasize that lasting peace can be achieved by strengthening the spirit of cooperation and interlinking the interests of states.

Xi Jinping's approach to these issues has been more proactive than that of Jiang Zemin and Hu Jintao. By advancing slogans such as the "Chinese Dream," the "community with a shared future for mankind," and by launching a range of initiatives—most prominently the Belt and Road Initiative—Xi departed from Deng Xiaoping's strategy of keeping a low profile and pursuing quiet development.

The slogan of a "community with a shared future for mankind" has become the central concept of China's foreign policy under Xi Jinping. The term was first employed in Hu Jintao's political report to the Eighteenth National Congress of the Chinese Communist Party in a section addressing the Taiwan issue. However, within days of the Congress it became evident that the concept would be applied more broadly to global affairs, referring to the necessity of mutual solidarity, shared development among nations, "collective security," and "cooperative security," among other ideas (S. Chen, 2021).

Over the past decade, this concept has been further elaborated to encompass a wider array of ideas related to global order and China's place within it. Concepts associated with global governance—such as win-win cooperation, harmonious coexistence, diversity, and mutual learning—as well as a new approach to international relations that rejects zero-sum competition and coercive behavior, have all been incorporated under the umbrella of the community with a shared future for mankind.

In essence, the concept posits that countries with different political systems and levels of development are mutually interdependent and that their interests are deeply intertwined. Together, they form a community with a shared future in which one country's destiny is inseparable from that of others (X. Zhang, 2018). Official documents further state that: "China aligns its own interests with the common interests of the people of the world and seeks to expand the shared interests of all parties. China works, across various fields and at multiple levels, to build and expand communities of shared interests with other countries and regions. China is committed to promoting the common interests of all humankind

and to bringing the benefits of human civilization to all” (Information Office of the State Council, 2011).

The idea of constructing a world in which states interact through coordination rather than competition lies at the core of China's current discourse under Xi Jinping. By advancing this perspective, Chinese scholars, think tanks, and diplomats seek not only to delegitimize the narrative that China's development constitutes a threat, but also to move the debate beyond China itself by arguing that the very practice of labeling rising powers as threats is fundamentally misguided.

In Xi-era foreign policy, the slogan of a community with a shared future for mankind has been conceptually linked to the Belt and Road Initiative. Lin Yueqin,¹⁷ a researcher at the Chinese Academy of Social Sciences,¹⁸ describes this concept in her article entitled *The Belt and Road Initiative and the Concept of a Community with a Shared Future for Mankind: China's Proposals and Global Practices* as follows:

The Belt and Road Initiative constitutes a major practical experiment and exploration toward building a community with a shared future for mankind, while simultaneously representing an important pathway to its realization. Drawing on the traditional spirit of exchange, cooperation, and shared prosperity embodied in the ancient Silk Road, the Belt and Road Initiative promotes regional development by linking the development of countries along its routes with China's own development, connecting the Chinese Dream with the dream of the world, and fostering coordinated development among participating countries. Through this process, countries form a community of shared interests, characterized by shared benefits and shared risks (Lin, 2018).

The concept of a community with a shared future for mankind now occupies a central position within “Xi Jinping Thought on Diplomacy.”¹⁹ Xi Jinping Thought on Diplomacy encapsulates China's foreign policy for the “new era.”²⁰ In 2017, Xi Jinping employed this concept in his keynote speech at the opening of the Belt and Road Forum, and in 2018 it was incorporated into the Constitution of the People's Republic of China as a core guiding value in the conduct of the Chinese Communist Party's international relations. Notably, it was positioned ahead of language affirming China's opposition to imperialism, hegemonism, and colonialism, as well as its commitment to solidarity among the peoples of the world (S. Chen, 2021).

The literature surrounding the Belt and Road Initiative, and more broadly Beijing's diplomatic discourse on foreign affairs, has consistently been conservative in tone. It is

¹⁷林跃勤 (*Lín Yuèqín*).

¹⁸中国社会科学院 (*Zhōngguó Shèhuì Kēxuéyuàn*).

¹⁹习近平外交思想 (*Xí Jìnpíng wàijiāo sīxiǎng*).

²⁰新纪元 (*xīn jìyuán*).

therefore unsurprising that strategic considerations constrain the explicit articulation of perceptions regarding global order and China's intended role within it. In other words, although China's outward discourse in this domain—both in scholarly writings and official political statements—has displayed a largely coherent continuity across the leadership of the past three generations, this discourse cannot be assumed to fully reflect the totality of leaders' underlying views. Moreover, the closed media environment and pervasive caution characteristic of the People's Republic of China significantly limit access to perspectives beyond those officially disseminated by Beijing.

Nevertheless, a body of scholarship examining China's views on the international order does exist and offers valuable insights. Analyzing this academic literature can, to some extent, circumvent the constraints imposed by official political discourse and shed light on underlying debates.

3.3.3.1 Scholarly Debates on Order

Despite China's relatively closed intellectual environment, internal debates have emerged regarding its conception of the international order and system. These debates can contribute to a deeper understanding of Chinese leaders' discourse and partially compensate for the gaps created by strategic caution. One of the most important discussions in this regard centers on a traditional concept known as *Tianxia*,²¹ which can be understood, in broad terms, as a conception analogous to global order.

Tian refers to “heaven,” while *xia* means “below”; taken together, the literal meaning of the term is “all under heaven,” or, in other words, everything that exists beneath the sky.²² In essence, the concept refers to a distinctly Chinese worldview in which the emperor is metaphorically regarded as the Son of Heaven²³ and the sovereign ruler of the entire world, with order prevailing globally through his rule. This worldview was founded on a hierarchical structure, within which all other polities were considered tributary states of the Central Kingdom²⁴. A further implication of this system was that China's relations with other polities were treated as internal affairs; consequently, China's interactions with other peoples and regions were conducted through ideas and practices analogous to those governing domestic relations (T. Zhao, 2023).

The roots of the *Tianxia* concept can be traced back to the Zhou dynasty²⁵ (1046–256 BCE). In brief, because the Zhou dynasty lacked the material capacity to establish com-

²¹天下 (*tiānxià*).

²²The correct pronunciation is achieved by combining the sounds of the English letters *T* and *N* without pause.

²³天子 (*tiān zǐ*).

²⁴中国 (*Zhōng guó*).

²⁵周朝 (*Zhōu cháo*).

plete hegemonic domination over other peoples and tribes, it constructed a global order designed to secure legitimacy and preserve peace and stability—an order open to all peoples, a world composed of all nations and for all nations. Conceptually, this system rested on three foundational ideas. First, instead of relying on coercive force to resolve problems of global politics, it depended on a universally accepted world order. Second, the political legitimacy of this order derived from institutional mechanisms that benefited all peoples. Third, such a system functioned effectively because it fostered harmony²⁶ among all nations and civilizations (T. Zhao, 2023).

Zhao Tingyang,²⁷ one of the most influential contemporary theorists of *Tianxia* in China, characterizes the main features of the *Tianxia* system in this historical period as follows:

It was an open network, or a kind of world home, composed of a general government for the world and multiple governments for sub-states. The world government was primarily responsible for maintaining order, as well as for formulating rules and regulations and mediating disputes among sub-states. The government of each sub-state—while highly autonomous—was responsible for its own domestic politics, economy, and socio-cultural affairs. Moreover, people enjoyed full freedom of movement and could work or reside in whichever sub-state they chose (Qin, 2012).

The concept of *Tianxia* stands in tension with the anarchic conception of international relations that underpins all modern international relations theories. From this Chinese perspective, the anarchic nature of international relations is a product of Westphalian sovereignty, within which all nation-states pursue their own interests, thereby generating a global order founded on competition and confrontation. By contrast, the *Tianxia* system envisions a world based on shared interests, in which unity exists alongside difference, and where, although states continue to exist, the notion of the political community ultimately encompasses all people of the world.

Chinese political scientists, philosophers, and historians have sought to integrate the *Tianxia* system into the contemporary global order, generating a range of proposals within academic debates. One prominent theorist in this regard is Xu Jilin,²⁸ a historian and professor at East China Normal University,²⁹ who argues that the traditional *Tianxia* framework can be updated within the context of modernity by incorporating the principle of sovereign equality, thereby adapting it to the current international system.

²⁶和谐 (*héxié*).

²⁷赵汀阳 (*Zhào Tīngyáng*).

²⁸许纪霖 (*Xǔ Jilín*).

²⁹华东师范大学 (*Huádōng Shīfàn Dàxué*).

What is meant by the “new” *Tianxia* is precisely the addition of the principle of equality among sovereign nation-states. In this new *Tianxia* order, there is no central authority; states respect one another's equality and independence, and no longer exist relations of domination, subordination, or hierarchical power structures designed to command obedience. Instead, the envisioned order is one of peaceful coexistence based on equality, without power or domination. A more fundamental transformation in the new *Tianxia* lies in the elimination of the distinction between the Chinese and the “barbarian.”³⁰ There is no longer a division between insiders and outsiders. As classical thinkers expressed it, the world belongs to all who inhabit it (Xu, 2017).

While Xu emphasizes peaceful coexistence and mutual respect and rejects hierarchical power structures as constitutive of the new *Tianxia*, Zhao Tingyang maintains that hierarchy is a necessary condition for the realization of such a system. In his view, modernizing the traditional *Tianxia* concept requires a fundamental rethinking of economic and political interests. The world must be understood as an integrated whole, and by moving beyond Western state-centric thinking, global political and economic interests should become the primary basis for decision-making. Through the construction of a new world system and the articulation of novel ideas of global responsibility, responsibility for global order should become internalized by states themselves (T. Zhao, 2023). For such a system to be feasible, Zhao argues, the hierarchical and networked structure characteristic of the traditional *Tianxia* order remains indispensable.

The feudal system of the Zhou dynasty created a network that encompassed the entire known world and was explicitly hierarchical in structure. Even from a contemporary perspective, the networked nature of the *Tianxia* system appears modern—indeed, even forward-looking—yet its hierarchical structure conflicts with present-day normative values and can readily be interpreted as a form of domination. Nevertheless, a classless society remains an ideal for which the practical conditions do not exist. Not only was ancient society hierarchical; the contemporary world is hierarchical as well. This suggests that although hierarchy stands in tension with the value of equality, it remains necessary for the functioning of society. Values have their own logic, and reality has its own constraints (T. Zhao, 2016).

Some Chinese scholars further contend that the *Tianxia* conception of world order lacks universal applicability. From their perspective, the inherent tensions between *Tianxia* and

³⁰This dichotomy reflected historical modes of thought in which the Chinese—predominantly of Han ethnicity—regarded other peoples as uncivilized.

the normative foundations of the contemporary international order—particularly the principle of equality among races and states³¹—preclude the possibility that this Confucian order could prevail in the modern world. As noted earlier, even Zhao Tingyang, one of its principal advocates, acknowledges these contradictions. Zhang Xiaoming, in his article entitled *China's Rise, the International Order, and World Order*, argues that *Tianxia* is fundamentally a historical concept and is unlikely to serve as the foundation of a future global order unless all modern sovereign states were to disappear. He further observes that even scholars in China's East Asian neighbors doubt the feasibility of such an order; consequently, “not only is a global order based on *Tianxia* impossible, but *Tianxia* cannot even function as a regional order in East Asia” (X. Zhang, 2018).

Understanding the *Tianxia* debate significantly facilitates comprehension of the concepts advanced by China in discussions of international and global order. Ideas such as a community with a shared future for mankind, the Chinese Dream, and even policy initiatives such as the Belt and Road Initiative have all been examined within a *Tianxia*-based interpretive framework. However, misinterpreting this debate or attempting to understand it solely through a Western worldview can be misleading. Qi Lingling,³² in her article entitled *Western Society's Understanding of China's Views on the International Order and Its Policies*, explains that some Western observers fail to grasp the *Tianxia* concept correctly and assume that China seeks to become a hegemonic power to which the rest of the world would pay tribute. At the same time, she notes that other non-Chinese scholars recognize that the *Tianxia* framework does not entail a hegemonic central power and that Chinese officials consistently emphasize recognition of the principle of sovereign equality (Qi, 2021).

A full understanding of the *Tianxia* concept requires familiarity with the Confucian worldview. For Chinese audiences, Confucian philosophy constitutes an integral part of cultural life, everyday practice, and even formal education, providing an intellectual foundation for engaging with these debates. For non-Chinese scholars, by contrast, insufficient familiarity with the nuances of this millennia-old intellectual tradition can easily result in misinterpretation. Nevertheless, these concepts warrant careful engagement. Traditional Chinese ideas exert a significant and enduring influence on the intellectual foundations shaping contemporary Chinese decision-making, and familiarity with them contributes to a deeper understanding of how Chinese political leaders and academic scholars approach theoretical notions such as international order.

Zhang Xiaoming, in his article *China's Rise, the International Order, and World Order*, argues that the *Tianxia* concept continues to influence China's foreign policy and the struc-

³¹ As noted, the privileging of Han ethnicity and the classification of others as “barbarians” formed part of the traditional *Tianxia* structure.

³² 祁玲玲 (Qi Lingling).

ture of East Asian order (X. Zhang, 2018). Norms, rules, and models that governed and sustained East Asian international relations for thousands of years, together with the intellectual traditions and historical experiences derived from them, continue to exert both positive and negative effects on international relations and foreign policy in the region, particularly in China. Citing Li Yangfan's book *The Rise of the World: How the Chinese Worldview Changes the Theory of History (1500–1911)*, Zhang adds:

According to Li, nationalism in Chinese politics serves as a mobilizing force, but it does not constitute the core of China's worldview or its primary concern. What lies at the heart of China remains a concern for the world as a whole; throughout the historical haze of the twentieth century to the present, nationalism has functioned merely as the dragon's claws. China has not truly undergone a conceptual transition from *Tianxia* to a nationalism-centered worldview (X. Zhang, 2018).

The *Tianxia* debate and the concepts articulated within it thus help to clarify the intellectual background underlying the ideas advanced by Xi Jinping and other Chinese leaders. These discussions will be revisited in Chapter Four to assist in interpreting Xi Jinping's cognitive map. When this understanding of international order is linked to debates on development and the international conditions required to achieve it, a clearer picture emerges of the process that culminated in the launch of the Belt and Road Initiative.

Through the convergence of domestic and external priorities, Chinese leaders' understanding of order becomes directly connected to the issue of development. As explained above, tracing China's economic and political processes alongside the international requirements for their realization reveals a convergence between domestic and foreign priorities (Clarke, 2018, p. 85). This convergence ultimately led to the integration of the Western Development Strategy and the Go Out strategy within the framework of the Belt and Road Initiative.

This convergence is not limited solely to domestic and external needs and priorities. Rather, by linking the development of western provinces to outward foreign investment, the Belt and Road Initiative appears to have sought to bridge existing gaps among competing development approaches within China itself. Indeed, an examination of Xi Jinping's own rise to power suggests that his selection as General Secretary of the Chinese Communist Party was itself the outcome of a form of compromise among rival political currents.

The following section turns to Xi Jinping's political life. In doing so, it clarifies how, amid policy competition and disagreement, Xi emerged as a centrist compromise candidate and ascended to power, while also explaining how his life experiences as a "Party princeling"³³ who grew up in a rural environment shaped his later thinking and policy

³³太子党 (*Tàizǐdǎng*). The term refers to the children of senior leaders of the Chinese Communist Party.

preferences. In this way, the necessary groundwork is laid for the analysis of his perceptions in Chapter Four.

3.4 Xi Jinping's Political Life and Family Background

As the son of one of the Chinese Communist Party's key revolutionaries, Xi Jinping's life has never been separate from politics. The political and administrative orientations of both Xi himself and his father have exerted influence not only within the context of his personal life, but also within the broader trajectory of Chinese politics and, ultimately, China's foreign policy following his rise to power.

After Mao Zedong and Deng Xiaoping, Xi Jinping is the third paramount leader of China to have successfully centralized the country's fragmented political landscape and to have enshrined his thought in the Constitution of the Chinese Communist Party. Xi's position is the product of complex political, economic, and social transformations that have shaped contemporary China and, by extension, its foreign policy. Xi Jinping rose to power by drawing on the imperatives generated by these transformations, and his governance can be interpreted as a response to them.

This section examines Xi Jinping's life prior to his ascent to power and elucidates the foundations of his rise within the context of China's political, economic, and social transformations.

3.4.1 Early Life (1953–1972)

Xi Jinping was born on 15 June 1953 in Beijing into a revolutionary family. His father, Xi Zhongxun,³⁴ was a renowned revolutionary figure and one of the early leaders of the People's Republic of China, who held senior positions in the 1950s, including vice premier and minister of propaganda.³⁵ (Chan, 2022, p. 38). His mother, Qi Xin,³⁶ was also a Party member and state cadre who worked in Marxist educational institutions during the 1950s. Xi Jinping spent his childhood among Beijing's political elite (Brown, 2016, p. 63). All four children in the Xi family—Jinping, his two elder sisters, and his younger brother—attended the prestigious Beihai Kindergarten,³⁷ often referred to as the “cradle

³⁴ 习仲勋 (*Xí Zhòngxūn*).

³⁵ Earlier official Chinese translations used the title “Minister of Propaganda.” It was later rendered as “Minister of Publicity” because of the former term's negative connotations in the West. Chinese uses the same term, 宣传 (*Xuānchuán*), for publicity and propaganda; 政治 (*Zhèngzhì*, “political”) may be added when referring to propaganda in its pejorative sense. Political propaganda is not generally regarded in Chinese political culture as a disreputable activity that must be concealed, but as a necessary part of political and social life.

³⁶ 齐心 (*Qí Xīn*).

³⁷ 北海幼儿园 (*Běihǎi Yòu'eryuán*).

for revolutionaries,” which was reserved for the children of high-ranking officials. There, they interacted closely with the children of China's top leaders (Chan, 2022, p. 41). Nevertheless, given China's difficult economic conditions and the cumulative impact of decades of war and revolution, the privileges associated with such institutions were only relative and remained modest by comparison with contemporary standards (Chan, 2022, p. 41).

This period of relative comfort did not last long. In the early 1960s, the Xi family was engulfed by a severe political crisis. In September 1962, amid internal struggles within the Chinese Communist Party, Xi Zhongxun was accused of belonging to an alleged “anti-Party clique” and fell from political favor. The charge was leveled by Kang Sheng,³⁸ a powerful security figure closely aligned with Mao Zedong. Kang claimed that a novel whose publication Xi Zhongxun had approved was in fact an attempt to rehabilitate the case of a purged Party member (S. Hu, 1994, p. 601). As a result, Xi Zhongxun was stripped of all official positions in 1962 (Y. Zhao, 2005, p. 46), sent to the Central Party School for political “re-education” in 1963 (K. Ye & Qi, 2008), exiled in 1964 to work in a wheat mill, and ultimately imprisoned from 1968 until the end of the Cultural Revolution (Y. Zhao, 2005, p. 46).

The Cultural Revolution (1966–1976) had a devastating impact on the Xi family and, more broadly, on the families of first-generation revolutionary elites in China. Relatives of purged officials were subjected to persecution and, under the collective violence of the Red Guards,³⁹ were often coerced into making denunciations against themselves and others. During this period, the young Xi Jinping was imprisoned on four occasions. He experienced hunger and was even forced to beg for food. His half-sister, Xi Heping, unable to withstand the pressure, committed suicide during this time (Chan, 2022, p. 44).

In December 1968, Xi made use of Mao Zedong's directive that “educated youth must go to the countryside and receive re-education from poor and lower-middle peasants,”⁴⁰ and left Beijing for the remote village of Liangjiahe⁴¹ in order to escape the highly charged political atmosphere of the capital (X. Yang, 2000, pp. 66–67).

Under the policy of sending educated youth to the countryside, approximately seventeen million urban youths—many of whom had been Red Guards—were relocated to rural areas. Officially, Mao's stated objectives were to promote rural development, reduce the “three major gaps” between mental and manual labor, urban and rural areas, and workers and peasants, and to cultivate a new generation of revolutionary successors committed to the principle of permanent revolution. In practice, however, the policy functioned as a

³⁸康生 (*Kāng Shēng*).

³⁹红卫兵 (*Hóng Wèibīng*).

⁴⁰The Up to the Mountains and Down to the Countryside Movement, 上山下乡 (*Shàngshān Xiàxiāng*), literally means “going up to the mountains and down to the countryside.” During the Cultural Revolution, the policy sent millions of educated urban youths to rural areas for re-education.

⁴¹梁家河 (*Liángjiāhé*).

means of alleviating urban unemployment and dissipating the radical energies of the Red Guards. Young people were typically dispatched “voluntarily”—under intense ideological pressure—to remote villages or state farms. Initial enthusiasm quickly gave way to the harsh realities of poverty, exhausting labor, illness, malnutrition, sexual abuse, and even death. Local villagers often viewed them as burdens—extra mouths to feed with limited productive capacity. Many of these so-called “sent-down youth”⁴² fled the countryside; however, having lost their urban *hukou*,⁴³ they became illegal migrants in cities, deprived of access to education, employment, and social services. Ultimately, nearly all of them lost critical educational and professional opportunities (Chan, 2022, pp. 46–47).

Unlike many sent-down youths, this experience proved advantageous for Xi Jinping's later political and professional trajectory. The Cultural Revolution was an especially hostile environment for “Party princelings.” They were often forced either to suffer victimization, as Xi did, or to participate in the violent excesses of the Red Guards, thereby acquiring radical political records that later became serious obstacles to advancement. Distance from Beijing's radical milieu allowed Xi to maintain a politically “clean” record, which ultimately facilitated his rapid rise (Brown, 2014, pp. 109–110). During this period, even figures such as Jiang Zemin and Hu Jintao were later required to account for their activities during the Cultural Revolution. Xi Zhongxun's exile further insulated Xi Jinping from association with radical Party actions of the era. Reflecting on this period, Xi later remarked: “At the time, my feeling was that the countryside was better. If you were in a factory or something like that, the closer you were to those kinds of places, the more intensely the Cultural Revolution was implemented, and there was no escape from daily criticism and denunciation” (X. Yang, 2000, p. 67).

Xi took advantage of this opportunity to join the Communist Youth League of China.⁴⁴ The minimum age for membership in the Chinese Communist Party is eighteen, and the Youth League provided an institutional pathway through which individuals under that age could demonstrate merit, build trust, and accumulate the social standing necessary for Party membership. Hu Jintao and many of his close associates, including Li Keqiang, emerged from this organization. Given the political climate of the Cultural Revolution and Xi's stigmatized political identity resulting from his father's condemnation, it was effectively impossible for him to gain admission to either the Youth League or the Party while remaining in Beijing.

⁴² 下乡青年 (*Xiàxiāng Qīngnián*).

⁴³ 户口 (*Hùkǒu*) is China's household-registration system. It restricts access to employment, education, and social services outside the place of registration, most importantly through the distinction between urban and rural status. This contributed to a population of migrants living in cities without local social-service rights; although later reforms reduced its force, gaining or losing urban *hukou* was especially consequential in earlier decades.

⁴⁴ 中国共产主义青年团 (*Zhōngguó Gòngchǎn Zhǔyì Qīngnián Tuán*).

Reflecting on the process of joining the Communist Youth League, Xi Jinping recalled:

Joining the Youth League was also full of difficulties. Altogether, I wrote eight application letters...At that time, I no longer felt sadness or inferiority like some others did; I had only one thought: the more good people there are in the Party and the League, the fewer bad people there will be. So one must join—unless they absolutely refuse to let you. When I submitted my application for the eighth time, it was finally approved (X. Yang, 2000, p. 66).

Xi's applications for membership in the Chinese Communist Party were likewise repeatedly rejected because of his family background. Only after submitting ten applications did his sustained activities and the needs of the village lead to his acceptance into the Party, after which Xi Jinping was appointed secretary of the village Party branch (X. Yang, 2000, p. 66). He later stated with pride that among approximately 29,000 student youths sent from Beijing to the Yan'an region during the Cultural Revolution, he was the first to attain the position of village-level Party secretary (Dong, 2004).

Life in the countryside exerted a profound influence on Xi Jinping's values and outlook. Spending his formative years among impoverished peasants, he became intimately familiar with the hardships of ordinary people. In an interview, Xi described this experience as follows: "In Liangjiahe, I saw the strength of the masses and understood their foundations. I truly came to understand ordinary people and to know society. This was the most fundamental [impact of that experience on me]. A large part of my realistic approach⁴⁵ took root at that time and has continued to influence me ever since" (Dong, 2004).

3.4.2 Period of Political Advancement (1972–2012)

After seven years in the countryside, Xi returned to Beijing in 1975 to pursue higher education at Tsinghua University. As a consequence of the Cultural Revolution, the national university entrance examination, known as the *gaokao*,⁴⁶ was completely suspended between 1966 and 1977. During this period, admission to universities was based on political recommendations or class-based quotas. Students admitted through this system were known as worker–peasant–soldier students⁴⁷ and were selected by Party committees and work units rather than through competitive examinations (Liu, 2017). Xi Jinping entered Tsinghua University under this quota system and studied chemical engineering (F. Zhang, 2008).

⁴⁵ 实事求是 (*Shìshì Qiúshì*).

⁴⁶ 高考 (*Gāokǎo*) is China's centralized university entrance examination, comparable to Iran's *konkur* but historically even more consequential. For many people it was long the principal route from rural to urban *hukou* and upward mobility; its relative importance declined as university capacity expanded and *hukou* policy changed.

⁴⁷ 工农兵学员 (*Gōngnóngbīng Xuéyuán*).

Following the restoration of the national entrance examination under Deng Xiaoping's initiative, millions of candidates sat for the *gaokao* after an eleven-year hiatus. This led to the emergence of two cohorts commonly referred to as the “Classes of 1977 and 1978,”⁴⁸ which are widely regarded as a distinctive generation in the history of Chinese higher education. Characterized by unprecedented competition, wide age diversity, shared experiences of hardship, and an intense thirst for learning, this generation—later described as the “1977–1978 phenomenon”⁴⁹—played a critical role in filling the human-capital vacuum left by the Cultural Revolution. Many of China's subsequent political, scientific, and cultural leaders emerged from this cohort (Liu, 2017). China's foreign minister Wang Yi⁵⁰ and former premier Li Keqiang are among the notable members of the 1977 intake (China Daily, 2017). In this sense, Xi Jinping's earlier dispatch to the countryside enabled him to enter university two years ahead of many of his future peers and without facing the intense competition of the restored national entrance examination,⁵¹ a circumstance that would have lasting implications for his subsequent career trajectory.

Another significant development during this period was the release and rehabilitation of Xi Jinping's father. Xi Zhongxun was temporarily released from prison in late 1975 and, following Mao Zedong's death in 1976 and the end of the Cultural Revolution, was formally rehabilitated in 1978. Almost immediately thereafter, he was appointed second Party secretary of Guangdong Province in southern China,⁵² where he became one of the influential figures promoting the policy of “reform and opening up” in the early 1980s (Brown, 2016, p. 59).

In the same year, Xi Jinping graduated from university and, on his mother's recommendation, obtained the position of confidential secretary⁵³ to Geng Biao.⁵⁴ At the time, Geng Biao simultaneously held several key positions spanning all three branches of power: member of the Party Politburo (1977–1982), vice premier, secretary-general of the Central Military Commission (1979–1981), and minister of national defense (1981–1982) (Chan, 2022, p. 68). This appointment marked Xi Jinping's first significant role within Chinese politics. In China's highly personalized political system, confidential secretaries often wield substantial informal influence and are sometimes referred to as “second leaders,”⁵⁵ serving as important springboards to higher office. Although analysts generally assume

⁴⁸ 77、78级大学生 (*Qīqī, Qībā Jí Dàxuéshēng*).

⁴⁹ 77、78级现象 (*Qīqī, Qībā Jí Xiànxàng*).

⁵⁰ 王毅 (*Wáng Yì*).

⁵¹ In the 1977 *gaokao*, only 278,000 of approximately 5.7 million candidates were admitted to universities, an acceptance rate of 4.9 percent—the lowest in the history of the examination.

⁵² 广东 (*Guǎngdōng*).

⁵³ 机要秘书 (*Jīyào Mìshū*). In Chinese politics, officials are supported by several types of secretaries; a confidential secretary is responsible for handling classified documents and sensitive communications.

⁵⁴ 耿飚 (*Gěng Biāo*).

⁵⁵ 二领导 (*Èr Lǐngdǎo*).

that Xi's background as a princeling was a necessary precondition for securing such a post, his formal education also contributed to his eligibility for the position (Chan, 2022, p. 68).

Xi's appointment as Geng Biao's confidential secretary could have provided a secure and powerful starting point for his political advancement. Nevertheless, unlike some other Party princelings, Xi chose to distance himself once again from the capital and return to lower administrative levels. He later described this step as the true beginning of his career as a leadership cadre (Yong, 2009, p. 64). Scholars have offered several explanations for this decision. One commonly cited reason is that in 1981 or 1982 Geng advised Xi to separate himself from his own political orbit and seek advancement elsewhere. This advice reflected disagreements between Deng Xiaoping and Geng Biao at the time, and Geng may have feared that his own political position could adversely affect Xi's prospects (Brown, 2016, p. 63). Geng reportedly suggested that Xi remain within the military system and gain experience at the level of a provincial field army (Chan, 2022, p. 71). Xi, however, chose not to pursue a military career and instead decided to enter the Party's civilian political track.

Ultimately, in March 1982, Xi Jinping was dispatched as a cadre on job practice⁵⁶ to Zhengding County⁵⁷ in Hebei Province⁵⁸ (X. Guo, 2019, p. 367).

Xi Jinping made this decision at a time when the Party was in the process of identifying and training younger cadres under the rubric of the so-called "third echelon."⁵⁹ One of the prerequisites for selection into the third echelon was the accumulation of experience at the lower organizational levels of the Party (X. Guo, 2019, p. 366). Accordingly, some analysts argue that Xi Jinping's move constituted a calculated decision and a long-term strategy aimed at advancement within the Party and the eventual acquisition of power. Brown, however, rejects this tempting interpretation and instead attributes Xi's choice to the relative weakening of the military sector during that period, viewing it as a rational decision for political advancement rather than a grand strategic design (Brown, 2016, p. 64). Chan similarly emphasizes that although many cadres who worked in impoverished regions later entered the Politburo, this outcome was far from apparent in the 1980s and could not have been foreseen by Xi at the time (Chan, 2022, p. 71).

The complexity of China's political environment during this period posed substantial challenges for young cadres. With the onset of the reform era, competing political currents emerged within the Chinese Communist Party. Party conservatives feared that communist ideals were being eroded, placing considerable pressure on Deng Xiaoping and his reform agenda. As a result, many cadres lacked the confidence to implement reform-oriented

⁵⁶挂职干部 (*Guàzhí Gàn bù*).

⁵⁷正定县 (*Zhèngdìng Xiàn*).

⁵⁸河北 (*Héběi*).

⁵⁹第三梯队 (*Dìsān Tīduì*).

policies that promoted market mechanisms. During this period, Xi Zhongxun was among the vanguard supporting Deng's campaign against those loyal to Maoist orthodoxy (X. Guo, 2019, p. 367). Xi Jinping's own administrative style likewise leaned more toward reformist experimentation than rigid adherence to Maoist ideals, a political orientation that would later play a significant role in his advancement.

At the time, China required figures like Xi Jinping. Under pressure from conservative factions, princelings such as Xi—by virtue of their political backing—enjoyed greater latitude to pursue reform initiatives. Nevertheless, not all princelings were willing to relinquish their comfortable lives in Beijing to work in poor and underdeveloped areas, and even among those who did, few were prepared to live among local populations on equal terms. Many preferred instead to ride the wave of development generated by Deng's reforms by securing positions within state-owned enterprises.

In a context where some Party cadres lacked sufficient political backing to pursue bold initiatives, while others exploited such backing primarily for personal gain, Xi managed to strike a careful balance between leveraging and restraining his status as a Party princeling. This balance enabled him to pursue reformist initiatives with relative boldness while avoiding the large-scale financial scandals that engulfed many cadres during the critical reform period.

The core of Xi Jinping's activities during this phase of his career was his seventeen-year tenure (1985–2002) in Fujian Province. Over these seventeen years, he rose from village-level administration to the provincial governorship, gradually ascending the bureaucratic hierarchy. In this respect, this period constitutes the most consequential phase of Xi's life as a politician. If his seven years in Liangjiahe shaped his character as an individual, his seventeen years of governance in Fujian shaped his outlook as an administrator and political leader. All of the interviews analyzed in this study also date from this period of Xi Jinping's life.

Xi Jinping's tenure in Fujian coincided with the peak phase of reform under Jiang Zemin. The rapid pace and large scale of development during this period were accompanied by widespread cadre corruption and rising inequality. This era also encompassed China's accession to the World Trade Organization, the Tiananmen protests, and the Third Taiwan Strait Crisis. As the province geographically closest to Taiwan, Fujian stood on the front line of cross-strait tensions (Figure 3.2). At the same time, as a coastal province, its proximity to Hong Kong endowed it with a distinctive position in the reform-era development process, and several Special Economic Zones (SEZs)⁶⁰ were located within Fujian and fell under Xi's administrative jurisdiction. The province was also marked by

⁶⁰ 特别经济区 (*Tèbié Jīngjì Qū*).

pronounced inequality and endemic corruption, both characteristic features of the reform period and central to conservative critiques of the reform trajectory.

In other words, during Xi's administration of this strategically sensitive province, he simultaneously confronted issues of development, political legitimacy, China's integration into the global economy, and the Taiwan security crisis. Bold reform initiatives, support for military preparedness, and long-term planning constituted three defining features of his governance in Fujian (Chan, 2022, pp. 99–104).

One illustrative example of Xi's reformist assertiveness in economic and administrative governance dates to his tenure as Party secretary of Fuzhou.⁶¹ Shortly after assuming this position, he adopted the slogan "Act immediately"⁶² as the official motto of Fuzhou's administrative apparatus (Zhaoshang Zhoukan, 2007), aiming to reduce bureaucratic inefficiency and administrative delays. The slogan was rapidly displayed at the entrances of government offices and even carved into a hillside in the Mawei area overlooking the highway,⁶³ becoming a defining symbol of his managerial style (Chan, 2022, p. 101).

In 1992, Xi formulated a long-term development plan for Fuzhou known as the "3820 Program,"⁶⁴ which outlined a twenty-year development vision alongside medium-term targets for 1995, 2000, and 2010 (Lam, 2023, p. 22). Inspired by the experience of the "Four Little Dragons of East Asia,"⁶⁵ the plan identified electronics, television components, and automobile manufacturing as strategic priority industries. According to official statistics, Fuzhou's economy grew at an annual rate exceeding 20 percent between 1990 and 1995, and the city's gross domestic product surpassed 400 billion yuan (Chan, 2022, pp. 101–102). In addition, approximately ten thousand residents of the Cengxia shantytown area were relocated to newly developed districts.

In implementing these policies, Xi attached great importance to research. This emphasis constitutes a defining feature of his managerial style during this period and has continued to characterize his approach to governance. In formulating economic programs, he brought county-level officials to Beijing to consult with national-level economists (Chan, 2022, pp. 87–93). In numerous interviews, he repeatedly stressed that before adopting any policy decision, a leader must conduct thorough research on the locality under his jurisdiction and personally visit all subordinate areas. In the sources examined for this study, Xi explicitly refers to this principle in thirty interviews and speeches. This emphasis, together with his academic publications, has contributed to his reputation as a research-oriented

⁶¹ 福州 (*Fúzhōu*).

⁶² 马上就办 (*mǎshàng jiù bàn*).

⁶³ 马尾 (*Mǎwěi*).

⁶⁴ The name of the program refers to its temporal horizons: three years later (1995), eight years later (2000), and twenty years later (2010).

⁶⁵ The term refers to Hong Kong, Singapore, South Korea, and Taiwan. In Chinese usage, the literal translation is "the four small dragons of Asia."



Figure 3.2: Map of the Taiwan Strait

Note. Reprinted from *Detailed Taiwan Strait Area Map With Relief, Roads, Railroads and Major Cities—1998*, by Mapsland, 1998 (<https://www.mapsland.com/asia/taiwan/detailed-taiwan-strait-area-map-with-relief-roads-railroads-and-major-cities-1998>). Copyright 1998 by Mapsland. Reprinted with permission.

official. During his tenure in Fujian, Xi published numerous works on agricultural development as well as political essays on the qualities of effective cadres. Ultimately, in 2002, he obtained a Doctor of Law degree through an in-service, part-time program at the School of Humanities and Social Sciences of Tsinghua University, specializing in Marxist theory and ideological and political education (Xinhua, 2018). While doubts have been raised regarding his academic capabilities, Chan's examination of Xi's published books and articles, including his doctoral dissertation, concludes that he was likely capable of earning the degree and producing these works, even if the actual drafting may have been carried out by his confidential secretaries (Chan, 2022, pp. 128–131).

Another enduring feature of Xi's governance style is the close relationship he cultivated with the military. His attention to the armed forces earned him the nickname "the army-supporting Party secretary" (Chan, 2022, p. 103). This close relationship stemmed partly from his father's military background and partly from Xi's own earlier service as Geng Biao's confidential secretary. Xi maintained these ties throughout his career and, even after becoming commander-in-chief, described himself as a civilian who had served in the military (Lam, 2023, p. 26). Within days of arriving in Fuzhou, he visited all ground, naval, and air force units stationed in the area and facilitated a range of support measures, including the construction of roads for troop transport, the provision of housing and employment for demobilized soldiers and their families, and even the establishment of pig and poultry farms for military use. These actions signaled to both the Party and the military that Xi attached particular importance to political stability and national defense during the turbulent early 1990s (Chan, 2022, pp. 103–104).

Overall, Xi's governance during this period focused on sustaining development through the advancement of reforms, preserving Party legitimacy by improving living standards, attracting foreign investment, and integrating China's economy into the international system. Many of these managerial characteristics persisted after his ascent to power in 2012, including his strong support for the military, which later culminated in the articulation of a vision for building a modernized armed forces.

Nevertheless, Xi's political rise cannot be explained solely by reference to his managerial attributes. A range of additional factors—including the broader political environment and competition among political currents at the time—also played a significant role in his ascent to the national level of Chinese politics.

Xi's promotion in 2002 can be understood as part of the relatively smooth transfer of power from Jiang Zemin to Hu Jintao. In this transition, age and term limits were observed, leading to the retirement of many leaders over the age of seventy (with the exception of Jiang Zemin), while approximately two-thirds of the new leadership consisted of first-time entrants. This generational turnover created extensive opportunities for suc-

cession across different levels of the Party and intensified competition for political office. Although factional rivalry, patronage networks, and informal politics are integral to leadership succession in China, post-Mao power transitions have generally been characterized by consensus and compromise. Analysts often employ a factional model to explain these dynamics, referring to groups such as the “Shanghai Gang,” the “League faction,” and the princelings; however, it is widely acknowledged that these factions are neither fixed nor immutable, and that alliances are frequently temporary, shaped by shared interests and specific contextual conditions (Chan, 2022, pp. 135–137).

At this stage, although Jiang Zemin was no longer Party general secretary, he retained the chairmanship of the Central Military Commission and thus continued to wield substantial political power and influence for a prolonged period. This arrangement constrained Hu Jintao's authority to such an extent that he never attained the level of power enjoyed by his three predecessors. Consequently, although Hu's preferred successor was Li Ke-qiang, both sides ultimately made concessions and agreed on a compromise candidate—Xi Jinping (Lam, 2023, p. 23).

Xi Jinping was widely regarded as a centrist and conciliatory option. His principal advantage lay in the absence of clearly articulated ideological positions, which rendered him acceptable to both conservatives and reformists. Moreover, his reputation for modesty, prudence, personal integrity, and freedom from scandal fostered trust among senior members of the Politburo Standing Committee. Alongside these attributes, emerging promotion criteria—such as loyalty to the Party, closeness to the masses, and a clean style of governance—also played a role in his selection. As a result, Xi Jinping emerged as a mutually acceptable candidate for both factions, smoothing the path of his political advancement (Chan, 2022, pp. 138–139).

Xi was first appointed Party secretary of Shanghai. Although he held this position for only a few months, the office carried considerable institutional weight.⁶⁶ At the Seventeenth Party Congress, Xi was elevated directly from the Central Committee to the Politburo Standing Committee without prior membership in the Politburo, thereby joining the nine-member body that exercised the greatest authority in China (Chan, 2022, p. 195). Ultimately, at the Eighteenth National Congress of the Chinese Communist Party in November 2012, Xi was elected general secretary of the Party and simultaneously assumed the chairmanship of the Party's Central Military Commission. With his election as president of the People's Republic of China and chairman of the state Central Military Commission in March 2013, the consolidation of power was complete. In this way, the three principal pillars of political authority in China—the Party, the state, and the military—were simul-

⁶⁶By convention, Party secretaries of Beijing, Shanghai, and Tianjin automatically become members of the Politburo.

taneously brought under his control. This process not only marked the formal transfer of leadership to the fifth generation of Chinese leaders, but also inaugurated a period characterized by strengthened personal authority and a redefinition of leadership patterns within the political structure of the People's Republic of China.

As emphasized throughout this chapter, Xi Jinping's political ascent cannot be attributed solely to his managerial skills and personal capabilities. Rather, it unfolded within a broader context of domestic and international transformations and intense political competition. Although the challenges of this period encompassed a wide range of issues—including divergent views on development, international pressures stemming from Western concerns over China's rise, and the structural constraints facing Chinese enterprises—they ultimately converged around the central question of development in China.

3.5 Conclusion

This chapter examined China's domestic and international challenges during the 1990s and 2000s and analyzed the competing intra-Party approaches to addressing them. It then situated Xi Jinping's life within the broader landscape of Chinese politics, offering an account of his managerial style and family background as a Party princeling. In doing so, the chapter provided a clear picture of the process through which Xi rose to power in China, as well as the domestic and international decision-making environments he confronted after assuming leadership.

At the international level, the suppression of the Tiananmen Square protests extinguished the hopes of the United States and the European Union for political reform in China and transformed previously positive perceptions of China's development into a sense of strategic apprehension. At the same time, structural constraints on development compelled China to pursue outward expansion and investment in the international environment. Most importantly, uneven development between coastal provinces and the central and western regions generated growing dissatisfaction in the latter.

Disagreements over how to address these multidimensional challenges produced divisions within the Party and led to the formation of rival political currents. These political disagreements created a complex environment whose outcome was the rise of Xi Jinping in 2012 as a broadly acceptable compromise candidate. Xi Jinping rapidly consolidated his position as paramount leader and almost immediately launched the Belt and Road Initiative.

By examining China's socio-economic and political transformations, this chapter has demonstrated the types of challenges confronted by China's leaders across three succes-

sive generations. It has also explained the approaches these leaders adopted to address such challenges and clarified how Xi Jinping's approach as a fifth-generation leader differed from those of his two predecessors. As the analysis shows, in the post-Tiananmen context all three leaders faced broadly similar problems, yet each responded in distinct ways according to their respective policy orientations.

Building on the historical background established in Chapter Three, the next chapter draws on data and findings derived from qualitative content analysis of selected interviews and texts to systematically reconstruct Xi Jinping's cognitive map of the Belt and Road Initiative. In doing so, it provides a rigorous and evidence-based account of how Xi understands the Belt and Road Initiative and its place within China's overarching strategic framework, thereby addressing the research questions of this study.

Chapter 4

Data Presentation and Cognitive Map Construction

4.1 Introduction

This chapter constitutes the analytical core of the thesis and is divided into three main sections. First, the systematic presentation of data extracted from the textual corpus; second, the analysis of these data in the form of Xi Jinping's cognitive map; and third, directly addressing the research questions based on the obtained results. In this way, after providing a descriptive report of the data and establishing the necessary foundation, the chapter proceeds to analyze the data and ultimately presents conclusions leading to answers to the research questions.

In the first section of the chapter, the research data are presented and organized. This section is devoted to explaining the outputs derived from the qualitative content analysis of selected texts and demonstrates how key concepts, causal relationships, and semantic orientations were extracted from Xi Jinping's speeches.

The second section of the chapter focuses on analyzing the presented data. Here, Xi Jinping's cognitive map is examined as a reflection of the causal logic governing his political mindset. The analysis of the cognitive map allows for understanding how concepts such as development, stability, legitimacy, power, and the international order are interconnected within Xi Jinping's thought system.

In the third section, the analytical findings of the chapter are directly employed to address the research questions. Using the process-tracing method, this section shows how Xi Jinping's perceptions of development, legitimacy, order, and China's position in the global system contributed to the formation and structuring of the Belt and Road Initiative. Thus, by linking empirical data to the theoretical framework of the cognitive map, this chapter enables a reasoned, evidence-based response to the central research question.

4.2 Data Presentation

In order to adhere to methodological standards, this study was required to rely exclusively on texts that were directly articulated by Xi Jinping, particularly those with a spontaneous and informal character, such as interviews. Such forms of discourse are considered to offer a more accurate reflection of an individual's perceptions and cognitive patterns (Axelrod, 1976, p. 363).

To collect the primary data from Xi Jinping's interviews, a precise, step-by-step selection criterion was established to ensure both the authenticity of the texts and their suitability for cognitive analysis. First, only interviews published in verbatim form were selected; that is, texts in which the distinction between the interviewer's questions and Xi Jinping's responses was clearly maintained and the question-and-answer structure was preserved without substantive editorial intervention. Second, the sources had to be published in academic or magazine-style periodicals rather than newspapers. The rationale for this criterion was that data collection was conducted through the CNKI database, to which the researcher's access was limited to journals and did not include newspapers.

Following the establishment of these criteria, a systematic search was conducted. All entries related to "Xi Jinping" within the time frame of 1989 to 2002 were reviewed in CNKI. Each entry was manually examined to determine whether it met the selection criteria. The earliest suitable interview dated to 1989, and all comparable materials up to 2002 were subsequently assessed. Ultimately, thirteen interviews that satisfied the criteria were identified and collected. These texts consist of scanned originals of the published materials and are all in Chinese, a feature that further strengthens their authenticity for qualitative analysis. Together, these thirteen interviews constitute the core textual corpus used to extract Xi Jinping's cognitive map.

In addition to these materials, two pivotal speeches delivered by Xi Jinping in 2013 were also incorporated into the textual corpus. The first is his speech at Nazarbayev University in Astana, Kazakhstan (Xi, 2013a), in which the concept of the "Silk Road Economic Belt" was introduced. The second is his speech before the Indonesian Parliament (Xi, 2013b), which focused on the "Twenty-First Century Maritime Silk Road."¹ These two conceptual frameworks were subsequently linked and ultimately articulated in a unified form under the title of the "Belt and Road Initiative." The inclusion of these speeches serves to connect the Belt and Road Initiative to Xi Jinping's broader cognitive map and to clarify the position of this initiative within his wider network of perceptions.

¹21世纪海上丝绸之路 (*Èrshíyī Shìjì Hǎishàng Sīchóu Zhīlù*); the word "Road" in the later name "Belt and Road" derives from this component.

Table 4.1: List of Interviews Used in the Study

Interview Year	Interview Title
1989	Reflections on the Economic Development of Mindong — Exclusive Interview with Xi Jinping, Secretary of the Party Committee of Ningde Region — C. Chen & Li (1989)
1993	Xi Jinping on Leadership — Weng & Liu (1993)
1994	The Key to Work Is the Continuous Improvement of Comprehensive Coordination Capacity — Interview with Xi Jinping, Member of the Standing Committee of the Party in Fujian Province and Party Secretary of Fuzhou City — Q. Chen (1994)
1996	Fuzhou: Toward an International and Modern City — Interview with Xi Jinping, Deputy Party Secretary of Fujian Province and Party Secretary of Fuzhou City — Qiu (1996)
1998	A Historic Transition — Interview with Xi Jinping, Deputy Party Secretary of Fujian Province — J. Guo (1998)
2000	Strengthening the Social Security System in the Service of Fujian's Economic Development — Detailed Interview with Xi Jinping, Governor of Fujian Province — Ba (2000)
2000	Xi Jinping: How I Entered the Political Arena — X. Yang (2000)
2000	Governor Xi Jinping on Economic Restructuring and Enhancing Comprehensive Competitiveness — Y. Wang (2000)
2001	Efforts to Strengthen the Sustainability of Fujian's Economic Development — Xi Jinping, Governor of Fujian, Responds to Journalists' Questions — Y. Zhang & Wang (2001)
2001	Governor Xi Jinping on the Open-Door Policy: The Lifeline of Fujian's Economic Development — Y. Wang (2001)
2001	Remember the Word "People" in the Phrase "People's Government" — Gao & Xi (2001)
2002	Governor Xi Jinping on the Mechanism of Mountain–Sea Cooperation, Internal Links, and the Open-Door Policy as a Strategic Passage for Export-Oriented Development — Y. Wang (2002)
2002	Improving Administrative Efficiency as an Effective Basis for Advancing Government Functional Reform — Interview with Governor Xi Jinping on Building Administrative Efficiency — Hao & Yang (2002)

After selecting the texts, the causal relationships present within them were extracted and recorded. To minimize the researcher's interpretive interventions and maintain the highest possible degree of objectivity, the criterion for identifying causal relationships was linguistic structures in which causality between propositions could be inferred explicitly or implicitly. The coding scheme was chosen based on Margaret Wrightson's 1976 guide in the appendices of Axelrod's *The Structure of Decision*.

After identifying causal relationships, the next step involved selecting, for each relationship, a phrase that best represented the main concept of the sentence. In this selection, excessive generalization and deviation from Xi Jinping's own expressive style were avoided. Therefore, as much as possible, phrases close to the text's original wording were retained to uphold the principle of "minimizing researcher intervention."

Once this stage was completed, the process of concept integration began. First, phrases that differed only slightly in meaning or were merely stylistically different were merged. This variation in expression often resulted from efforts to remain faithful to Xi Jinping's speaking style, whereby a single concept could be expressed using multiple similar formulations. However, "extreme compression" was avoided in these mergers to prevent the loss of meaningful conceptual distinctions.

For example, in cases such as "expanding industrial access," "industrial upgrading," and "industrial development," although subtle differences exist, the functional similarity of these concepts led to their consolidation under a single concept: "industrial development." The goal of these integrations was to reduce network complexity and focus on more fundamental concepts, thereby facilitating the understanding of causal relationships within the map. In this way, while preserving the authenticity of the data, research interpretations remain distinguishable from the data itself, enhancing the scientific validity of the results.

Overall, applying these steps led to a significant reduction in the number of nodes. The initial volume of 612 nodes decreased to 326 after integration—a reduction that simplifies the network while preserving its conceptual and analytical fidelity, enabling a clearer and more meaningful representation of Xi Jinping's cognitive structure. The procedure for processing the data and transforming it into a cognitive map is explained in detail in Appendix B. After processing the data, the clusters extracted are used in the next section for map analysis and addressing the research questions.

4.2.1 Development, Legitimacy, and Order in Xi Jinping's Cognitive Framework

Economic development constitutes the central pillar of Xi Jinping's governance blueprint, and the cognitive map provides a precise depiction of Xi's beliefs regarding how development is realized. The cognitive map also clarifies the relationship between development and legitimacy, as well as its linkage to cooperation and order at the international level, and demonstrates the position China occupies within the hierarchy of such cooperation in Xi's perceptions. By analyzing the relevant concepts in the cognitive map, this section first addresses the subsidiary research questions—"How does Xi Jinping understand development within his intellectual framework, and what relationship does he establish between development, power, and legitimacy?" and "How does Xi Jinping conceptualize the linkage between authority, hierarchy, and cooperation in the process of constructing order and advancing development?"—and then proceeds to test the validity of the research hypothesis that "Xi Jinping's perceptions of the relationship between development, order, and leadership have led to the Belt and Road Initiative."

4.2.1.1 Development

"Development" in Xi Jinping's cognitive system is not merely a policy objective. It can be regarded as the cornerstone of Xi's philosophy of governance and worldview. In Xi's cognitive map, "development" is located at the heart of an interconnected network of concepts (Figure B.4). The centrality of "development" in Xi's perceptions is so pronounced that it is apparent even without more detailed interpretation of the map and solely from the quantitative data generated during processing (see Appendix B).

In Xi Jinping's cognitive map, "development" is not a short-term or merely economic objective, but rather a structural, long-term, and multidimensional process that shapes the overall foundation of governance. In this intellectual system, development is not equivalent to short-term quantitative growth; instead, it is defined as the sustained enhancement of national capacities to maintain progress over time. Accordingly, the concept of "development potential" occupies a central position in the map.

For example, nodes such as "advance high-tech industrialization," "implement brand strategy," and "support SME development" all point—via "industrial development"—toward increasing "development potential," indicating that Xi believes these measures strengthen long-term growth capacity. In addition, "technological innovation" and "updating market economy concepts" feed into this node, demonstrating that innovation and modern economic thinking are regarded as essential for sustained progress.

In sum, Xi's map supports an innovation-driven, development-centered model. Moving toward higher value chains, cultivating new industries, and improving the quality and efficiency of growth are treated as the primary conditions for preventing the economy from hitting a growth ceiling. Within this framework, development is meaningful only insofar as it preserves long-term growth capacity and avoids entrapment in exhausting or dependent trajectories.

This is consistent with the objectives pursued through the “Going Global” strategy and may reflect broader Chinese perceptions of this issue. Preserving domestic development has long been vital to the legitimacy of the Chinese Communist Party; since the post-1989 period, the Party's political mission has been grounded in delivering economic development in exchange for public acceptance (Zenglein & Gunter, 2023, p. 27). Xi Jinping inherits this logic and connects it to the international environment. He repeatedly invokes Deng Xiaoping's proposition that “development is the absolute principle,”².

4.2.1.2 Order, Power, Leadership, and Hierarchy

Although Xi does not explicitly prescribe the Chinese path of development to other nations, the shared roots that appear in his cognitive map between “development” and the “realization of respective dreams” for every country make it clear that, in Xi Jinping's logic, development is a non-local concept. His belief system suggests that any country, by possessing “public support” and “hard work,” can achieve its own “national revitalization” and “respective dream,” and that, through “cooperation” with China and the existence of “common interests,” China's development—rather than constituting a threat—can play a reinforcing role in this process. Figure 4.1 shows which concepts act as the common roots for “development” and “realization of the related dreams.” In this cluster, “cooperation” is considered a very important intermediate node.

Although the map depicted in Figure 4.1 appears complex, by further simplifying the concepts, it can be seen that, in essence, it suggests that through “cooperation,” countries can achieve their goals or dreams. According to Xi's perceptions of objectives, these dreams are roughly equivalent to economic development.

In Xi's perceptions, development and power are used almost interchangeably. In the map, China's development, represented through the node “Stronger China,” acts as a reinforcing element for “Peace,” “Global Development,” and “Friendship” (Figure 4.2). Considering the discussions on the China threat presented in Chapter Three, it appears that over time both Western and Chinese interlocutors tend to equate China's economic development with power, regardless of whether this economic capability has translated into

²发展才是硬道理 (*Fāzhǎn Cǎi Shì Yìng Dàolǐ*)

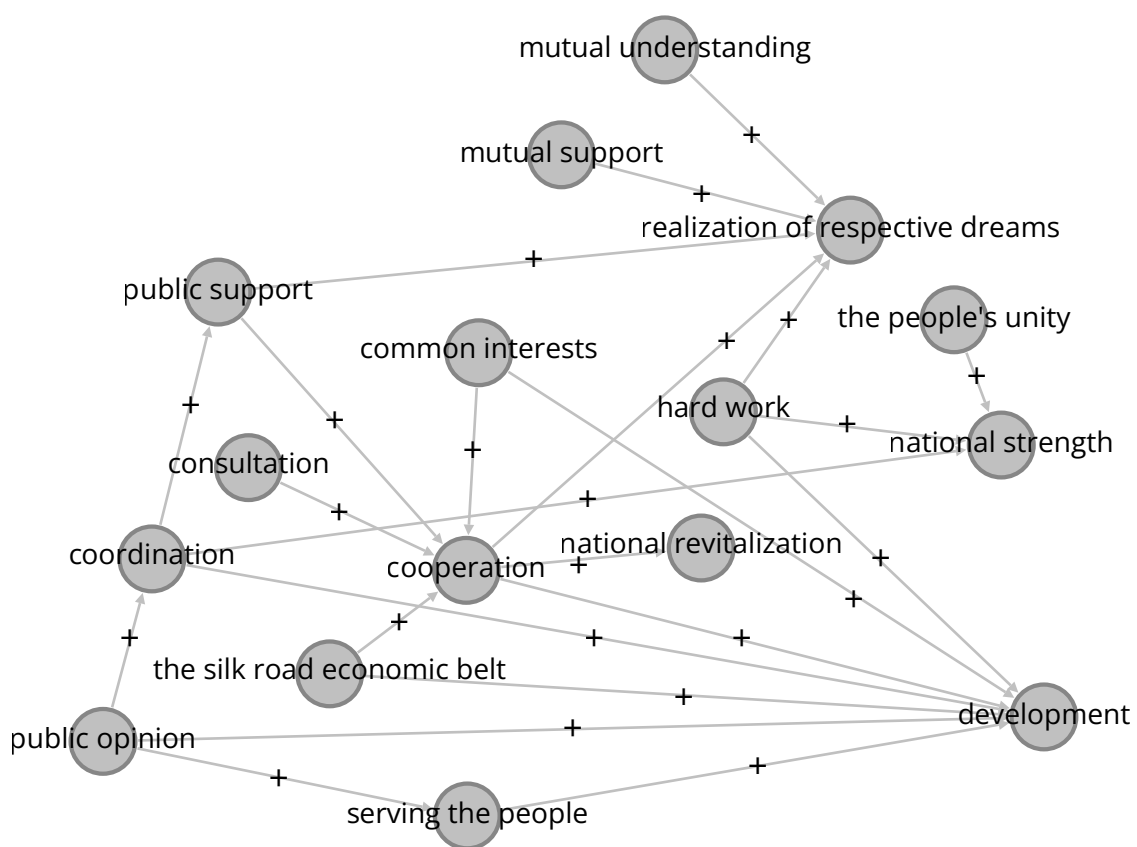


Figure 4.1: Shared roots of development and the realization of national dreams for China and other countries

Note. Figure created by the author based on the analysis of the research data.

other forms of power (political influence or military capability). In Xi's map, "Strong China" is also used in connection with China's development.

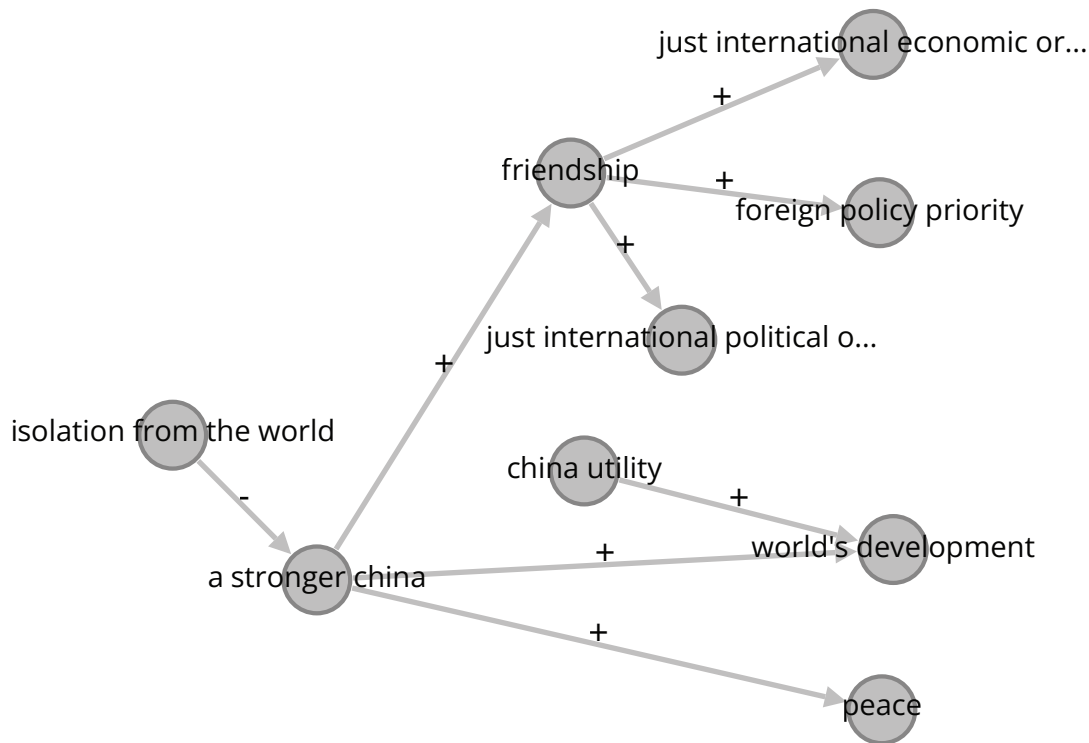


Figure 4.2: Incoming and outgoing links of the node "a stronger China"

Note. Figure created by the author based on the analysis of the research data.

The map establishes a positive relationship between power derived from China's development and peace. For instance, in his 2013 speech at Nazarbayev University, Xi emphasized that countries with "diverse" cultures can share "peace" and "development" through adherence to values such as "solidarity", "mutual trust", "inclusiveness", and "win-win cooperation"(Xi, 2013a). This perspective reflects Xi's belief that development and peace have common roots (Figure 4.3). It also indicates that, in his belief system, countries do not need to sacrifice domestic sovereignty to engage in international cooperation. Emphasis on "mutual cooperation," "mutual learning," "respect," "inclusiveness," and the notion that every country can follow its own path to development all highlight the importance of preserving national sovereignty while expanding international cooperation.

In other words, in Xi's perceptions, China's development (represented as "Stronger China" in the map) has a reinforcing relationship with the international order (represented as "Peace" in the map). Figures 4.2 and 4.3—despite their apparent complexity—illustrate this simple principle: development leads to order.

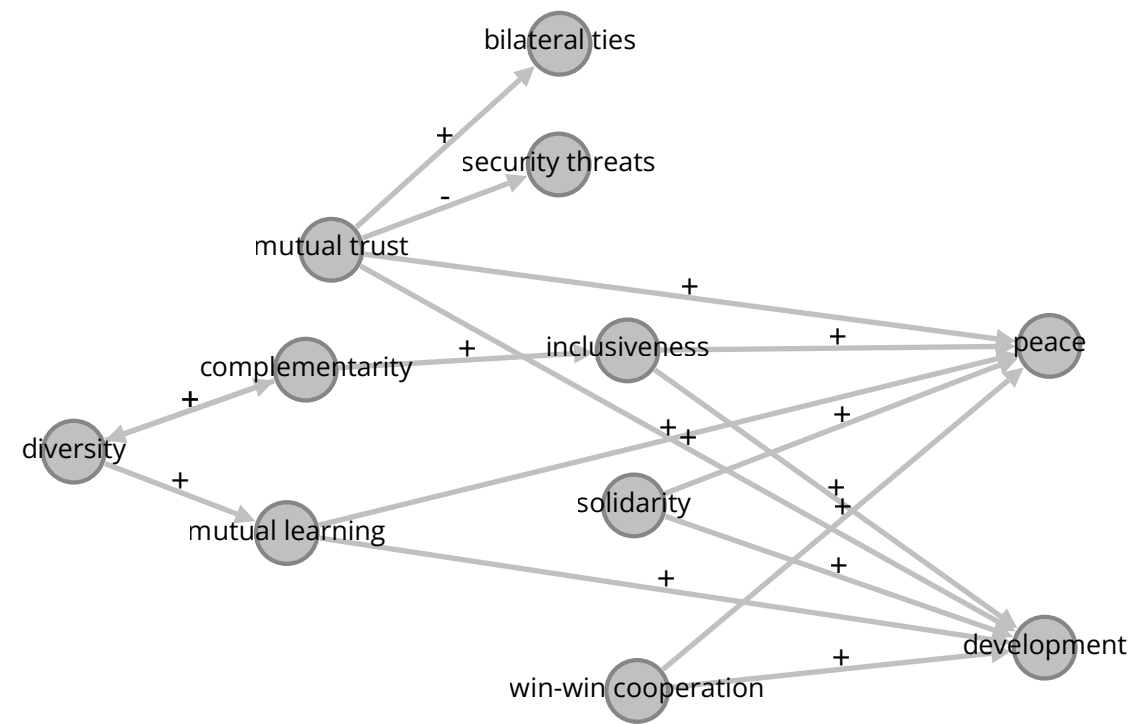


Figure 4.3: The relationship between “solidarity,” “mutual trust,” “inclusiveness,” “win–win cooperation,” “peace,” and “development”

Note. Figure created by the author based on the analysis of the research data.

Xi has acted very cautiously in expressing the relationship between China's development and the development of other countries, assigning them a parallel status. In other words, Xi emphasizes that through win-win cooperation, all countries can develop together. He establishes a causal link between China's development and order but does not explicitly present it as a factor that promotes the development of other countries. Instead, by positioning "cooperation" as an intermediate node, he suggests that countries can develop through "cooperation," and the "Silk Road Economic Belt" (later the Belt and Road Initiative) serves as a tool to realize this cooperation. Figure 4.4 presents a simplified representation of the concepts introduced in Figures 4.1, 4.2, and 4.3 and illustrates the relationship between development and international order in Xi's perceptions.

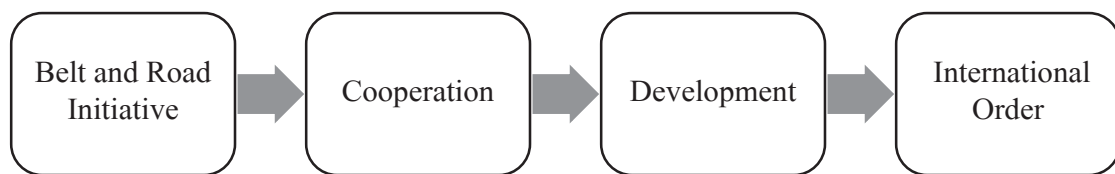


Figure 4.4: The relationship between the Belt and Road Initiative and the international order

Note. Figure created by the author.

Thus, the map portrays China and other countries in a framework emphasizing cooperation, with an equal and parallel hierarchy. Xi Jinping is unwilling to publicly define a leadership role for China. This aspect of Xi's cognitive map is not entirely reliable. It should be noted that, due to limitations in data access, the map is drawn solely based on texts from interviews and public speeches. As mentioned, China's foreign policy after Deng mainly followed a strategy of quiet progress. Despite this cautious and development-oriented foreign policy during Jiang's era, China faced a serious issue of negative international image. The intensity was such that the Hu administration had to replace the term "rise" with "development." It is unsurprising that the diplomatic caution of Chinese policymakers prevents the public articulation of strategic issues.

The difficulty in accessing reliable information can be considered one of the limitations of cognitive studies, particularly regarding leaders of non-liberal regimes. Nevertheless, policy decisions are made within a comprehensive decision-making environment. By relying on other aspects of policy decisions, it is at least possible to fill, hypothetically, the gap created by the lack of data by drawing on other features identified at the international system level and the state level, as well as assuming rationality in leaders' decision-making. In the process-tracing section, this dimension of Xi's perceptions will be further explored, taking into account conditions at both the international system and state levels.

4.2.1.3 Legitimacy

“Public opinion” plays a structurally significant role in Xi’s cognitive map. Nodes related to the populace, such as the “public opinion” node, indicate that Xi believes people’s sentiments and judgments have a broad impact across various governance domains. This node, with five incoming links and seven outgoing links, constitutes one of the key intermediary nodes that connect tools to objectives. In the map, “public opinion” positively affects “coordination” and the “administrative management system” while simultaneously suppressing issues such as “corruption” and “work style problems” (see Figure 4.5). Thus, public opinion functions as a force capable of prompting the government to improve performance and constraining misconduct.

The “mass line” node also exhibits multiple effects in Xi’s map: it leads to “problem-solving,” “popular support,” and “serving the people.” This reflects Xi’s belief that adherence to the mass line yields both practical and political benefits; that is, it helps identify local needs, thereby resolving problems and, in turn, enhancing popular support and advancing policy objectives.

The interwoven links in Figure 4.5 connect four categories of nodes. The first category includes nodes related to the populace, such as “public opinion,” “serving the people,” and the “mass line.” The second category consists of nodes related to governance, including the “administrative management system” and “rule-based governance.” The third category comprises nodes associated with “development” and its sustaining factors, such as “research and planning activities” and “globalization.” The final category consists of problem nodes, representing obstacles that must be overcome, such as “work style problems” and “corruption.”

A key feature of this cluster is the reciprocal role of governance and populace-related nodes, as well as the intermediary nodes connecting them. In other words, in Xi’s perceptions, governance both influences the people and is influenced by them, and the interaction between the two ultimately leads to development. Development, in turn, reinforces the mass line, and ultimately, all concepts form a positive reinforcing cycle that defines the rationale and mechanisms of legitimacy for China’s ruling system. Figure 4.6 presents a simplified depiction of this cycle.

In Xi’s perceptions, all three of these concepts mutually influence each other. Development leads to legitimacy by increasing public satisfaction, and legitimacy, by encouraging public cooperation, creates the space for development to be realized.

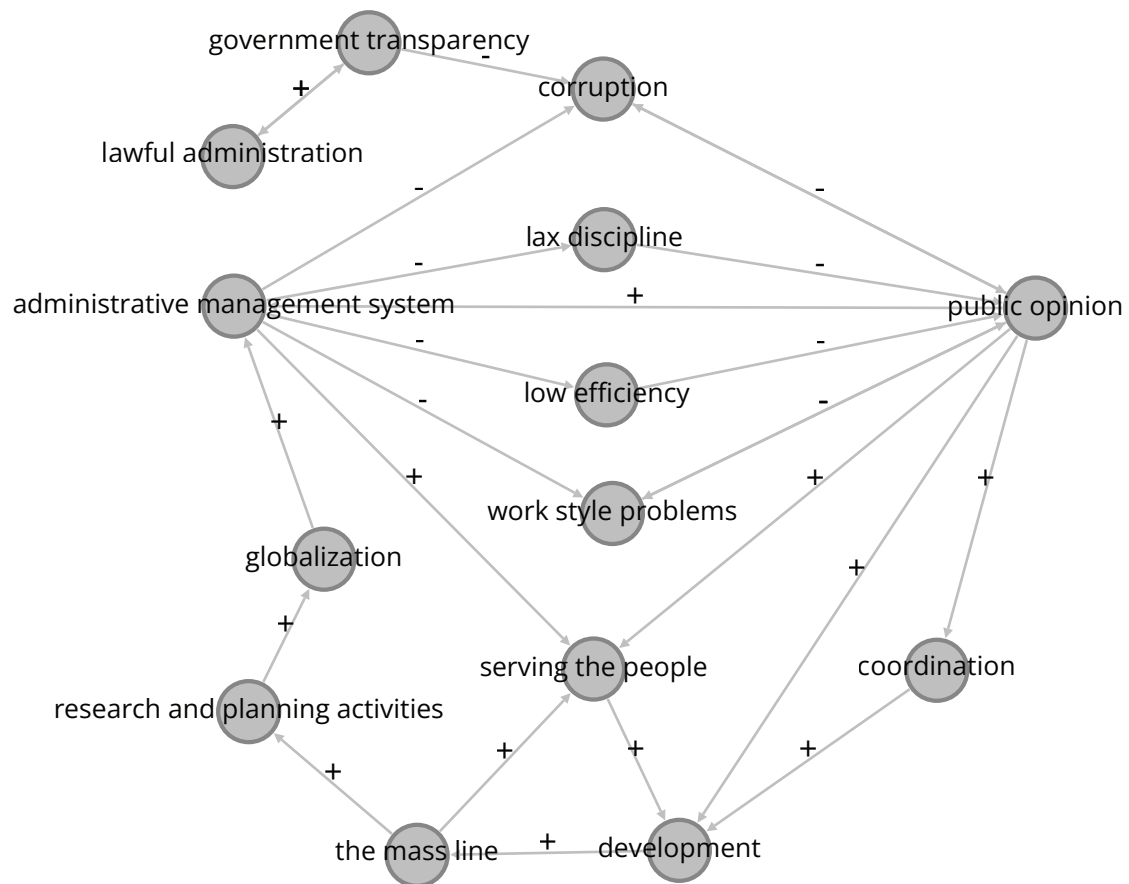


Figure 4.5: The relationship between public opinion, the administrative management system, and development

Note. Figure created by the author based on the analysis of the research data.

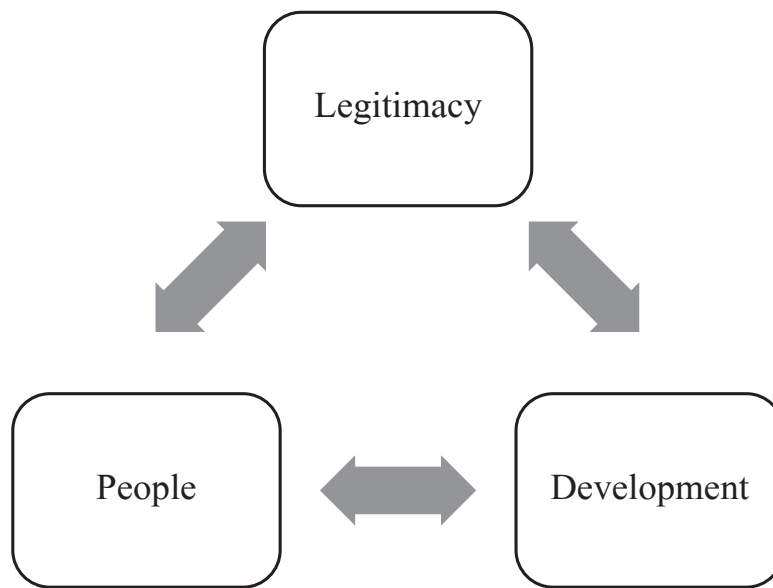


Figure 4.6: The relationship between legitimacy, development, and the people

Note. Figure created by the author.

4.2.1.4 The Relationship Between Development, Order, and Leadership

Xi's cognitive map provides an accurate picture of his understanding of development and its relationship with order, but the connection between these two and leadership does not yield satisfactory results. Xi's discourse on order is well-developed in tone and, contrary to expectations, he is unwilling to define a leadership role for China. As noted, this can be linked to Deng Xiaoping's strategy of "silent progress." Deng explicitly stated that China should not seek leadership and should continue its development without engaging in such matters. In other words, even if there is a belief in China's leadership role at the international level, Chinese policymakers, including Xi, are not willing to express it publicly.

Xi's emphasis on solidarity, cooperation, inclusiveness, equality, and other concepts framed under the umbrella of a "community with a shared future for mankind" can be seen as a response to the West perceiving China's development as a threat. As noted in Chapter Three, the Tiananmen Square protests heightened concerns about China's development as a communist state; however, concerns about China's governing system were only part of Western apprehensions. The core of these concerns lies in China's economic growth, increasing power, and its impact on the global balance of power. Accordingly, China cannot halt its development merely because its rise might provoke a sense of threat in the United States and trigger a hegemonic conflict.

In response to these Western reactions, Xi describes a world in which different states cooperate to achieve the common goal of development, with international institutions like the United Nations overseeing this cooperation based on consultation and respect for all countries. According to his cognitive map, the path to such a world involves strengthening cooperation, and the Belt and Road Initiative serves as a tool for achieving this cooperation. From this perspective, it can be inferred that Xi envisions a “Tianxia-like” system in which international organizations play the role of a central authority, while states act as sub-units akin to traditional Tianxia sub-states.

The problem with this interpretation is that existing international institutions cannot perform the same role as a central, order-establishing state in a Tianxia system. In other words, military intervention by the Security Council to maintain order, as might have been possible in China’s historical context, does not occur in the contemporary world. From this perspective, Qin Yaqing’s relational theory can explain why Xi believes that by strengthening cooperation, it is possible to build an order in which shared developmental objectives lead to stability and lasting peace. As noted, according to this theory, the identities and interests of actors are constructed and reconstructed through ongoing interactions, and thus can serve as a basis for order-building.

Unfortunately, these conjectures based on theory do little to clarify Xi’s actual perceptions on the matter. At the theoretical level, they merely represent one of several possible perspectives on China’s approach and objectives concerning international order and the role of the Belt and Road Initiative in achieving them.

Despite these theoretical interpretations regarding the role of Chinese leadership, one cannot escape the fact that China takes the initiative in its foreign interactions. China’s investment capacity and economic role are vital for many countries. China has also demonstrated in its diplomatic behavior that it is not afraid to apply pressure or force (often in the form of limiting economic cooperation) to protect its red lines. For example, in 2010, when the Obama administration, along with ASEAN countries, pressured China over its claims in the South China Sea, then-Foreign Minister Yang Jiechi³ stared at the Singaporean Foreign Minister and said, “China is a big country and the other countries are small countries, and that is simply a fact.” Shortly thereafter, the Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs issued a statement claiming that the United States had ganged up with other countries against China (Pomfret, 2010). The Philippine Defense Minister commented on China’s behavior in the South China Sea, saying, “China’s behavior toward smaller countries is like that of a bully in a schoolyard... the issue is not merely about stealing lunch money, but actually about stealing lunch boxes, chairs, and even school enrollment” (Watson et al., 2023). In recent years, with China’s growing economic and military power,

³杨洁篪 (*Yáng Jiéchí*)

Chinese leaders expect humility and respect from other powers, both large and especially small (Lowsen, 2018).

Given this, the reinforcing relationship between development and its legitimacy-building role in domestic politics with order can provide a basis for examining the role of Xi Jinping's perceptions in launching the Belt and Road Initiative. The next section addresses the process tracing of the Belt and Road Initiative, taking into account the role of Xi's perceptions in its initiation.

4.3 Tracing the Process of the Belt and Road Initiative

As noted in the methodology chapter, in order to validate the findings of this study, they must be subjected to process tracing. This requires that Xi's perceptions regarding the relationship between **development, order, and leadership** be conceptually reconstructed as a causal mechanism, that this mechanism be operationalized, and that empirical evidence be gathered and tested to demonstrate a causal link between the hypothesized mechanism and the Belt and Road Initiative.

An important caveat at this stage is that process tracing as a method, and cognitive map theory in particular, do not claim exclusive causality. It is widely acknowledged that policy decisions are the outcome of complex and intertwined causal factors and typically pursue multiple material and strategic motivations simultaneously. This is an inherent feature of international politics and applies to virtually all foreign policy decisions. Material motivations—such as the pursuit of national interest, security, or development—do not automatically translate into policy outcomes; rather, they are interpreted, prioritized, and operationalized through decision-makers' perceptions, eventually manifesting as foreign policy choices. It is evident that decision-makers select options they believe will best advance their objectives, and in this sense, every decision reflects a perception-based causal mechanism consistent with instrumental rationality. What distinguishes perception-based explanations is that they imply that goals and beliefs may change independently of objective material conditions, thereby leading to different policy choices (Bennett & Checkel, 2015, p. 45).

This study does not claim that the Belt and Road Initiative is solely the product of Xi Jinping's perceptions or that it emerged independently of factors at the international-system and state levels. On the contrary, structural and economic variables played a crucial enabling role. However, these factors do not uniquely or deterministically specify a single policy path. Xi Jinping's perceptions of the relationship between development, order, and leadership can be understood as a cognitive filter that shaped the framing, design, and legitimation of the Belt and Road Initiative. From this perspective, the BRI should not

be seen merely as a material response, but as a policy translation of a specific cognitive framework.

The conditions at the international-system and state levels that gave rise to the Belt and Road Initiative were not unique to the period following Xi Jinping's rise to power. As discussed in Chapter Three, China faced similar international pressures and domestic challenges under Jiang Zemin and Hu Jintao. Nevertheless, the policy responses adopted by these earlier leaders differed markedly from the Belt and Road Initiative advanced under Xi.

To validate the findings, this section employs a *longitudinal, within-unit covariational design*, which examines the covariation between ideas and policy outcomes within a single political unit (China) across different time periods and under different leaders. A longitudinal analysis allows for the differentiation of temporal sub-cases within a single unit, thereby assessing the explanatory power of ideational variables relative to purely material explanations (Jacobs, 2014, pp. 60–61).

In this analysis, China remains the constant unit of analysis, while the transition in leadership from Jiang Zemin to Hu Jintao and subsequently to Xi Jinping corresponds to shifts in dominant cognitive frameworks. Since many structural and international pressures—such as the need for economic growth, the maintenance of social stability, the enhancement of domestic legitimacy, and responses to international reactions to China's rise—remained broadly stable across these periods, significant variation in policy responses cannot be attributed solely to changes in material conditions. Under such circumstances, following the logic of *covariation over time*, the relative stability of material variables combined with variation in ideas and decisions weakens materialist explanations and provides supporting evidence for the role of perceptual variables.

This section of the study identifies the different factors by examining the points of convergence and divergence between Xi's leadership and that of his two predecessors, clarifies the role of Xi's perceptions in launching the Belt and Road Initiative, and addresses the research question.

4.3.1 Comparison of the Approaches of Jiang, Hu, and Xi

As discussed in Chapter Three, at the state level, all three leaders faced similar challenges. China's economic growth following the launch of the reform and opening-up policies was largely based on the utilization of cheap labor, attracting foreign investment, and establishing an organized export-oriented model. However, from the late 1990s and early 2000s (the Jiang Zemin period), this model encountered a series of structural constraints, indicating the gradual erosion of the traditional advantages based on the "China price".⁴

⁴Low prices of Chinese products.

The continuous rise in wages, the declining supply of migrant labor in coastal areas, and the increasing demands of workers were the main factors that weakened past cost advantages and exerted considerable pressure on industrial profit margins, particularly in the garment sector. Furthermore, the implementation of stricter labor and environmental regulations, along with the expansion of corporate social responsibility (CSR) requirements imposed by international buyers, increased production costs and made firm operations more challenging. On the other hand, the geographic concentration of production in coastal regions—an outcome of the economy's reliance on exports and cheap labor—exacerbated development gaps between coastal and inland areas and highlighted the need for government intervention to reduce regional inequalities and mitigate social risks (Zhu & Pickles, 2014, pp. 37–38).

At the international system level, the response of the international community to Chinese projects during the “Go Global” strategy and the Belt and Road Initiative is very similar. Since the introduction of Jiang's strategies in the early 2000s, the international literature regarding China's development and its implications for the world, as well as countries' approaches to these projects, has changed little.

The approach of all three leaders to addressing these challenges is at least discursively very similar. All three recognize the importance of development for legitimacy. All three believe that China needs foreign investment to sustain development, and their foreign policy discourse is also linguistically close. To the extent that if the speeches of all three leaders were placed side by side and certain leader-specific keywords removed, it would be difficult to determine which speech belongs to which leader. The differences in the approaches of Jiang, Hu, and Xi lie less in the substance of the concepts than in the prioritization of these demands within the broader governance agenda and how they are operationalized; in other words, the structural configuration of these concepts within the larger system of perceptions of these three leaders differs.

During the Jiang Zemin period, external economic engagement was primarily understood as a tool to ensure domestic modernization and strengthen regime resilience in the uncertain environment following the suppression of the Tiananmen protests and structural economic pressures. The “Go Global” strategy and related ideas well represent Jiang Zemin's policy outlook. According to Jiang, by utilizing domestic and international markets and resources to achieve development, the country becomes powerful and, through this, can address any challenge in the world (M. Ye, 2020, p. 93). With the intensification of problems such as excess production capacity, non-performing loans, and loss-making state-owned enterprises in the mid-1990s, he focused on mobilizing state-owned enterprises to go abroad in order to secure financial resources and new markets (M. Ye, 2020, p. 94). Jiang's perspective on the relationship between development and order empha-

sized domestic development and strengthening China; in other words, as long as China develops, it becomes powerful and can overcome international challenges.

In contrast, Hu Jintao is generally described as a collective, process-oriented, and risk-averse leader who relied more on institutions, procedures, and consensus for decision-making. He did not want the impression to arise that he was creating or relying on a private circle of associates. In this way, he sought to differentiate himself from Jiang, who followed such an approach, thereby gaining the support of officials dissatisfied with Jiang's behavior. Moreover, Hu had worked for over a decade in the central party apparatus, which reinforced his habit of using institutions (H. Lai, 2010, p. 151). This institutionalized and multi-actor mechanism increased the influence of multiple actors in the design of China's foreign policies, which in turn made major foreign policy changes dependent on reaching consensus (H. Lai, 2010, pp. 154–155). On the other hand, two dominant discourses during Hu's period—the “Scientific Outlook on Development” and the “Harmonious Society”⁵—emphasized equality, balanced development, and the management of social and environmental consequences of development, implicitly warning that growth based solely on GDP could erode the cohesion and legitimacy of the Communist Party (X. Guo, 2019, p. 193).

This style of governance prevented Hu Jintao from launching a major initiative like the Belt and Road Initiative. Although infrastructure diplomacy was actively pursued prior to the Belt and Road Initiative during Hu's tenure, diplomats did not have direct access to the financial levers controlled by other institutions (such as the National Development and Reform Commission and state-owned banks), and the dispersion of authority limited the ability to package and coordinate projects. As a result, many proposals similar to the Belt and Road Initiative during his time remained largely at the proposal stage (M. Ye, 2020, pp. 117–119). Consequently, although Hu's period saw increased overseas infrastructure activities and the foundations of both Xi Jinping's proposals for the Silk Road Economic Belt and the 21st Century Maritime Silk Road were laid during Hu Jintao's era, the weak coordination capacity meant these efforts achieved limited diplomatic outcomes (M. Ye, 2020, p. 120).

Moreover, Hu's era experience shows how domestic legitimacy and sensitivities regarding balanced resource distribution could constrain extensive overseas spending, especially when such spending was framed as “assistance to less-developed foreign regions.” For instance, when former Deputy Minister of the State Taxation Administration⁶, Xu Shanda⁷ proposed a “Chinese Marshall Plan” involving massive overseas expenditures conditional on prioritizing Chinese companies, he faced strong criticism. Critics explicitly asked why

⁵和谐社会 (*Héxié Shèhuì*).

⁶国家税务总局 (*Guójiā Shuìwù Zǒngjú*).

⁷徐善达 (*Xú Shàndá*).

“money should be wasted abroad” when domestic regions of China still required state investment (M. Ye, 2020, pp. 120–121). These reactions were aligned with Hu Jintao’s developmental tendencies and those of the *Tuanpai*, or Communist Youth League faction, more generally. Policy preferences focused on redistribution, reducing inequality, and building a harmonious society aimed at strengthening domestic purchasing power and social stability, forming one of the hallmarks of their policy approach (X. Guo, 2019, p. 238). Overall, Hu pursued stability and the legitimacy derived from it through domestic justice and prudence in the international arena. Combined with the bureaucratic dispersion of financial control, this made integrating connectivity-oriented initiatives similar to the Belt and Road Initiative into a single coherent plan difficult.

Xi Jinping, in this context, represents a third configuration. This means that external connectivity and overseas infrastructure financing were explicitly defined as extensions of domestic development goals and the legitimization of the ruling system in China, and this linkage was subsequently supported by centralized authority at the top level and institutional coordination. Rather than viewing overseas projects merely as a form of scattered “infrastructure diplomacy,” Xi situated the “Silk Road Economic Belt” within the same geographical and administrative space as the “Western Development Strategy” and combined it with the “Going Global” strategy; an action that provided political coverage and a fresh impetus to existing domestic regional development priorities through foreign investment and also brought the central coordinating apparatus of the Western Development Strategy into the implementation chain of the Belt and Road Initiative (M. Ye, 2020, p. 74). Xi’s elevated authority in foreign policy decision-making, which enabled more coherent mobilization across institutions (Sutter, 2021, p. 137), alongside an ideological framework expressed in concepts such as the “Chinese Dream,” reinforced this process; Xi’s framework explicitly establishes a strong linkage between domestic governance, welfare, and stability with China’s external role and status in the world (X. Guo, 2019, pp. 194–195). In this way, it allows for the justification of foreign investment within the domestic political space.

In the international order, Xi also framed China’s domestic development as a strengthening factor for regional and global peace and stability. Although the idea of a “Community of Shared Future for Mankind,” promoted by Xi Jinping, directly inherits concepts articulated by previous leaders, its configuration as a mega-infrastructure project, involving other countries and aiming at order-building, is the result of these concepts being arranged in a new and elevated structure. This new configuration simultaneously links domestic development to the international order, creating a reciprocal relationship between the two. As a result, both domestic and international concerns are addressed simultaneously.

In contrast, China's development and the response to international pressures during the Hu and Jiang periods were configured separately. While it is true that, in essence, the discourse of all three leaders advocated an order based on China's interests, the translation of this discourse into an actionable program—where China takes initiative and actively pursues its realization—is the outcome of the linkage Xi establishes between China's development and the international order.

Overall, it can be said that the differences in foreign policy outcomes across the Jiang, Hu, and Xi periods do not stem from fundamental changes in objectives or material conditions at the level of the international system or the state, but from differences in the configuration of concepts related to leadership style, domestic development, and international order. Jiang viewed development as a precondition for power and the resolution of external issues, treating external engagement as a tool serving domestic modernization; Hu, emphasizing institutionalized, consensus-based governance and equity in resource distribution, constrained China's capacity to consolidate resources and formulate large transnational initiatives; and finally, Xi, by concentrating authority, coordinating institutions, and redefining external connectivity as an extension of legitimacy and domestic development on one hand, and framing China's development as a reinforcing factor for order on the other, was able to integrate these scattered elements into a coherent project with a clearly defined configuration, acceptable domestically and intelligible internationally. In this way, the Belt and Road Initiative is not merely the accumulation of previous policies, but the product of a qualitative leap in the way legitimacy and development requirements in domestic policy are linked with the demands of order in the international space under Xi Jinping's leadership.

4.4 Conclusion

The findings of this chapter indicate that Xi Jinping's perceptions regarding development and order have played a key role in the design and launch of the Belt and Road Initiative. Although the findings concerning the linkage between the concepts of development and order with the concept of leadership were not fully satisfactory due to limited access to sources, attempts were made to fill this gap by examining academic articles and scholarly debates within China. Nevertheless, it cannot be stated with certainty what position Xi Jinping assigns to China's leadership in the international order.

Xi's cognitive map shows that development and its sustainability occupy a central place in his perceptions. Like his predecessors, Xi views development as the ultimate goal and the primary source of legitimacy within the domestic political context. Moreover, Xi's cognitive map reveals a reciprocal relationship among the people, legitimacy, and

development. Development, by increasing popular satisfaction, generates legitimacy, and legitimacy, by encouraging public cooperation, creates the conditions for the realization of development.

Process tracing in this chapter demonstrated how Xi Jinping's configuration of perceptions created convergence between domestic and international needs. On one hand, China's economy required overseas investment to sustain development, while on the other, slow development in the central and western provinces generated dissatisfaction in these regions regarding such investments. By aligning domestic development with overseas investment, Xi was able to address this problem. Xi's cognitive map indicates that, in his perceptions, international investment can lead to simultaneous development for China and other countries. By choosing the "Silk Road," he references China's historical experience of successful engagement with the outside world, and by integrating the Western Development Strategy into the Belt and Road Initiative, he prevents dissatisfaction in the western provinces resulting from China's overseas investments. He even appointed the same managers to the Belt and Road Initiative who had previously overseen the implementation of the Western Development Strategy (M. Ye, 2020, p. 74).

Despite the limitations of cognitive approaches in studying leaders' decisions, this chapter was able, through process tracing, to reveal the differences between Xi Jinping's perspective and that of his two predecessors. The chapter showed that by establishing a positive reciprocal linkage between China's domestic development and the international order, Xi not only seeks to reduce international skepticism toward China but also addresses legitimacy challenges that Hu Jintao faced by connecting international investment projects to the development of China's domestic regions. These perceptions ultimately found operational expression in the Belt and Road Initiative and led to the emergence of this vast infrastructure project.

Chapter 5

Conclusion

5.1 Introduction

This chapter aims to explain the overall logic of the research findings, situate them within the theoretical literature, and extract their research and policy implications. Within this framework, the results obtained from the analyses in the preceding chapters are revisited in direct relation to the main research question, showing how these findings contribute to understanding the reasons behind the formation of the Belt and Road Initiative. The focus of this chapter is on providing a concise analytical interpretation of the results and clarifying their theoretical and policy implications, while avoiding a detailed repetition of the data and empirical evidence presented earlier.

This thesis, entitled “Xi Jinping’s Perceptions and the Belt and Road Initiative,” sought to answer the question: “Why did China launch the Belt and Road Initiative?” To this end, using qualitative content analysis of selected texts within a theoretical framework based on cognitive mapping theory, an effort was made to reconstruct the conceptual network and causal relationships within Xi Jinping’s cognitive system. Through this process, the central hypothesis of the research—that Xi Jinping’s perceptions regarding the relationship among development, order, and leadership played a role in launching the Belt and Road Initiative—was tested and its validity evaluated.

5.2 Summary of the Main Findings

This study answered its research question through a multistage process. First, a purposive set of Xi Jinping’s speeches, interviews, and official documents from the specified period was collected and sampled according to defined criteria. The selected texts were then coded manually through qualitative content analysis to extract key concepts and propositions containing causal or normative relationships. Next, the concepts were integrated and

their relationships organized in an Excel file, on the basis of which the cognitive map was reconstructed. Once the map had been drawn, measures including the number of connections, conceptual clusters, and feedback cycles were analyzed to clarify the internal logic of the cognitive system. Finally, process tracing placed this cognitive structure alongside the policy developments and chronology surrounding the formation of the Belt and Road Initiative, allowing the correspondence between cognitive patterns and the policy decision to be assessed and the causal relationship between them to be inferred.

The findings of the research indicate that although the Belt and Road Initiative emerged through the gradual evolution of China's responses to the structural pressures of the international system and the material imperatives of the Chinese economy, the configuration of Xi Jinping's perceptions has played a pivotal role in shaping and designing this initiative. The analysis of the cognitive map demonstrates that these imperatives and interests, after passing through the filter of Xi Jinping's cognitive framework, have been articulated in the form of a comprehensive transregional policy.

The research indicates that China's rapid development in the 1990s and 2000s generated both domestic and international challenges for the nation. This accelerated growth led to increasing disparities between the coastal provinces and the central and western provinces of China. During this period, the Chinese economy as a whole required strategies that were not necessarily aligned with the developmental needs of its western provinces. Another consequence of this rapid expansion was the often-negative international reaction to the rapid growth of this emerging power.

The research, by tracing the process of responses across three successive leaders, including Xi Jinping, demonstrates how each leader's style of leadership shaped the nature of China's reactions to these challenges. In this context, Xi Jinping's perceptions, by establishing a link between domestic development and its implications for the international order, seek to construct a mutually reinforcing causal relationship between China's development and the development of its partner countries. The Belt and Road Initiative represents the practical embodiment of this formulation.

In summary, within Xi's cognitive system, development is defined as a central objective that is simultaneously connected to domestic political legitimacy and a particular conception of the international order. The cognitive map indicates that, in Xi Jinping's mindset, China's domestic development and its international role derive from a common root and are inseparable. Within this framework, the Belt and Road Initiative functions as a policy instrument to sustain the continuity of domestic development, reproduce Party legitimacy, and manage the international environment in a manner compatible with China's vision of a desirable order.

By linking domestic developmental concerns to an international program, Xi Jinping has succeeded in framing the Belt and Road Initiative as both an effective and useful solution for maintaining the possibility of continued domestic development and as an order-shaping instrument in the international arena. By tying China's developmental interests to the national interests of other countries, he seeks to reduce external anxieties about China's rising power while simultaneously justifying large-scale overseas investments to the Chinese people. In this way, as the fate of development in China's inland provinces becomes intertwined with international investments, the Party's domestic legitimacy is preserved and popular support for these infrastructure projects is secured.

This conclusion is consistent with arguments advanced in some of the studies reviewed in the literature review, particularly the view that the Belt and Road Initiative is the product of the convergence of domestic and international politics (Clarke, 2018). What the present research adds to the existing literature is an explanation of why this convergence occurs in the Xi Jinping era and the role of his perceptions in shaping it.

5.3 Research Limitations and Suggestions for Future Research

Perception-based research generally faces a range of challenges. Limited access to internal decision-making data, the difficulty of directly observing cognitive mechanisms, and the entanglement of ideas with material interests are among the main obstacles of this approach. This study likewise cannot claim to offer a complete and precise account of Xi Jinping's perceptions, due to the lack of access to texts in which he expresses his views without consideration or restraint. This limitation is particularly significant given that secrecy and the maintenance of appearances are among the salient characteristics of Chinese politicians and of Chinese foreign policy more broadly.

Nevertheless, the influence of perceptions on policy choices cannot be disregarded. Numerous studies, including the present one, demonstrate that leaders' perceptions have a real impact on actual policy decisions. This is especially the case in the contemporary era, in which the structure of the international system presents decision-makers with a wide range of policy options and does not constrain choices to the same extent as during the bipolar Cold War period. The study of perceptions makes it possible to identify subtle details in leaders' decision-making processes and to incorporate them into policy formulation and analytical assessments. Identifying the ways in which concepts are interconnected within leaders' cognitive maps can contribute to the analysis of their states' behavior and even help anticipate policy decisions under similar conditions.

By examining the Belt and Road Initiative as a major infrastructure program, this research has contributed to clarifying certain aspects of Xi Jinping's perceptions. Future studies can examine other initiatives proposed by Xi, such as the Global Development Initiative and the Global Security Initiative, in order to explore additional dimensions of his perceptions. In this way, a more comprehensive picture of his perceptions across different issue areas can be developed, and the configuration of key concepts within his cognitive framework can be identified.

At the same time, incorporating a perceptual approach into analysis must always be done with caution. The lack of access to reliable information—such as correspondence, records of communications among leaders, and decision-making meetings—undermines the possibility of reconstructing an accurate cognitive system. Moreover, the implementation of qualitative methods for extracting causal relationships is time-consuming and makes comprehensive coverage of primary sources costly. As a result, research in this area faces serious challenges at the levels of data access, theory and methodology, and operational implementation, all of which must be taken into account when conducting such studies.

From the perspective of data access, linguistic barriers as well as strategic and security considerations consistently pose serious challenges for perception-based research. Consequently, such studies must proceed with caution in formulating research questions and expectations, and must take these limitations seriously throughout the research process and in the presentation of findings. Nevertheless, from a methodological and theoretical standpoint, researchers can turn to cases in which documents have been declassified and made publicly available. Given the political system governing China, the likelihood of sensitive or classified materials becoming public is extremely low, which can constitute a major obstacle to deeper research. Even so, China's intellectual and theoretical discourse represents a novel terrain that seeks to introduce new ideas into the existing literature on international politics. Although these ideas may not reflect individuals' genuine internal beliefs, in light of China's growing importance and the novelty of the ideas advanced, they are sufficiently significant to warrant examination even at this public level.

Overall, the perceptual approach offers researchers a relatively novel research space through which, by addressing gaps in the mainstream theories and methodologies of international relations, they can contribute to enriching the discipline's scholarly and analytical landscape. Perceptual considerations are particularly valuable during periods of foreign policy crises and negotiation processes, which are relatively more influenced by the perceptions of the individuals involved, and can thus provide substantial assistance to analysts and decision-makers in the field of foreign policy.

5.4 Policy Implications for the Islamic Republic of Iran

Understanding the perceptual logic underpinning the Belt and Road Initiative can contribute to shaping more realistic policy expectations on the part of the Islamic Republic of Iran regarding cooperation with China. Such an understanding indicates that considerations of domestic development, political legitimacy, and international order-building are simultaneously present in Beijing's policy calculations. Consequently, economic cooperation with China is not merely material in nature, but also carries potential normative and order-shaping implications. Conversely, strategic and order-oriented partnerships, given their close linkage to domestic legitimacy and development, cannot be pursued independently of economic interests. Attention to this logic can facilitate the formulation of proposals that are more closely aligned with the underlying objectives of the Initiative.

By recognizing the centrality of “the possibility of sustained development” and the constraints imposed by the need to preserve domestic legitimacy on Chinese leaders, policy actions undertaken by Beijing can be more accurately interpreted. For example, alongside material incentives, the insistence of Chinese companies on employing Chinese labor can also be understood as an effort by Beijing to maintain the domestic legitimacy of overseas investments in the eyes of the Chinese public. From this perspective, expectations regarding the employment of local labor in projects should be articulated with due consideration of the constraints facing Chinese policymakers.

Similarly, the shared roots of development and regional and global order in the discourse of leaders across the past three generations should be taken into account when calibrating expectations toward Beijing and interpreting its behavior. The common foundations of development and order in Xi Jinping's perceptions indicate that, for him, security and development are not separable domains. In other words, the assessment of any potential form of economic cooperation, beyond its material benefits, may also inherently involve considerations regarding its potential impact on order. From this perspective, China may be reluctant to enter into economic partnerships that lack an element of order-building or peace-building.

Alongside these constraints, an understanding of the centrality of China's domestic development also highlights certain opportunities. Emphasizing cooperation proposals that take into account the economic conditions of China's central and western provinces increases the likelihood of their acceptance by Beijing. In other words, by considering the legitimacy-related motivations underlying the launch of the Belt and Road Initiative, it becomes possible to focus on areas of convergence between the Islamic Republic of Iran and these regions—particularly provinces with large Muslim populations—and to propose programs that are more closely aligned with the Initiative's underlying objectives.

Finally, the Belt and Road Initiative relies to a significant extent on Xi Jinping's capacity to manage domestic concerns and international pressures. At the same time, given the Initiative's fragmented and non-institutionalized character, it should be understood more as an approach than as a fully codified program. Any effort to situate the Initiative within the policy planning of the Islamic Republic of Iran should therefore take into account the possibility that, with a change in leadership in China, the status and salience of the Initiative could potentially decline abruptly. Although its importance has grown to a level that makes its complete disappearance from China's foreign policy unlikely, this does not guarantee that the same degree of attention and focus will necessarily persist in its current form after Xi Jinping. In other words, just as many previously unrelated projects—some of which predated the Belt and Road Initiative—were incorporated under this framework during Xi's leadership, a reverse process may also occur, whereby Chinese projects are reoriented toward a different overarching approach and strategic vision.

5.5 Conclusion

In the final analysis, this research demonstrates that the Belt and Road Initiative cannot be analyzed solely at the level of the international system or the level of the state. Rather, it is the outcome of the filtration of requirements, interests, and necessities through Xi Jinping's cognitive system—a system in which domestic development, political legitimacy, the international order, and China's leadership role are causally and interdependently configured. Reconstructing the Chinese leader's cognitive map shows that the initiative has functioned as a deliberate instrument for linking domestic development, political legitimacy, and the management of the international order. From this perspective, by adding a perceptual dimension to the existing literature, the present study offers a less reductionist account of China's Belt and Road Initiative and underscores the importance of attending to the role of leadership in the analysis of the country's grand policies.

Appendix A

A Critical Examination of the Belt and Road Initiative

Appendix A introduces and critically examines the Belt and Road Initiative. First proposed by Xi Jinping in 2013, the Belt and Road Initiative is considered China's most ambitious foreign policy project in the contemporary era. Known under the titles "Silk Road Economic Belt" and "21st Century Maritime Silk Road," the initiative gradually became the backbone of China's foreign policy and the central element of Xi's personal strategy, to the extent that in 2017 it was enshrined as one of the fundamental principles in the Constitution of the Communist Party of China (International Department of the Central Committee of the CPC, 2018). The main objective of this initiative is to create a vast network of transportation and energy infrastructure connecting China to three continents: Asia, Africa, and Europe (McBride et al., 2023). At official levels, the project is aimed at strengthening regional economic ties, facilitating trade, promoting financial integration, and fostering cultural exchanges among nations through the construction of railways, ports, highways, and pipelines (MERICS, 2018).

As shown in Figure A.1, the Belt and Road Initiative is structured around two main pillars: the Silk Road Economic Belt, which encompasses land-based routes across Eurasia, and the 21st Century Maritime Silk Road, which connects China to key European ports via the Indian Ocean.¹ (China Economic Information Service, 2023; MERICS, 2018). Implemented through multiple economic corridors, the initiative covers a wide range of strategic regions, including Southeast and South Asia, Central Asia, the Middle East, and East Africa. Chinese leaders have portrayed the initiative as a model of win-win cooperation and shared development, while simultaneously viewing it as a mechanism for expanding China's economic and infrastructural influence on a global scale (Haenle, 2017).

¹The earlier expression "One Belt, One Road," later rendered as the Belt and Road Initiative, combines the "belt" of the Silk Road Economic Belt with the "road" of the Maritime Silk Road.

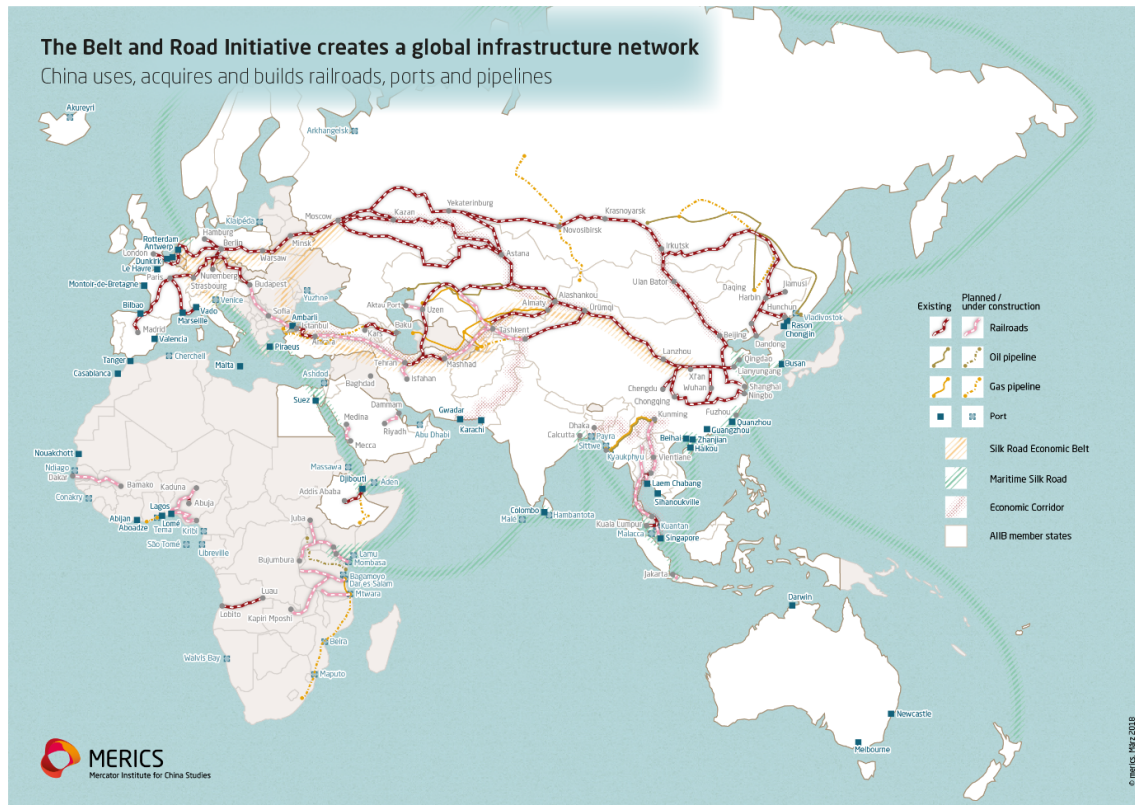


Figure A.1: Connectivity Corridors of the Belt and Road Initiative

Note. Screenshot reprinted from *Mapping the Belt and Road Initiative: This Is Where We Stand*, by MERICS, 2018, Mercator Institute for China Studies (<https://merics.org/en/tracker/mapping-belt-and-road-initiative-where-we-stand>). Copyright 2018 by Mercator Institute for China Studies.

One of the most prominent strategic cases of the initiative is the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC),² which, with an estimated budget exceeding \$62 billion, has established a network of transportation, energy, and communication infrastructure linking western China to Pakistan’s Gwadar Port (McBride et al., 2023). Similar projects are underway across various regions, including Central Asia, Southeast Asia, Africa, the Middle East, and Europe. Notable examples include port development projects in Greece and the construction of railway lines connecting to Western Europe (Xinhua, 2023). In addition, the establishment of institutions such as the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB)³ and the organization of related international forums highlight the initiative’s institutional and coordinating dimensions in financing and economic policymaking.

More than a decade after its launch, the Belt and Road Initiative has expanded far beyond its original Eurasian scope and has effectively become a global project. By the first half of 2025, approximately 146 to 150 countries⁴—representing more than two-thirds of the world’s population—had joined the initiative or formally expressed interest in participation (Nedopil, 2025b). According to the latest report by the Griffith Asia Institute at Griffith University, China’s total financial engagement under the initiative between 2013 and June 2025 reached \$1.308 trillion, comprising \$775 billion in construction contracts and \$533 billion in direct investment (Nedopil, 2025a, p. 7). This upward trajectory continues to lend credibility to earlier estimates suggesting that total project costs could eventually approach \$8 trillion (McBride et al., 2023). The expanding scale of the initiative has nevertheless generated growing concern among some international actors.

From a geopolitical perspective, the Belt and Road Initiative has faced negative reactions and strategic skepticism from several key actors. The United States, India, and some European countries view the initiative not merely as an economic project but as a tool for expanding China’s political influence and military power (McBride et al., 2023). U.S. officials have even described it as a “Trojan horse” for advancing China’s regional dominance, warning that infrastructure investments in ports along major maritime routes—from the Indian Ocean to the Mediterranean—could challenge the United States’ maritime balance of power (Haenle, 2017). India, citing the passage of the China–Pakistan Economic Corridor through the disputed region of Kashmir, has refused to join the Belt and Road Initiative and has expressed concern over the expansion of China’s naval presence in the Indian Ocean. In Europe, concerns regarding China’s influence over sensitive infrastructure—such as strategic ports and fifth-generation (5G) telecommunications networks—have led

²中巴经济走廊 (*Zhōng-Bā Jīngjì Zǒuláng*)

³亚洲基础设施投资银行 (*Yàzhōu Jīchǔ Shèshī Tóuzī Yínháng*)

⁴Participation in the Belt and Road Initiative generally refers to the signing of a memorandum of understanding with China. Some countries—for example, Russia—have not formally confirmed the signing of such a document. As a result, calculating the exact number of participating countries is subject to methodological challenges.

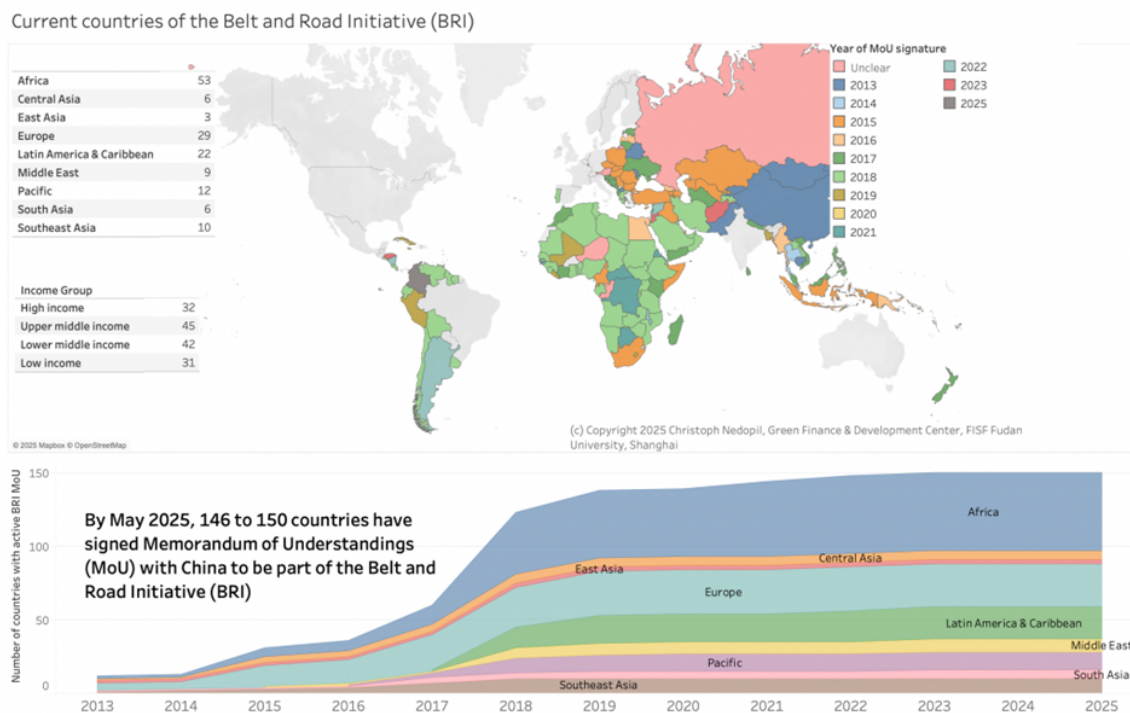


Figure A.2: Countries Participating in the Belt and Road Initiative

Note. Reprinted from *Countries of the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)*, by C. Nedopil, 2025, Green Finance & Development Center, FISF, Fudan University (<https://greenfdc.org/countries-of-the-belt-and-road-initiative-bri/>). Copyright 2025 by the Green Finance & Development Center.

to a reduction in the level of cooperation with the initiative. Moreover, some governments, due to sovereignty-related concerns and the high costs of project implementation, have decided to suspend or limit their cooperation; countries such as Malaysia, Myanmar, and Tanzania have cancelled or revised several projects (Jie & Wallace, 2021). Even Italy, the only G7 country that had signed a memorandum of understanding to join the initiative, ultimately withdrew due to domestic political pressure (Sacks, 2023). Convincing global public opinion of the Belt and Road Initiative's purely economic and development-oriented nature thus remains one of China's fundamental challenges in advancing this project.

Despite its wide geographic scope and large-scale investments, not all projects associated with the Belt and Road Initiative have been economically successful. Some of the infrastructure developed under the initiative—particularly in less developed regions—has exhibited limited economic functionality and has failed to meet expectations regarding increased trade flows and revenue generation. These shortcomings are especially evident in ports and railway lines constructed in areas lacking an industrial base and characterized by low traffic volumes. Alongside these issues, Chinese banks, which have played a central role in financing these projects, have faced growing financial pressures due to the expansion of high-risk projects and rising levels of non-performing or doubtful debt. As a result, new lending has been carried out with greater caution, and credit policies have been subject to revision (Clark, 2023).

Another fundamental weakness of the Belt and Road Initiative is the absence of a comprehensive and integrated roadmap to guide projects. In practice, many initiatives have been developed on a case-by-case basis and shaped by proposals from Chinese companies or local and partner governments; this has resulted in a lack of strategic coordination, inefficient allocation of resources, and reduced effectiveness of certain investments (Kallio, 2022). At the same time, the development of so-called soft infrastructure, including regulatory alignment, trade agreements, and institutional arrangements, has lagged behind the pace of physical infrastructure development, thereby undermining the overall efficiency of the projects.

In response to these criticisms, the Chinese government has sought to shift the orientation of the initiative from a quantity-driven approach toward an emphasis on quality, redefining it through concepts such as the “Green Silk Road” (Xiao & Ding, 2023). Nevertheless, doubts regarding the financial and diplomatic sustainability of the initiative persist, as the economic returns of many projects remain unclear and the rising costs for China have become a source of concern.

Beyond economic challenges, the Belt and Road Initiative has also encountered significant obstacles in achieving its soft power objectives. While China has promoted the

initiative as a tool for international cooperation and mutual prosperity, this narrative has been met with skepticism in many countries. Critics argue that some projects have resulted in increased economic dependence and heavy debt burdens for host countries, leading the initiative to be interpreted less as an embodiment of “win–win cooperation” and more as an instrument of economic leverage. Some scholars, drawing comparisons with the U.S. Marshall Plan, contend that the Belt and Road Initiative lacks the cultural and ideological appeal necessary to evolve into an effective global brand (Lindley, 2022).

It appears that many participating countries have joined the Belt and Road Initiative not on the basis of shared values or discursive alignment with China, but rather primarily in pursuit of economic benefits. Moreover, China’s domestic political image—particularly the authoritarian nature of its single-party system and security-oriented policies in regions such as Xinjiang and Hong Kong—has subjected China’s official narrative to widespread international criticism. Taken together, these factors have become significant obstacles to the expansion of China’s soft power. Consequently, although the Belt and Road Initiative has achieved some success in strengthening China’s international economic position, its impact on enhancing China’s global political legitimacy and soft power has remained limited.

Although trade data indicate that China’s trade volume with Belt and Road member countries followed an overall upward trend between 2003 and 2023, a closer examination of this period—as illustrated in Figure A.3—reveals that a substantial portion of this growth occurred prior to the initiative’s official announcement in 2013. In the subsequent period, while average annual trade volumes increased, the overall growth rate declined and, in some years, exhibited fluctuations and downturns. This pattern suggests that the Belt and Road Initiative has functioned more as an extension of pre-existing trends in China’s trade development rather than as a fundamental turning point that generated structural transformation.

Meanwhile, the absence of a central institutional framework for international cooperation and the limitation of Belt and Road memoranda to bilateral agreements have effectively transformed the initiative from what could have been a coherent international project—capable of norm creation, new order-building, and the formation of a coordinated cooperation network—into a fragmented collection of commercial contracts with countries that often lack any meaningful structural or regional connection to one another, aside from being designated by China as part of the initiative.

Nevertheless, the Belt and Road Initiative continues to occupy a central position in the foreign policy of the People’s Republic of China and, despite its strategic, economic, and symbolic challenges, remains one of the country’s key strategic instruments in its pursuit

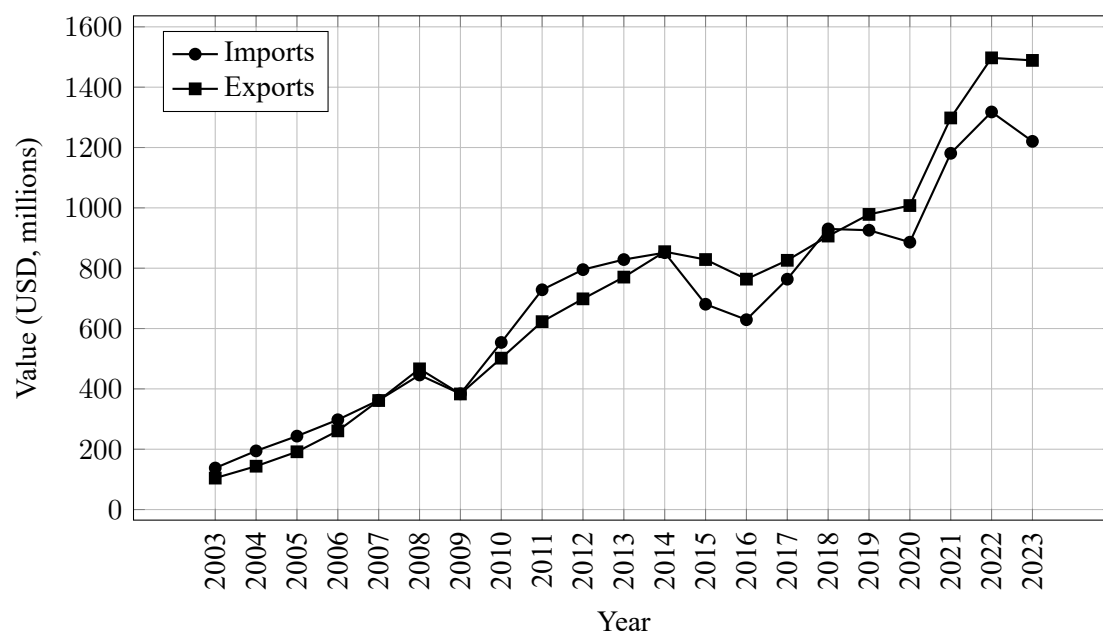


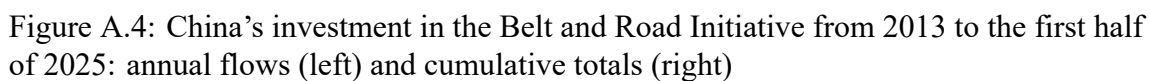
Figure A.3: Total imports and exports between China and Belt and Road member countries

Note. Data compiled by the author from World Bank sources.

of international ascent. China has not only refrained from abandoning the initiative, but its level of investment has reached its highest point since the initiative's launch in 2013.

The Belt and Road Initiative has evolved into a comprehensive and multidimensional framework shaping China's foreign policy and global development strategy. Nevertheless, despite being presented as the most central foreign policy project since China's accession to the World Trade Organization in 2001 (H. Wang, 2019, p. 2), the initiative lacks a clearly defined and binding institutional foundation within the legal system of the People's Republic of China. Although it was incorporated as a strategic objective into the Constitution of the Chinese Communist Party at the nineteenth Party Congress in 2017 (International Department of the Central Committee of the CPC, 2018), no precise legal or executive definition has been articulated in China's state constitution, leaving its formal status ambiguous. Rather than diminishing over time, this ambiguity has deepened: the repeal of the requirement to obtain formal authorization from key implementing bodies in late 2017 and early 2018 further weakened central coordination and undermined the overall coherence of the initiative (Clark, 2023).

The Belt and Road Initiative, contrary to claims that it constitutes a framework for international cooperation, lacks a coherent institutional structure and binding multilateral mechanisms. Unlike comparable Western initiatives—such as the Partnership for Global



Note. Reprinted from *China Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) Investment Report 2025*, by C. Nedopil, 2025, Griffith Asia Institute and Green Finance & Development Center, FISF (<https://doi.org/10.25904/1912/5798>). Copyright 2025 by Griffith Asia Institute and Green Finance & Development Center. Reprinted with permission.

Infrastructure and Investment,⁵ which was advanced by the United States and the G7 in 2022 in response to the Belt and Road Initiative and is characterized by transparent and binding structures grounded in clearly defined governance standards and formal institutional frameworks (Simonov, 2025, p. 3)—the Belt and Road Initiative lacks a centralized international mechanism. Instead, it is largely operationalized through non-binding bilateral memoranda of understanding, which are typically of medium-term duration and offer limited legal guarantees (H. Wang, 2021, p. 5).

In sum, nearly a decade after its inception, the Belt and Road Initiative illustrates both the ambitions and the limitations of China's expansive foreign policy strategy. While it has secured substantial economic engagement and extended China's presence across multiple regions, its implementation has exposed significant structural, financial, and institutional weaknesses. The lack of a centralized governance framework, reliance on non-binding bilateral agreements, and uneven project outcomes highlight the persistent gap between the initiative's stated objectives and its practical achievements. Beyond economic considerations, the initiative's impact on China's global political legitimacy and soft power remains limited, constrained by skepticism from key international actors and by domestic political factors. Taken together, these observations suggest that the Belt and Road Initiative, despite its scale and strategic prominence, embodies the inherent uncertainties and trade-offs of pursuing ambitious global projects within a complex and contested international system.

⁵全球基础设施和投资伙伴关系 (*Quánqiú Jīchǔ Shèshī Hé Tóuzī Huǒbàn Guānxì*)

Appendix B

Large-size cognitive map

Appendix B outlines the steps for data preparation and processing for analysis in the study. This ensures the reproducibility of the research and enables the evaluation of the resulting findings in the analysis section.

As noted earlier, the data in this study can be divided into three broad categories. The first consists of the key concepts articulated in the cognitive map, which form the nodes of the network. The second concerns the relationships among these nodes, that is, the structure of the map. The third is the visual representation of the map itself.

After completing the initial steps for organizing the data, the extracted nodes and links were imported into the Gephi software in a spreadsheet format. The software automatically merges duplicate relationships and represents the frequency of each relationship in the form of a weighted edge. It also calculates the in-degree and out-degree of each node by counting the number of incoming and outgoing links. Degree serves as an indicator of node centrality. In other words, the higher the degree of a node, the more central and significant the concept it represents is within Xi Jinping's cognitive system.

B.1 Key Concepts

The concepts present in Xi Jinping's cognitive map encompass a broad range of issues, reflecting his cognitive system with regard to governance, development, and the international order. The most important dimension of these concepts is economic, and it includes nodes related to growth and development, such as "economic development," "development potential," and "industrial development." It also covers structural economic factors including the "industrial base," "infrastructure construction," "technological innovation," and the "investment environment," as well as economic policies such as "reform and opening up," "state-owned enterprise reform," and "support SME development." In addition, it incorporates modes of interaction and international objectives such as "cooperation," "friendship," and "peace."

Alongside these, governance- and politics-related concepts are also richly present, including “social stability,” “public opinion,” “party conduct and integrity,” “corruption,” “government transparency,” and the “administrative management system,” among others. In addition, ideologically specific nodes of the Chinese Communist Party occupy a prominent position, such as “the mass line,” “serving the people,” “broad democracy,” and “patriotism, socialism, and collectivism,” as well as their opposites, including “money worship, hedonism, and extreme individualism.”

With the introduction of the Belt and Road Initiative, concepts related to governance and development become connected to Xi Jinping’s worldview regarding the global order and the configuration of “China development” within that order, thereby linking discussions of China’s development to international debates. In two speeches related to the Belt and Road Initiative, Xi presents China’s development as reinforcing the development of other countries and links concepts such as “trust,” “cooperation,” and “friendship” to objectives such as “development,” “peace,” “realization of respective dreams,” and a “just international political order.” Within the international context, Xi’s primary concern remains China’s development, its impact on the development of other countries, and the pursuit of legitimacy by rejecting the notion that China’s rise is detrimental to the existing order.

B.2 Map Structure

Beyond the substantive meaning of individual concepts, their position within Xi Jinping’s cognitive network is also analytically significant. This section explains the data derived from the structural properties of the map. Xi Jinping’s cognitive map consists of 326 concepts connected by 453 directed links. While these concepts span a wide range of governance-related issues, the relationships among them constitute an important form of data in their own right.

Each link in the map represents a specific belief held by Xi. The majority of these links (over 86 percent) are positive in valence (390 out of 453 links carry a “+” sign), while only about 12 percent are negative (54 links).¹ These negative links are nevertheless analytically important, as they typically indicate perceived threats or the costs and trade-offs associated with particular actions. Negative effects generally represent outcomes that Xi seeks to minimize or overcome.

Another key structural indicator calculated at the network level is the distribution of node degrees. This network metric captures the structural prominence of each concept. For every node, both in-degree (the number of incoming links) and out-degree (the number

¹The map contains only nine neutral links.

of outgoing links) are calculated. In cognitive mapping, in-degree reflects the extent to which Xi perceives a given concept as being influenced by multiple factors, whereas out-degree indicates how many other concepts that node influences. Together, these measures provide an indicator of the node's causal centrality in Xi's cognitive framework, which is visually represented in the map by the relative size of the node.

In Axelrod's analytical approach, particular attention is paid to source nodes and sink nodes, that is, nodes with zero in-degree or zero out-degree. Source nodes typically represent policy levers or background assumptions that the decision-maker treats as starting points, while sink nodes usually correspond to desired end states or ultimate evaluative criteria.

The examination of the data in this study shows that Xi's cognitive map contains 150 source nodes and 79 terminal nodes. This asymmetry helps clarify a hierarchy of "means and ends" in Xi's thinking. In other words, Xi considers a large number of factors as starting points or independent inputs in his mental model. Many of these are external or contextual conditions. For example, "the central government's policy/spirit," "geographical advantage," "geographical proximity," "historical basis," and "historical interactions," as well as policy levers that Xi can initiate, such as the "western development strategy," "poverty alleviation," "institutional innovation," "win-win cooperation," and "mutual support."

On the other side, there are 79 terminal nodes. What is noteworthy about these nodes is that most of them appear to represent Xi's ultimate goals or evaluative benchmarks. For example, "the survival or downfall of the party," "social stability," "smooth progress of socialist undertakings," "moderately prosperous society," "modernization," and "problem-solving." These are outcomes that Xi regards as the end points of his chains of reasoning; that is, within the map, these concepts are not used to generate further effects but are themselves treated as goals. In Xi's case, despite the large size of the map, a substantial portion of it ultimately converges on a few core priorities such as "development," stability, and party legitimacy. This structural simplification makes the cognitive map, from Axelrod's perspective, easier to solve (Axelrod, 1976, p. 12); in other words, it becomes possible to focus on a limited number of key terminal nodes and assess how multiple initiatives move toward these goals or obstruct them (Axelrod, 1976, p. 112).

By counting the number of links connected to each node, we can identify the concepts that exhibit the highest centrality within Xi's belief network. In terms of indegree (goals or evaluative criteria), the most prominent concept is "development" (with 31 incoming links), followed by "development potential" (23 incoming links) and "economic development" (18 incoming links). By contrast, when considering outdegree (means or influenc-

ing elements), the leading node is “cooperation” (13 outgoing links), followed by “social security” (10 outgoing links) and “reform and opening up” (9 outgoing links).

As noted earlier, in Axelrod’s analytical approach, attention is paid to source and terminal nodes—namely, nodes whose indegree or outdegree is zero. However, a qualitative examination of the data shows that such nodes are not necessarily the best representations of goals and means. For example, Figure B.1 illustrates all twelve source nodes connected to the node “development potential,” each of which has zero indegree. Eleven of these nodes are connected to nothing in the map other than “development potential,” and “weak investment” is connected to only one additional node, which itself, in turn, is not connected to any other node.

Among the 150 source nodes identified in this study, many display similar peripheral characteristics and do not play a significant role in Xi Jinping’s overall cognitive system. This finding underscores the limitations of a purely quantitative approach to interpreting cognitive maps. For this reason, the importance of nodes and their structural positions in this study is assessed qualitatively. Nevertheless, analyzing these data solely in tabular form within Excel makes it nearly impossible to grasp their structural relationships. Visual analysis is considerably more effective than purely numerical analysis. Accordingly, visualization of the cognitive map constitutes a crucial stage in cognitive map analysis, and the visual configuration of the data is itself treated as a form of empirical data.

B.3 Visualization of the Cognitive Map

The map produced by the software in its default setting lacks a readable layout and does not clearly display the cognitive structure. For example, in the raw map (Figure B.2), nodes are represented with darker colors and larger sizes based on their degree. The color and thickness of the links are likewise determined by their weights. In this raw map, important nodes such as “development,” “cooperation,” “reform and opening up,” “economic development,” and “development potential” can be identified through their greater prominence and larger size; however, it is difficult to gain an effective understanding of the nature of the relationships among the components of the map. Following Axelrod’s recommendation, placing “source” nodes on the left and “destination” nodes on the right aligns the image with the reader’s visual expectations and represents the causal logic more clearly. Accordingly, a key part of the work at this stage involves the controlled repositioning of nodes and the adjustment of the map’s visual layout (Van Esch & Snellens, 2024, p. 436).

This repositioning must be carried out in light of the preliminary conclusions reached by the researcher during the coding stage. Although moving nodes does not alter the substantive content of the data, it has a significant effect on the viewer’s visual and cognitive

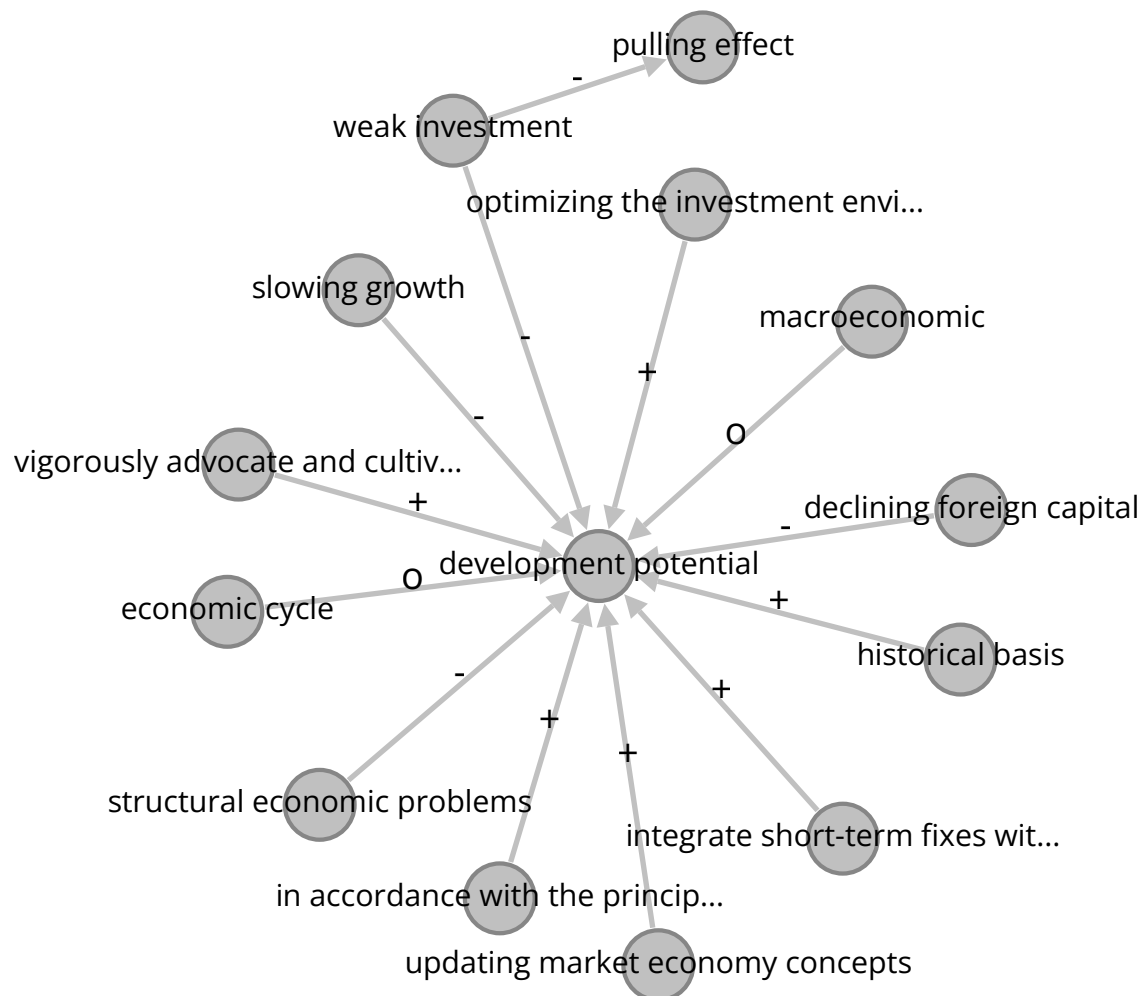


Figure B.1: Source nodes connected to the node “development potential”

Note. Figure created by the author based on the analysis of the research data.

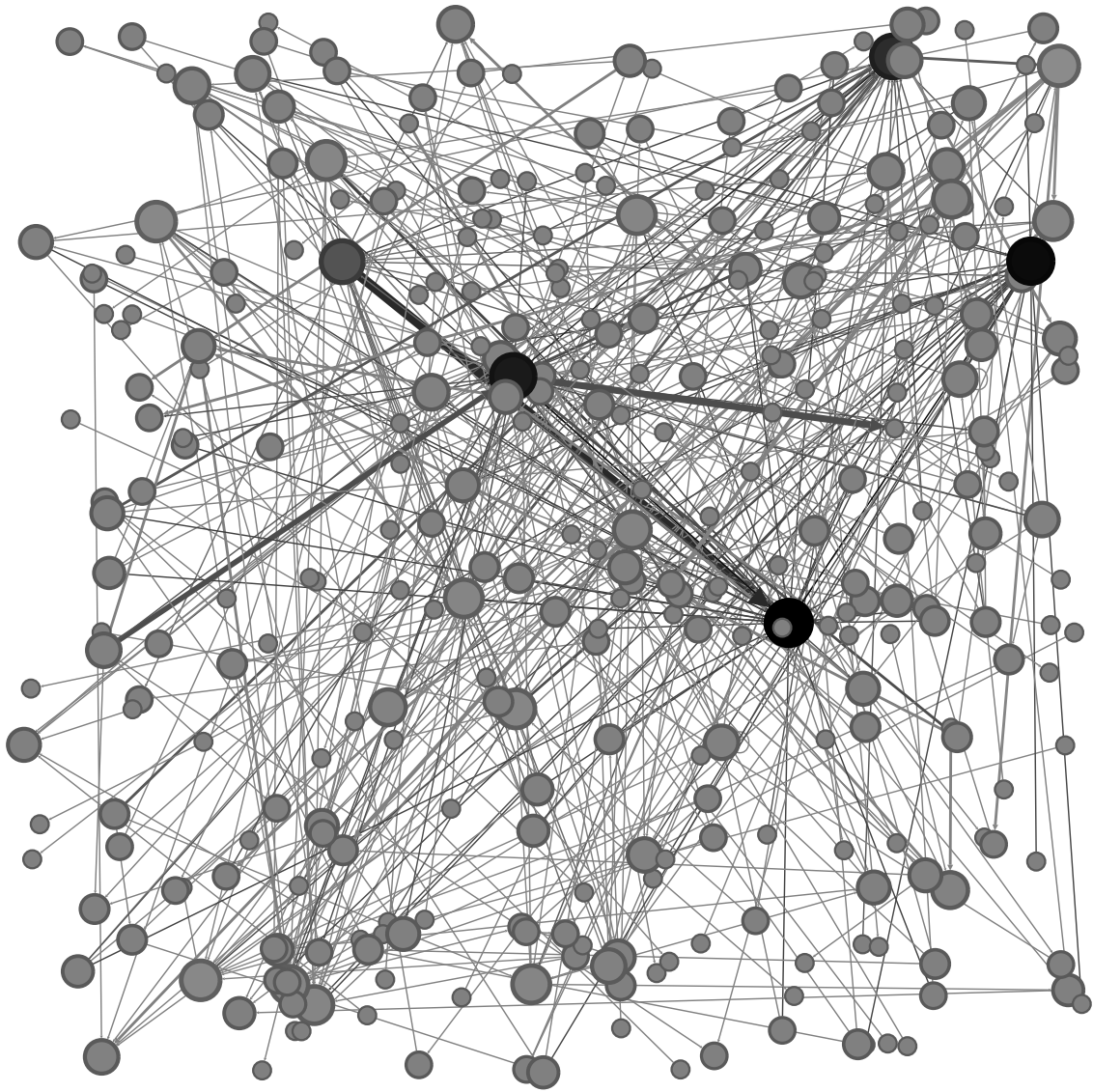


Figure B.2: Xi Jinping's cognitive map without layout adjustments

Note. Figure created by the author based on the analysis of the research data.

understanding. A crucial step in this process involves determining which nodes and links should be displayed in the map. The complete map (Figure B.8), is too complex to provide effective insight into Xi Jinping's perceptions. For this reason, the data analysis section presents smaller maps that are extracted from the main map according to the specific analysis being conducted. The step-by-step presentation of these reduced maps contributes to introducing Xi's cognitive map. In the reduced maps, when link weight and node degree are not analytically important, node sizes and link thicknesses are equalized to emphasize network structure and the spatial arrangement of nodes.

An examination of the map after the initial layout revealed that some nodes formed disconnected clusters (Figure B.3). These small clusters consisted of links among two or three nodes that had no connection to the main cluster of concepts. Such links were removed due to their lack of connection with the core structure of the network, as they did not contribute to understanding Xi Jinping's cognitive pattern and merely created scattered lines within the map.

Identifying these disconnected clusters is difficult without a visual rendering of the map. Although the number of nodes can be calculated in an Excel table, determining whether a relationship is disconnected from the main body of the network—without observing the spatial pattern of links in the map—is a labor-intensive process and prone to error. For this reason, the visual rendering of the map at this stage played a crucial role in refining the conceptual network. The links that were removed are shown in Table B.1.

The final stage of data preparation involves identifying the “strongly connected components” of the map. A strongly connected component is a set of nodes in which each node is reachable from every other node through directed paths, and vice versa. In other words, these components represent regions of the graph in which causal movement among concepts is possible in a reciprocal manner. Identifying these components reveals the most important clusters of the cognitive map, as the interconnectedness of nodes reaches its maximum within them. This is particularly true for the present cognitive map, since all major nodes and heavily weighted links in the map are part of its strongly connected components (Figure B.4). The strongly connected components were identified using the R programming language and the *igraph* package.

After cleaning the data and transforming raw inputs into secondary indicators such as link weights, node degrees, and visual representations, these data are analyzed and used to address the research questions.

Before beginning the analysis, some data that did not contribute to the purposes of this study were removed. This was due to the structure of Xi Jinping's cognitive map, which in some analytical dimensions lacked sufficient complexity to be informative.

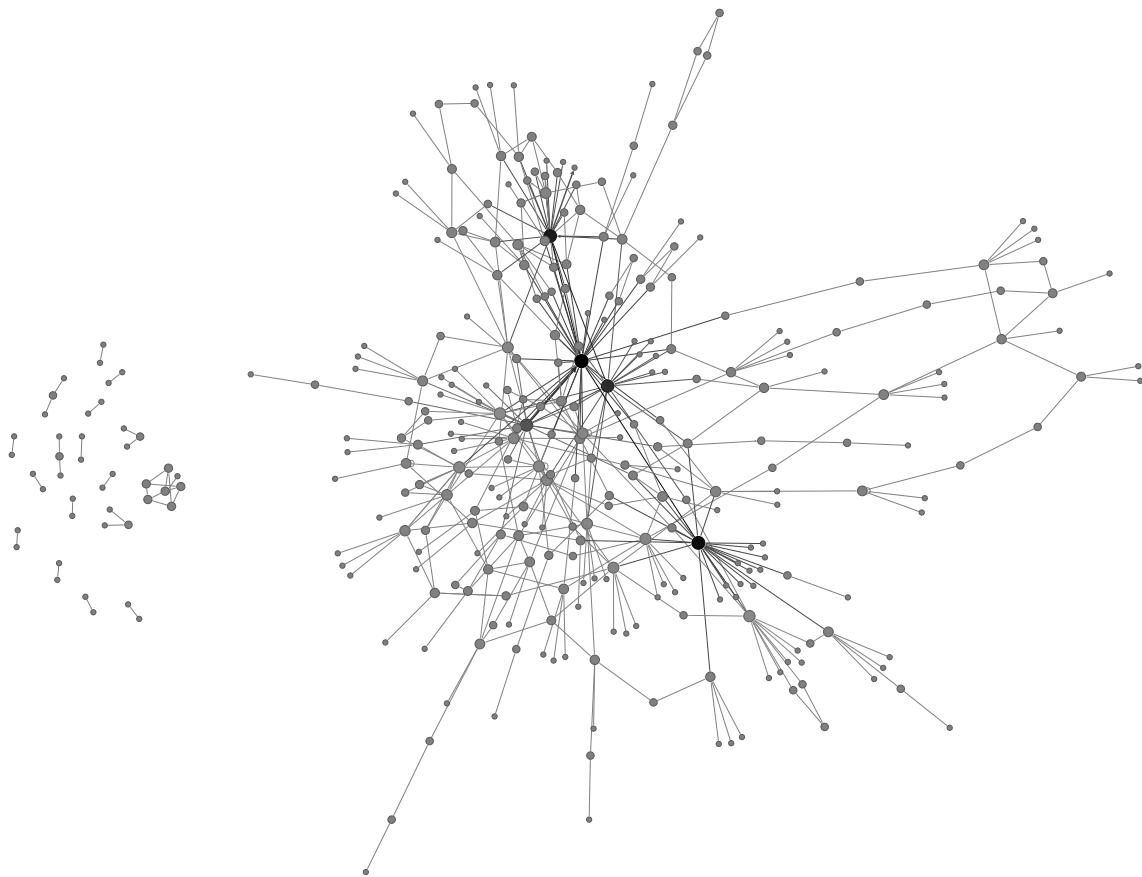


Figure B.3: Map arranged using the Yifan Hu layout algorithm, with disconnected clusters on the left

Note. Figure created by the author based on the analysis of the research data. Gephi provides algorithms for the automatic layout of nodes in a network, among which ForceAtlas2 and Yifan Hu are two of the most well-known. These algorithms are typically used for the analysis of large-scale datasets with a high number of nodes and edges and are therefore not relevant to the present study.

Table B.1: Links removed from disconnected clusters

Source Node	Valence	Target Node
Excessive scope and lack of focus	—	Dispersed resources and low efficiency
Experiencing failure and regression	+	Developing self-pity
Developing self-pity	+	Some individuals withdrew from politics
Lack of success despite active pursuit	+	Disappointment
Public eagerness for rapid change through new leadership	+	Disappointment
High inventory, low growth	—	Stable acceleration and growth
Industrial convergence and intense competition	—	Industrial restructuring
Seeking truth from facts	0	Adjustment of development strategy and focus on foundational work
Limited financial resources	+	Undesirable aspects
Adherence to a realistic and fact-based approach	—	Risky behavior detached from fundamentals
Merit-based promotion	+	Reflects comprehensive approval from superiors and the masses
Selection based on short-term achievements or superficial performance	+	Neglect of deep and long-term qualities and intentions
Interaction of subjective and objective factors	+	Bias and inconsistency in outcomes
Factors are variable and not fixed	+	Not numerically calculable
Northern Shaanxi experiences	+	Understanding reality and gaining self-confidence
Promotion as a merely superficial phenomenon	0	Not inherently equivalent to career success

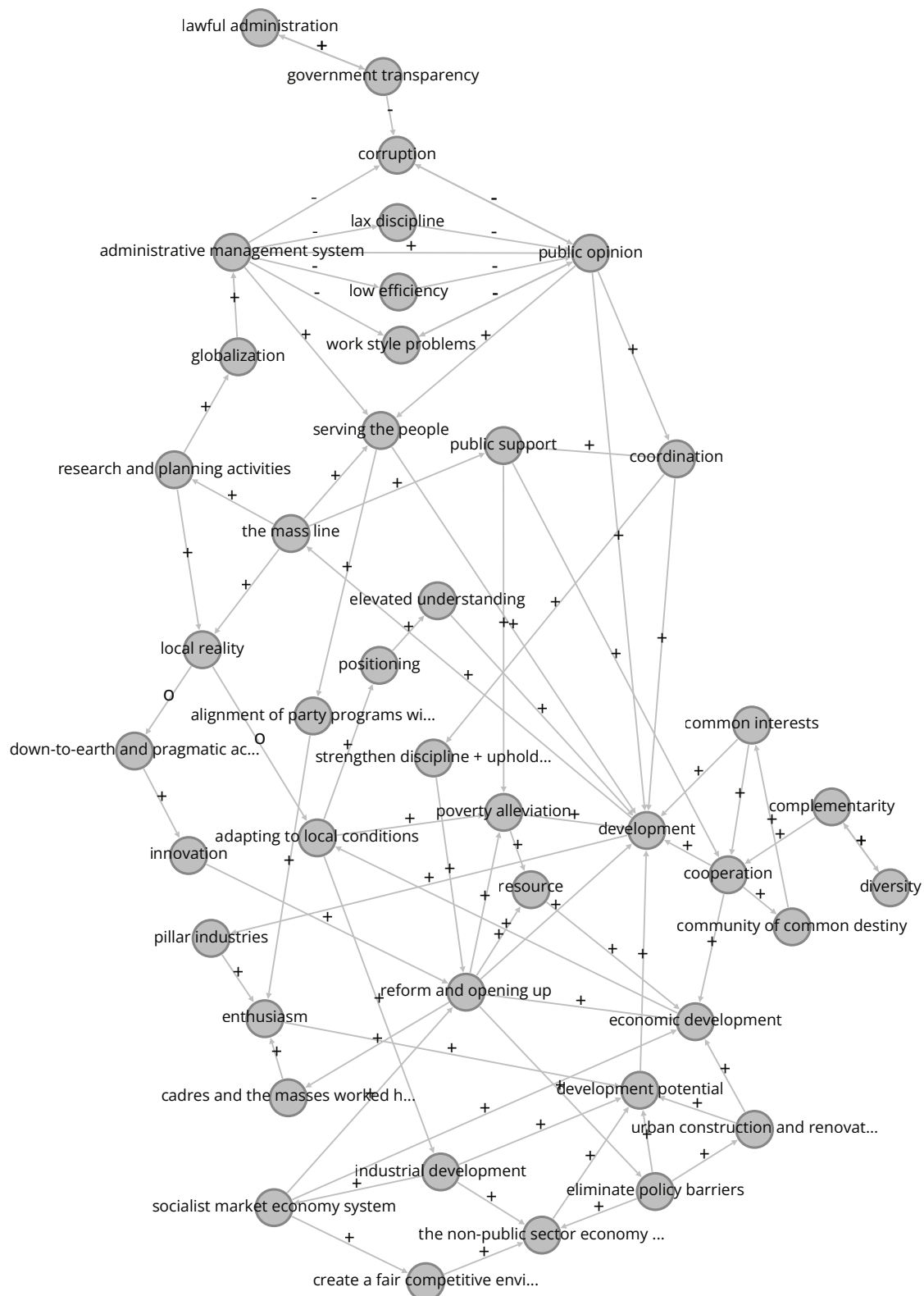


Figure B.4: Strongly connected component of Xi Jinping's cognitive map

Note. Figure created by the author based on the analysis of the research data.

B.4 Data Analysis

At the analysis stage, data from Xi's cognitive map are used to address the research questions. The analysis of the cognitive map consists of three dimensions. In the first dimension, paths within the map are traced in order to understand Xi's chains of reasoning; that is, how certain causes lead step by step to particular outcomes. Any sequence of nodes connected by directed links (for example, "encouragement and guidance" (+) ← "going out" (+) ← "development") represents a logical argument in Xi's mindset. By examining these paths, and by distinguishing between antecedent paths that enter a node and subsequent paths that exit from it, Xi's perceptions regarding how outcomes and processes are realized can be reconstructed.

In the second dimension, network indicators that reflect the structural salience of concepts are examined. For each node, its indegree (the number of arrows entering it) and outdegree (the number of arrows exiting it) are calculated, and for links, both link weight (the number of times the relationship appears in the texts) and link valence (whether the effect of the cause on the outcome is positive or negative) are assessed (Van Esch & Snelens, 2024, pp. 435–436). The final dimension concerns the identification of feedback cycles within the map, which are regarded as indicators of complex reasoning.

Xi Jinping's cognitive map does not display a high level of complexity in the second and third dimensions. In general, Xi tends to rely on positive links. In the limited cases where negative links appear in his statements, they usually concern concepts that carry a negative normative connotation. For example, there is a negative relationship between the "administrative management system" and "corruption," or a negative relationship between "low efficiency" and "public opinion." Even in these cases, no distinct cycle or extended chain is typically formed. Figure B.5 presents all negative links in the map.

As shown in Figure B.5, the negative links form only two notable clusters (Figure B.6). The upper cluster in Figure B.6 is an acyclic graph. All links flow from left to right, and the primary target node is clearly "development potential." In other words, this cluster represents a set of factors that, in Xi's perceptions, exert a negative and weakening effect on "development potential."

The lower cluster is also an acyclic graph without feedback loops. Although the influencing concepts on the left are, in some cases, connected to the affected concepts on the right through multiple paths, there is no return flow in the graph. A close examination of this graph shows that, along the sequence of negative links, the nodes alternate between negatively valenced concepts. For example, "excessive planned economy" weakens the "administrative management system." The "administrative management system," in turn, reduces "corruption." As a result, "excessive planned economy," by weakening the "ad-

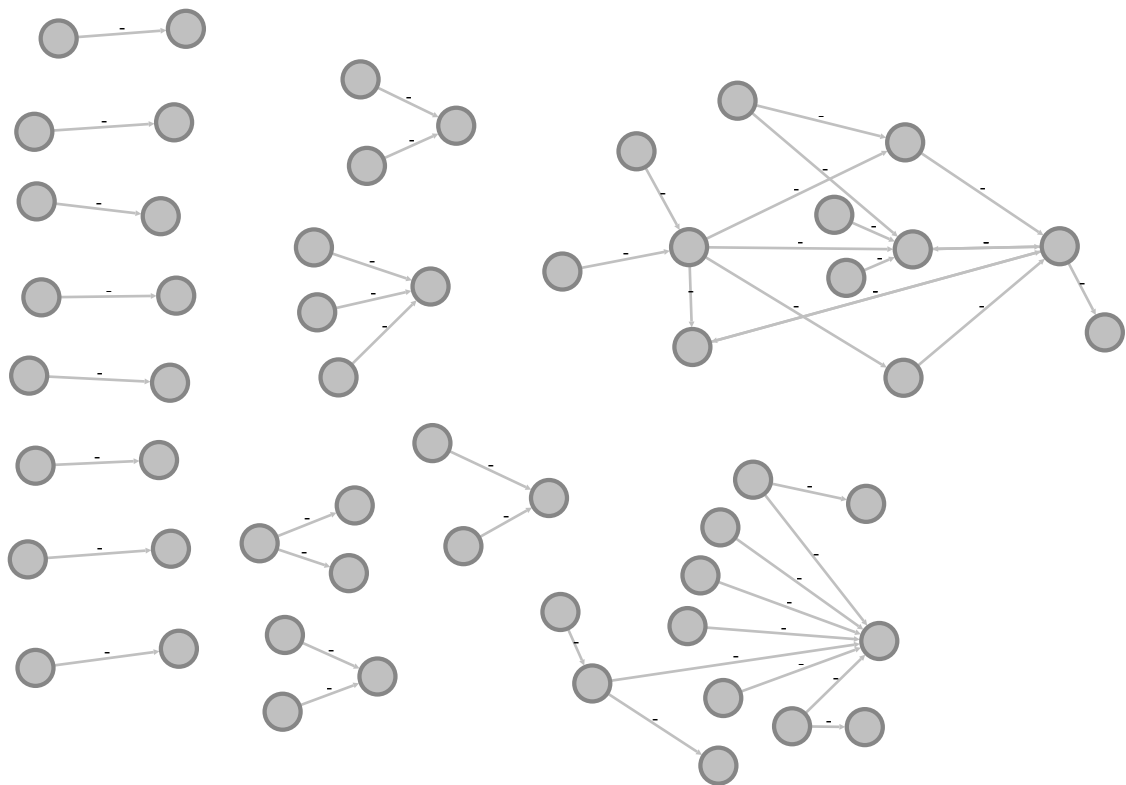


Figure B.5: All negative links in the cognitive map

Note. Figure created by the author based on the analysis of the research data.

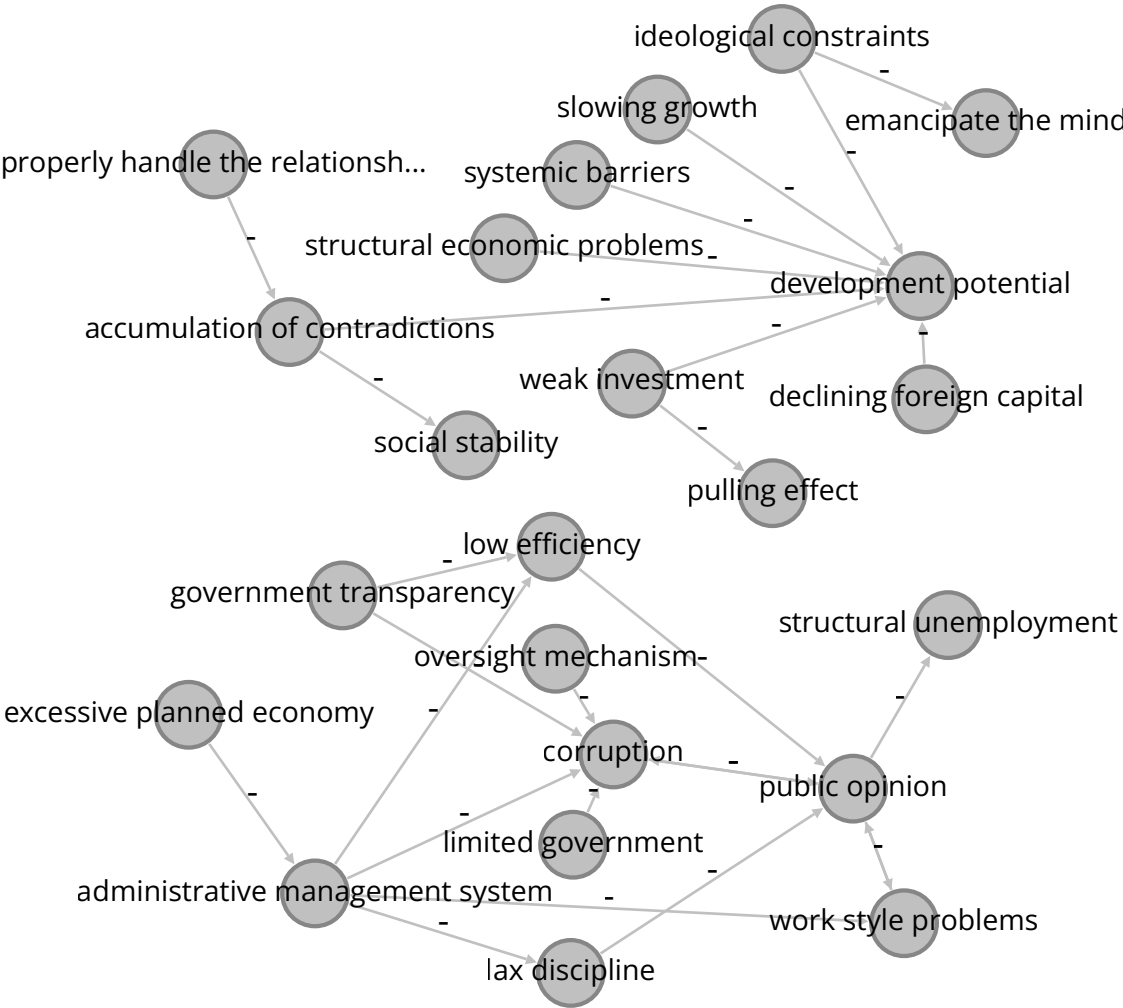


Figure B.6: Clusters formed by negative links

Note. Figure created by the author based on the analysis of the research data.

ministrative management system,” leads to an increase in “corruption.” Since “corruption” itself has a negative effect on “public opinion,” “excessive planned economy,” through increasing “corruption,” ultimately exerts a negative impact on “public opinion.” If the third node (or the fifth, or the seventh, and so on) were a positively valued concept, these links would constitute an inhibiting chain.

The notable absence of negative links and the complete lack of balancing feedback loops² may indicate a linear and reinforcing pattern of causal thinking that lacks critical or constraining approaches. This structure can implicitly suggest an amplifying interpretation of causality, in which policy actions are consistently expected to lead to desirable outcomes, without accounting for resistance, counter-reactions, or internal systemic constraints. It should be noted, however, that as Axelrod explains, this phenomenon is common in cognitive maps: decision-makers rarely argue both sides of an issue and typically articulate reasoning only in defense of one side of a policy question (Axelrod, 1976, p. 231).

Another important point is the large number of nodes with low degree and low-weight links. More than 48 percent of the nodes have a degree of one, meaning that they are connected to only one other node (Figure B.7). This reduces the analytical significance of node degree as a structural indicator. In terms of link weight, only three links are noteworthy: the link “reform and opening up” (+)← “development” with a weight of seven; the link “cooperation” (+)← “peace and regional order” with a weight of five; and the link “consultation” (+)← “cooperation” with a weight of four.

Given these structural characteristics of Xi Jinping’s cognitive map, the analysis primarily focuses on the first dimension, namely tracing paths within the map. By following relationships among relevant nodes, the analysis seeks to answer the sub-research questions and reconstruct the logic underlying Xi Jinping’s cognitive framework.

In analyzing the map, two different approaches will be adopted. The first involves tracing the relationship of a single node with the nodes of interest. For example, we track how the node “Stronger China” is connected to the node “Peace.” We examine which links enter or exit these nodes jointly, or which intermediate nodes connect the two nodes. This approach is sufficient for examining the relationship between two important nodes; however, to investigate connections among several different nodes, network analysis software is required. For this purpose, the R programming language and the iGraph library were used. After identifying the nodes of interest, R scripts were employed to extract the cluster that creates the highest degree of interconnectedness among these nodes. This cluster was then tested against qualitative analyses derived from the study and analysis of speeches and was used in the form of smaller maps in Chapter Four. At this stage, nodes that do not

²Feedback loops containing an odd number of negative links.

have a significant semantic connection to the topic under discussion were removed from these smaller maps.

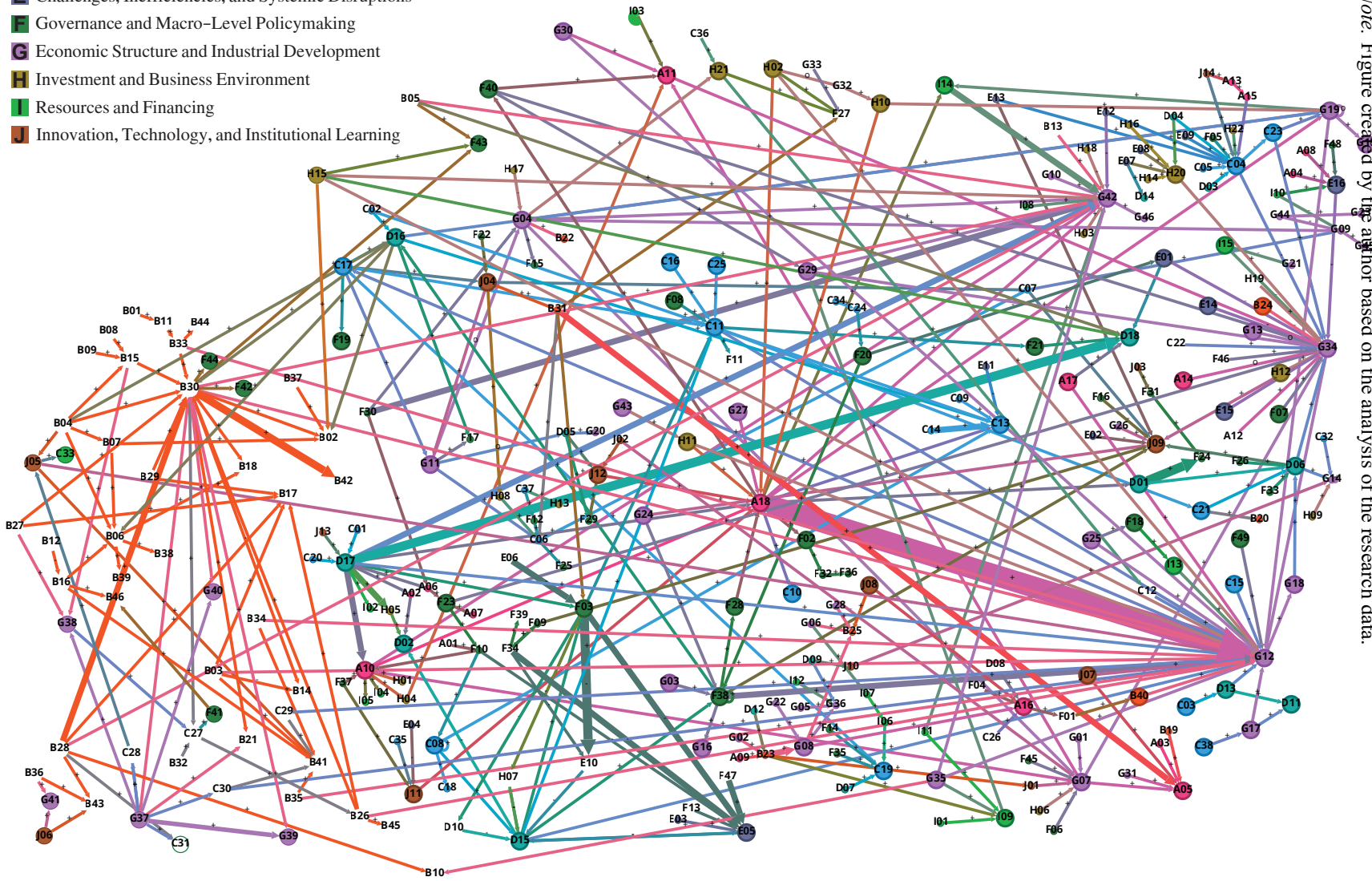
To review and validate the analyses conducted, these clusters can be placed back into the full cognitive map, and other previously overlooked links can be examined.

Figure B.8 shows Xi Jinping’s cognitive map on a large scale. The complete set of concepts and causal relationships identified through the coding process is accessible in this map, enabling the evaluation of the accuracy of the analyses presented in Chapter Four.

To aid in data management, the nodes have been divided into different categories. All nodes were grouped into ten broad clusters (Table B.2), and an English letter was assigned to each cluster. Consequently, each node on the map is represented by a code consisting of a letter and a number. For example, the node “Development” belongs to the category “Economic Structure and Industrial Development,” and its code on the final map is G12. The map also uses color coding for the nodes corresponding to each category, and the color of the links is generated by blending the colors of the source and target nodes to facilitate following them amid the map’s complexity.

Table B.3, by showing the correspondence between concepts and codes, serves as a key for interpreting the nodes displayed on the cognitive map.

- A** Institutional Reform and Structural Transformation
- B** International Order, Cooperation, and Development
- C** Ideology, Values, and Political Culture
- D** Society, Human Capital, and Social Dynamics
- E** Challenges, Inefficiencies, and Systemic Disruptions
- F** Governance and Macro-Level Policymaking
- G** Economic Structure and Industrial Development
- H** Investment and Business Environment
- I** Resources and Financing
- J** Innovation, Technology, and Institutional Learning



Note. Figure created by the author based on the analysis of the research data.

Figure B.8. Large-size cognitive map of Xi Jinping's perceptions.

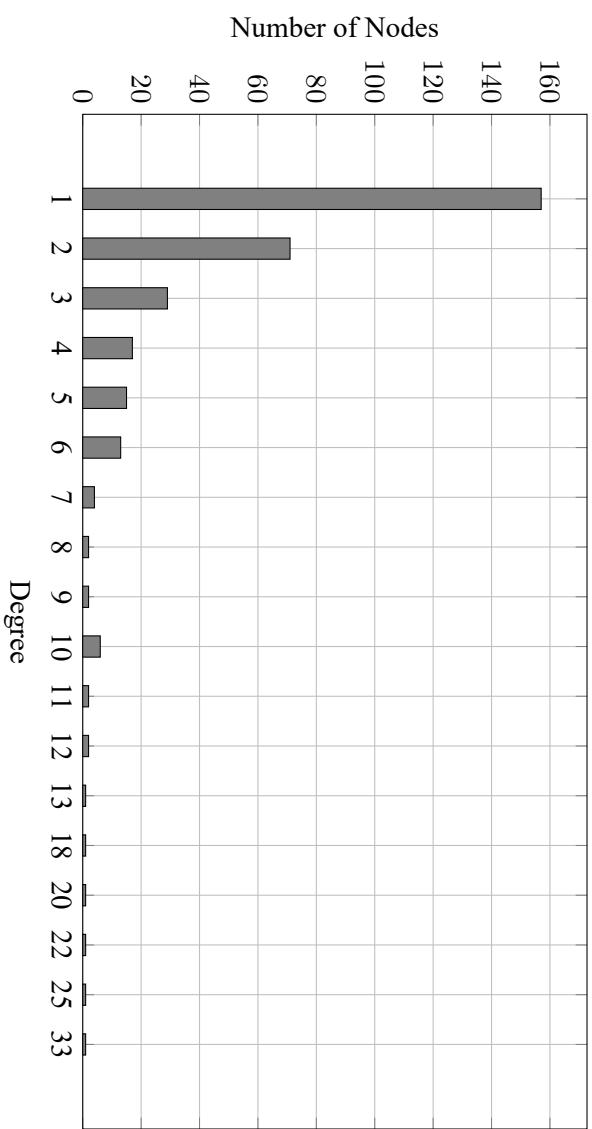


Figure B.7: Frequency distribution of nodes by degree

Note. Figure created by the author based on the analysis of the research data.

Table B.2: Node Categories and Map Codes

Code	Category
A	Institutional Reform and Structural Transformation
B	International Order, Cooperation, and Development
C	Ideology, Values, and Political Culture
D	Society, Human Capital, and Social Dynamics
E	Challenges, Inefficiencies, and Systemic Disruptions
F	Governance and Macro-Level Policymaking
G	Economic Structure and Industrial Development
H	Investment and Business Environment
I	Resources and Financing
J	Innovation, Technology, and Institutional Learning

Table B.3: Concept–Code correspondence table

Concept	Code
combating corruption	A01
economic restructuring of the province	A02
national economic restructuring	A03
slow pace of investment and financing system reform	A04
structural adjustment	A05
the province will carry out institutional reforms	A06
transforming government functions	A07
unresolved deep-seated problems in state-owned enterprise reform	A08
“one-building” system	A09
socialist market economy system	A10
the non-public sector economy grows stronger	A11
updating market economy concepts	A12
weak market economy concept	A13
economic cycle	A14
insufficient ability to utilize market mechanisms	A15
market adaptability	A16
practical system	A17
reform and opening up	A18
starting with work in individual areas	B01
realization of respective dreams	B02
trust	B03
people-to-people diplomacy	B04
the people’s unity	B05
friendship	B06
mutual understanding	B07
amity between people	B08
increased interactions	B09
travel in the region	B10
linking them up over time	B11
isolation from the world	B12
combating security threats	B13
security threats	B14
political relations	B15
a stronger china	B16

Concept	Code
bilateral ties	B17
foreign policy priority	B18
international competition	B19
win-win outcome	B20
jointly seizing opportunities	B21
adhering to a global political, economic, scientific, and cultural perspective	B22
foreign investment	B23
declining foreign capital	B24
export-oriented economy	B25
common interests	B26
geographical proximity	B27
consultation	B28
historical interactions	B29
cooperation	B30
globalization	B31
making joint efforts	B32
the silk road economic belt	B33
solidarity	B34
win-win cooperation	B35
welcome a constructive role by non-regional countries	B36
mutual support	B37
just international economic order	B38
just international political order	B39
going out	B40
peace	B41
peace	B42
regional stability	B43
economic ties	B44
potential of growth	B45
world's development	B46
“big pot” egalitarian system	C01
ideological and political work	C02
a political career is risky and lacks strong autonomy	C03
ideological constraints	C04
insufficient overall perspective	C05

Concept	Code
integrated whole	C06
national macro perspective	C07
party conduct and integrity	C08
patriotism, socialism, and collectivism	C09
perspectives have changed	C10
serving the people	C11
elevated understanding	C12
smooth progress of socialist undertakings	C13
spiritual civilization	C14
sticking to the old ways	C15
the essence of socialist leadership	C16
the mass line	C17
the survival or downfall of the party	C18
three historic tasks	C19
three represents	C20
alignment of party programs with public aspirations	C21
vigorously advocate and cultivate the "five spirits"	C22
emancipate the mind	C23
all work must be subordinate to the overall situation	C24
broad democracy	C25
competitive awareness	C26
community of common destiny	C27
diversity	C28
equality	C29
inclusiveness	C30
harmony	C31
entering politics	C32
human civilization	C33
establish a holistic perspective	C34
firm belief	C35
framework thinking	C36
grasping the overall situation and focusing on major issues	C37
having battles to fight	C38
cadres and the masses worked hard	D01
structural unemployment	D02
cadres lack morale	D03

Concept	Code
weak talent environment	D04
down-to-earth and pragmatic action	D05
enthusiasm	D06
hard work / decisive action	D07
incentive mechanism	D08
labor migration	D09
lax discipline	D10
one's pursuit can possibly be realized	D11
overseas chinese	D12
perseverance and persistence	D13
promotion loses validity as measure of real merit	D14
public opinion	D15
public support	D16
social security	D17
social stability	D18
accumulation of contradictions	E01
the "matthew effect" in openness (open areas become more open; closed areas fall further behind)	E02
wanting both to enter politics and to get rich	E03
wavering with the times	E04
corruption	E05
excessive planned economy	E06
flaws in criteria and procedures	E07
imperfect social credit system	E08
insufficient service awareness	E09
low efficiency	E10
money worship, hedonism, and extreme individualism	E11
rigid management style	E12
short-term behavior	E13
slowing growth	E14
structural economic problems	E15
systemic barriers	E16
encouragement and guidance	F01
individual leader	F02
administrative management system	F03
institutional flexibility	F04

Concept	Code
insufficient application of the "two benefits" principle	F05
integrate development and industrial zones	F06
integrate short-term fixes with long-term structural solutions	F07
integrating power with responsibility and service	F08
lawful administration	F09
limited government	F10
managing society	F11
focused priorities	F12
oversight mechanism	F13
party committees and government	F14
based on the overall national economic situation	F15
placing the focus or reliance on external forces (putting the emphasis on outsiders)	F16
policy	F17
priority industries to accelerate development	F18
problem-solving	F19
properly handle the relationships between the overall situation and the details, the individual and the collective, and the present and the future	F20
public security	F21
reducing adjustment to pillar-industry selection	F22
government system reform	F23
relationships to be handled	F24
building overall problem-solving advantage	F25
stabilizes expectations and sustains reform momentum	F26
strategic decision-making	F27
strengthen discipline + uphold the authority of the central government	F28
strengthening one's leadership capability	F29
the central government's policy/spirit	F30
the new tasks and requirements presented to young leading cadres	F31
the wisdom of everyone	F32
three-to-household	F33
government transparency	F34
willingness of party and government to invest	F35
collective leadership system	F36
combining the central government's directives with local realities	F37
coordination	F38

Concept	Code
democratic oversight	F39
eliminate policy barriers	F40
china utility	F41
national revitalization	F42
national strength	F43
prosperous nation	F44
implement brand strategy	F45
in accordance with the principle of "three advantages"	F46
inadequate oversight mechanism	F47
inadequate transformation of government functions	F48
increased support + preferential policies	F49
accelerate agricultural restructuring	G01
geographical advantage	G02
grasping both hands, and both must be strong	G03
adapting to local conditions	G04
household-based specialization and diversified operations	G05
industrial base	G06
industrial development	G07
industrial structure	G08
infrastructure construction	G09
investment zone	G10
local reality	G11
development	G12
macroeconomic	G13
become rich	G14
moderately prosperous society	G15
modernization	G16
opportunities	G17
pillar industries	G18
poverty alleviation	G19
promoting substantial progress and sustainable results	G20
pulling effect	G21
regional economic competition	G22
development cannot be achieved overnight	G23
seeking quality and quantity	G24
competitive advantage	G25

Concept	Code
soft environment	G26
the quality and completeness of the soft and hard environments	G27
trade methods	G28
urban construction and renovation	G29
western development strategy	G30
comprehensive economic strength	G31
comprehensive environmental competition	G32
configuration of productive forces	G33
development potential	G34
connectivity	G35
cultivating new growth points	G36
complementarity	G37
sustained growth	G38
common development	G39
common prosperity	G40
development of the region	G41
economic development	G42
economic environment	G43
economic foundation was weak	G44
enhanced agglomeration and radiation functions	G45
formation of central cities	G46
changes in the external environment	H01
situation / context	H02
solve problems for enterprises	H03
create a fair competitive environment	H04
state-owned enterprise reform	H05
support sme development	H06
work style problems	H07
differentiated measures and goals	H08
emerging enterprises	H09
enhance comprehensive environmental advantages	H10
favorable timing, advantageous location, and harmonious relationships	H11
historical basis	H12
formulating long-term strategic plans	H13
heavy extra-tax burden on enterprises	H14
hard work	H15

Concept	Code
inadequate legal environment	H16
macro environment restrictive	H17
natural and geographical constraints	H18
optimizing the investment environment, talent environment, and business development environment	H19
poor investment environment	H20
positioning	H21
power complex in cadre	H22
absorbing social idle capital	I01
addressing employees' concerns	I02
broaden financing channels	I03
changes in resource allocation mechanisms	I04
diversification of investment entities	I05
financial input	I06
financial strength (fiscal capacity)	I07
financial, tax, fiscal support	I08
funds	I09
imperfect fiscal system	I10
land-based financing	I11
optimization of mountain–sea resource allocation	I12
reduce imports	I13
resource	I14
weak investment	I15
advance high-tech industrialization	J01
low technological level	J02
questionnaire survey	J03
research and planning activities	J04
mutual learning	J05
draw upon the experience of other regions in development	J06
technological development	J07
technological innovation	J08
utility	J09
brought back wealth-creation information and know-how	J10
creativity	J11
innovation	J12
institutional innovation	J13

Concept	Code
insufficient innovation	J14

Appendix C

Mathematical Dimension of Cognitive Mapping Theory

This appendix provides a detailed explanation of the mathematical dimension of cognitive mapping theory in simplified terms. The purpose of this appendix is to offer a clearer understanding of how these concepts operate when expressed in mathematical language. Today, with the advancement of computational software, there is no longer a need to calculate these matrices manually. Nevertheless, understanding the logic of these calculations helps the researcher develop a deeper comprehension of the data and results and enables more accurate interpretation.

In this appendix, a sample cognitive map representing a simple feedback loop is used as an illustrative example. This cognitive map shows that infrastructure has a positive effect on economic growth, and that economic growth leads to political stability. Political stability, in turn, reduces corruption. At the same time, corruption negatively affects infrastructure. In other words, the direct causal relationships between the concepts can be expressed as follows:

“Improvement of infrastructure” (+) → “Economic growth” (+) → “Political stability” (−) → “Corruption”, and “Corruption” (−) → “Infrastructure”.

To calculate indirect causal relationships between concepts (for example, the relationship between infrastructure and political stability), these relationships must be expressed mathematically in the form of matrices. A matrix is a rectangular arrangement of numbers or mathematical expressions organized in rows and columns. The elements located at the intersection of rows and columns are called entries.

The first step is to construct the matrix of direct relationships. In this example, there are four concepts; therefore, to represent all possible direct causal relationships among them, we require a 4×4 adjacency matrix. In this matrix, concepts acting as causes are placed in rows, concepts acting as effects are placed in columns, and the causal relationship between

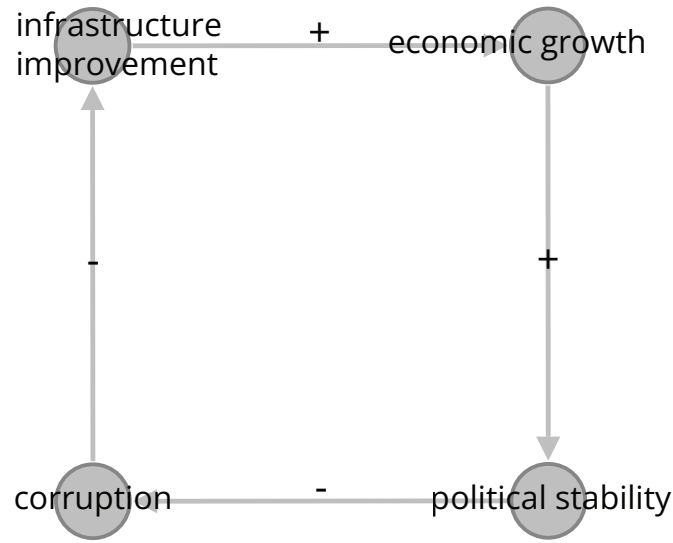


Figure C.1: An example of a feedback loop (reproduced from Figure 2.1).

each cause and effect is represented by the entry at the intersection of the corresponding row and column.

Positive causal relationships are represented by 1, neutral relationships by 0, and negative causal relationships by -1 . Accordingly, the adjacency matrix for the sample cognitive map is as follows:

	Infrastructure	Economic Growth	Political Stability	Corruption
Infrastructure	0	1	0	0
Economic Growth	0	0	1	0
Political Stability	0	0	0	-1
Corruption	-1	0	0	0

Zero entries in the table indicate the absence of a direct relationship between the two concepts. For example, there is no direct relationship between infrastructure and political stability. At the same time, corruption has causal relationships with two other concepts. The negative value in the row of political stability and the column of corruption indicates that political stability (cause) reduces corruption (effect). Conversely, the negative value in the row of corruption and the column of infrastructure indicates that corruption (cause) negatively affects infrastructure (effect).

The matrix above can be represented mathematically as matrix A . For instance, the value 1 in the first row and second column of matrix A indicates a positive causal relationship between infrastructure and economic growth. In mathematical notation, each entry is denoted as a_{ij} , where i represents the row and j represents the column.

Matrix A captures only the relationships among concepts. Computational software requires an additional table to specify which concept corresponds to each row and column index. Accordingly, each concept is assigned a numerical identifier.

Table C.2: Node IDs and Labels

ID	Concept
1	Infrastructure
2	Economic Growth
3	Political Stability
4	Corruption

Thus, the first row and column of matrix A correspond to infrastructure, the second to economic growth, and so forth.

To identify second-order causal relationships, matrix A is multiplied by itself:

$$A^2 = A \times A$$

Through this operation, indirect causal relationships of degree two replace direct relationships in the resulting matrix, denoted as A^2 . Matrix multiplication is performed by multiplying the rows of the first matrix by the columns of the second matrix and summing the products.

More formally, each entry of A^2 is computed as:

$$(A^2)_{ij} = \sum_{k=1}^n a_{ik}a_{kj}$$

This formula indicates that, for each entry (i, j) , all intermediate paths through index k are multiplied and summed. Because cognitive map matrices are always square and multiplied by themselves, if the number of nodes is $n = 4$, then i, j , and k all range from 1 to 4.

In the sample matrix, the only non-zero entry in the first row of A is in the second column, $a_{12} = 1$. Therefore, we examine the non-zero entries of the second row. The only non-zero entry in the second row is $a_{23} = 1$. The product of these two values contributes to entry $(1, 3)$ in A^2 , indicating a positive second-order causal relationship between infrastructure and political stability:

$$(A^2)_{13} = a_{12} \times a_{23} = 1$$

This result shows that infrastructure indirectly and positively affects political stability through economic growth.

Clearly, performing such calculations manually for cognitive maps with hundreds of nodes would be extremely demanding. Fortunately, modern software performs these computations automatically. The final result of this multiplication is matrix A^2 , which represents all second-order causal relationships.

As observed, entry (1, 3) in A^2 indicates a positive relationship between infrastructure and political stability. However, entry (1, 2), which represented a direct relationship between infrastructure and economic growth in matrix A , is now zero in A^2 . This indicates that there is no second-order relationship between these two concepts.

Similarly, to identify third-order relationships, matrix A is multiplied by itself three times, and to identify fourth-order relationships, it is multiplied four times. The maximum possible degree of causal relationships is equal to the number of nodes minus one, since a concept cannot have a causal relationship with itself.

By summing these matrices, we obtain the total influence matrix T , which represents all causal relationships among all concepts in the cognitive map:

$$T = \sum_{k=1}^{n-1} A^k$$

This expression can be written compactly as:

$$T = A + A^2 + \dots + A^{n-1}$$

Matrix addition is performed by summing corresponding entries. The entries of matrix T may be zero, greater than 1, or less than -1 . The absolute value of an entry represents the weight of the relationship, indicating that multiple paths connect the two nodes. This may reflect a complex influence, a strong causal relationship, or simply repeated pathways. If the strength of the relationship is not analytically important, it is sufficient to consider only whether the relationship is positive or negative.

In conclusion, the mathematical framework of cognitive mapping theory provides a systematic method for quantifying and analyzing both direct and indirect causal relationships among concepts. By representing these relationships as matrices and calculating higher-order interactions, researchers can capture the full network of influences within a system, revealing feedback loops and pathways that may not be immediately apparent. While computational tools automate these calculations, understanding the underlying matrix operations allows for a deeper interpretation of the results and a clearer insight into the structure and dynamics of complex systems. Ultimately, this approach transforms qualitative insights into a rigorous, quantitative representation, enabling more precise and informed analysis of interrelated concepts.

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